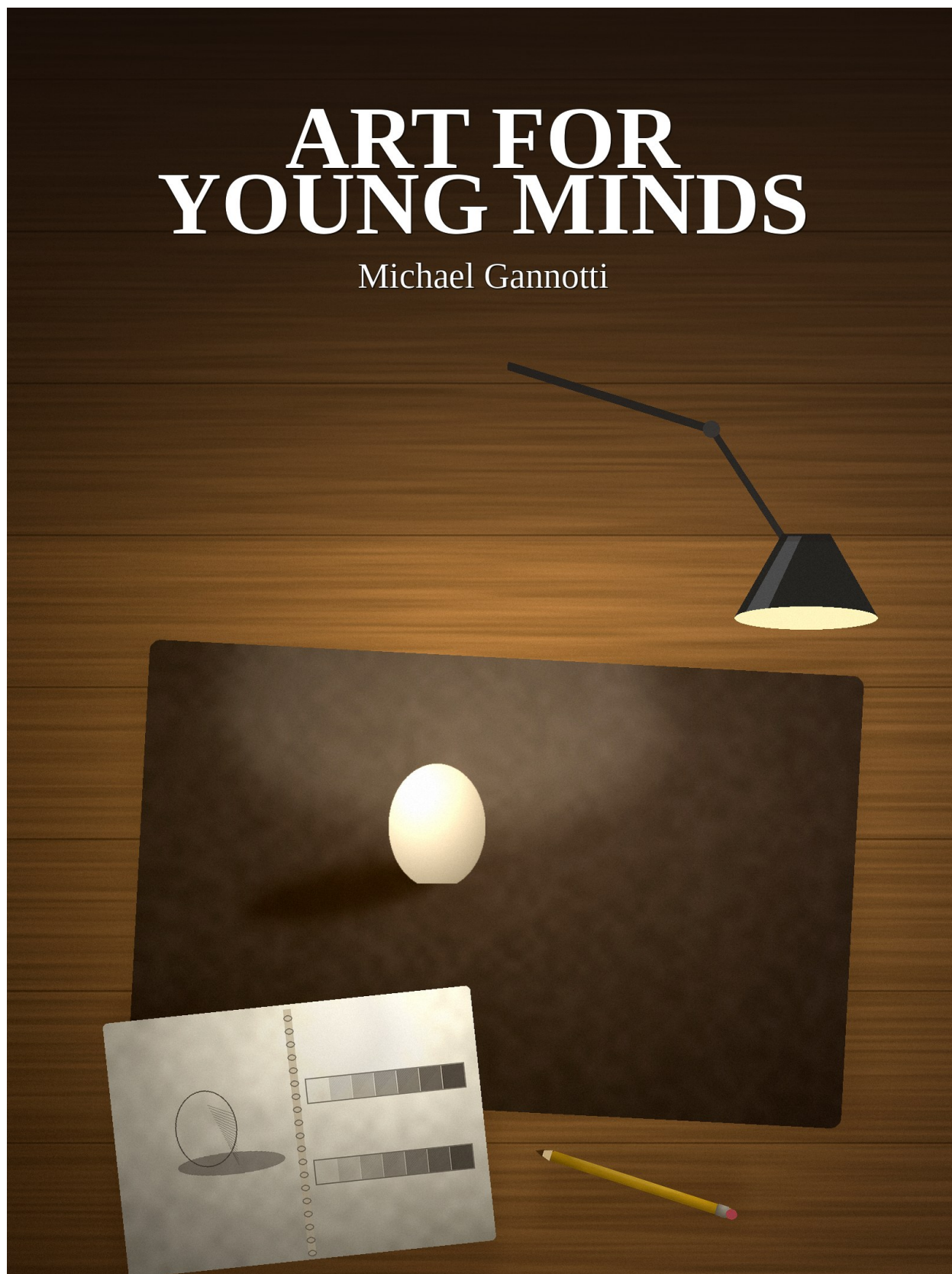


ART FOR YOUNG MINDS

Michael Gannotti



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A homeschool teaching manual for ages 11–14. Illustrated teaching-manual edition, 27 September 2026. Notes run in one series at the back. Chapter-opening images are original still-lives, not portraits of people or children.

Contents

- Welcome
- How to use this book this week
- If you only remember five things
- The Art Hour
- Chapter 1 — What art looks like at 11–14
- Chapter 2 — The sketchbook and observational drawing
- Chapter 3 — Value, light, and form
- Chapter 4 — Space and perspective
- Chapter 5 — Color and design
- Chapter 6 — Cut, print, and build: tools with rules
- Chapter 7 — Looking at real works and the language of critique
- Chapter 8 — Portfolio and progress checks
- Chapter 9 — Records and next steps
- Chapter 10 — Resources
- A Note on Sources
- Notes

Welcome

You do not need to be an artist to teach an eleven- to fourteen-year-old to draw what they see.

You need an object on the table, one good question, and the patience to wait for the answer.

That is what this book is for.

A Tuesday, for example

It is a little after ten in the morning. A desk lamp is clamped to the kitchen table and pointed at a single egg sitting on a dark dish towel. A twelve-year-old has a sketchbook open to a fresh page and has already written the date in the corner. Her arm is straight out, pencil upright, one eye closed. She is measuring how tall the egg is against how wide.

Her father sits across the table with his own cheap sketchbook. He is not drawing well. He is not trying to. He asks one question — “What do you actually see, before either of us decides if it’s good?” — and then he does the hardest thing in this book. He waits.

After a long moment she says the shadow is darker right up against the egg than it is farther out. That is true. He hadn’t noticed. Neither had she, until she looked.

Twenty minutes later there is a smudgy, honest egg on the page, a one-line note underneath it (“shadow darkest where it touches”), and a pencil back in the jar. That was an Art Hour: about forty minutes, five short beats, a dated page at the end.

(That Tuesday is a composite, drawn from common situations. It is not a real family. You will meet a few more like it in this book, always labelled.)

The student you actually have

Eleven to fourteen is a wonderful and slightly prickly age for art.

Your student can work longer than they could at nine. They can hold a project across several days. They want their drawings to look *real*, and they notice — instantly — when a drawing doesn’t. Many of them are harder on their own page than anyone else will ever be. They are more alert to being watched and judged than they were a few years ago. And their hands are ready for tools that

were off the table at eight: a charcoal stick, a lino gouge, and, at thirteen or fourteen if your family chooses, a craft knife used under a clear protocol.

This is also the age when a great many people decide they “can’t draw.” If you decided that about yourself at about this age, you are in very large company. You are also about to get a second chance, sitting beside your student.

Here is the good news, plainly. Most drawing trouble is seeing trouble. Careful research with adults found that the biggest source of drawing mistakes was misjudging what the object actually looked like — not an unsteady hand.¹ That was an adult study, so treat it as a useful map rather than a promise. But it points straight at something you can teach: seeing, with simple tools for measuring and checking.

The focus of the whole book

See before you judge. Sketch before you polish.

See before you judge means look, measure, and describe before anyone decides whether something is good — your student’s drawing, a painting in a museum, a sibling’s print, your own ugly page. Judgment still comes. It comes last, and it comes with reasons.

Sketch before you polish means thumbnails, quick studies, and honest first pages are the real work, not a warm-up before the real work. The good paper comes out after the sketch has made the decisions.

If you used *Art for Little Thinkers* with a younger child, you will recognize this. *Look before name; make before polish* has grown up.

What you actually do

You do not have to demonstrate like a trained artist. Your jobs are ones you can do well starting this week:

- Set up the object and the lamp.
- Protect the quiet minute of looking.
- Ask one good question — each chapter gives you the exact words — and then wait.
- Keep your hands off the student’s page. If you demonstrate, do it on a separate sheet.
- Teach the tool rules first, and count the tools back in at the end.
- Date things and keep them. That is most of assessment and nearly all of record-keeping.

Your student does the seeing, sketching, making, and talking. That division of labor is the method, not a shortcut around it.

Two readers at once

Most of this book talks to you, the parent or co-teacher. Each teaching chapter also has a section headed **For the student**, written directly to your eleven- to fourteen-year-old. Hand it over. It is short, it does not talk down, and it says a few things — *your sketchbook is yours; other people's opinions come when you ask for them* — that land better coming from the book than from a parent.

Why this matters now

In the 2016 national survey of homeschooling families, about half of homeschooled students in grades 6–8 had art as a subject that year — fewer than in the early grades, more than in high school.² The survey does not say why. It does suggest that middle school is where art often slips quietly off the week. This book is built to keep it on, at a size a busy home can manage: a few Art Hours a week and a ten-minute sketchbook page on the other days.

What this book will not do

It will not hand you a 180-day plan. You will get a this-week shape, a pacing sketch for the year, and the judgment to choose.

It will not sell you a curriculum or rank programs. The resources chapter describes options by fit — your time, your student's style, your budget — and starts with the library and free museum collections.

It will not promise a portfolio by spring, a percentile, or a student who draws like a professional in six weeks.

It will not tell you that art makes students smarter at reading or math. A large review of that question, from Harvard's Project Zero, found no reliable evidence that it does.³ Art is worth teaching for what art teaches: seeing, making, deciding, and talking about images with evidence.

It is not a reprint of *Art for Little Thinkers* (ages 5–10) or *Art for Homeschooling* (grades 1–12). If you have a younger child, the first is their book. If your fourteen-year-old is heading into high-school credit, the second picks up there. This book teaches eleven to fourteen.

It will never treat a generated image as your student's work. AI appears here as an optional helper for *you*, under clear rules, explained once in The Art Hour.

It will not ask you to put a brand on the transcript. The course line is **Art**.

Encouragement that is specific

This week, you can learn to ask one question and wait through the silence after it.

Today, your student can draw one object for ten minutes and write the date on the page.

That is enough to begin.

— Michael Gannotti

How to use this book this week

Read *The Art Hour* once. It takes about twenty minutes, and it holds the session shape, the talk-box shape, the safety rules, and the AI rules that every later chapter points back to. Then read the parent sections of Chapter 1. Then start.

That is the whole on-ramp. You do not need to read the book cover to cover before the first Art Hour, and you do not need to buy anything first. A pencil, a sketchbook, a lamp, and an egg will carry the first two weeks.

This week's shape

1. **Pick one focus.** In the first week, that is Chapter 1: the ugly page, the blind contour, the silent look, and one baseline drawing you will keep.
2. **Run two to four Art Hours** of thirty to fifty minutes, using the five beats in *The Art Hour*.
3. **Ten-minute sketchbook page on the other days.** One object, ten minutes, date in the corner.
4. **One out-of-home try-it** this week or next — a sketchbook outing, a library art-book hunt, a museum room.
5. **Friday: a short review.** The student tabs three pages in the week's sketchbook (best, most learned, try again). You run one short check from the chapter and look at the “done enough” list.

Here is what that looks like in a real week. Treat it as a sample, not an assignment.

Day	What happens
Monday	Art Hour: ugly page on purpose, then blind contour of a hand
Tuesday	Ten-minute page
Wednesday	Art Hour: five-minute silent look at a real work, then the monthly baseline drawing
Thursday	Ten-minute page; library art-book hunt if the week allows
Friday	Sketchbook review, one check, done-enough list
Weekend	Pocket sketchbook outing, if it fits

Most chapters take three to six weeks. Some take longer, and that is fine. The tools chapter in particular goes at the speed of the rules.

Placement: skill, not birthday

Inside every teaching chapter you will see two planning bands: **11–12** and **13–14**.

The 11–12 moves assume more modeling from you, shorter sits, sentence starters for talk, soft carving blocks before linoleum, and scissors rather than knives. The 13–14 moves assume longer independent work, multi-session projects, two-point perspective, full value range, fuller critique, and writing about art in the student's own words.

Use the bands as a guide, not a lock. A thirteen-year-old who has never drawn from life starts with the 11–12 moves, and there is nothing lost by it. A confident eleven-year-old may take a 13–14 move early. You will see the label **ready 12** on moves that some twelve-year-olds are ready for — traditional linoleum with a bench hook and an adult beside them, for instance, or drawing a box in two-point perspective.

A “grade 7 art” book is a publisher's scope. It is not a legal level, and your student is not behind or ahead of it.

Coming from *Art for Little Thinkers*, or from nothing? Both start in the same place: Chapter 1, with a dated baseline drawing. The baseline tells you where to begin far better than a birthday does.

How a teaching chapter is built

Every teaching chapter uses the same eight headings in the same order, so you always know where to look.

- **Why this matters** — one page on what this unlocks.
- **For the parent: understand it yourself** — the idea in plain words, an everyday picture and a precise one, the “wrong answers” you should learn to hear, and a five-minute warm-up for you alone.
- **How to teach it this week** — the first try-it, exact wording you can use, how to fade your help, when to stop talking, and the band moves.
- **Practice that actually builds learning** — named try-its in the home and outside it, the chapter's talk box, and one incorrect example to diagnose together.
- **For the student** — a page or two written directly to your student.
- **If it isn't clicking** — three common snags and the next move for each.
- **Tools, including AI** — short, and pointing back to The Art Hour.
- **What “done enough” looks like** — a checklist before you move on.

In order, or by need

The chapters build on each other, and the order is the one we recommend: seeing and the sketchbook first, then value, then space, then color and design, then cutting and building, then looking and critique, then the portfolio.

You can bend it. If drawing confidence is very low, spend longer in Chapters 1 and 2 before value. Looking at real works (Chapter 7) can thread through the whole year — many families spend a few minutes with one painting every week from the start. The progress checks in Chapter 8 begin in the very first month, even though the chapter sits near the end. And the tools chapter always starts with the rules, no matter when you reach it.

A year with this book (a sketch, not a schedule)

Month	Focus	Running alongside
1	Chapter 1 and the Art Hour rhythm; baseline drawing	Ten-minute pages
2	Chapter 2: sketchbook and observational drawing	Monthly unaided drawing
3	Chapter 3: value, light, and form	A museum or library outing
4	Chapter 4: space and perspective	An architecture walk
5	Chapter 5: color and design	A poster for a real family event
6–7	Chapter 6: cut, print, and build (slower is fine)	Tool count every session
8	Chapter 7: looking and critique (or threaded all year)	A timeline of works studied
9	Chapter 8: portfolio; Chapter 9: records	A portfolio conversation

A second year revisits the same chapters at the other band. That repetition is the design. The thirteen-year-old's two-point box is the eleven-year-old's one-point hallway, grown.

The banks are a menu

The try-its in this book come from ninety-four named activities, grouped in banks with short codes: SKB for sketchbook, OBS for observation, VAL for value, SPC for space, COL for color, DES for design, PRT for printmaking, BLD for building, LOOK for looking, HIST for art history, CRIT for critique, WRITE for writing, OUT for outings, SAFE for safety, AS for assessment, PORT for portfolio. A code like SKB-03 simply lets a later chapter point back to “Ugly Page on Purpose” without repeating it.

A chapter picks one or two try-its a week from its banks. Nobody does all ninety-four in a year, and nobody should try.

Two ages at one table

Many families will run this book beside *Art for Little Thinkers*. Share the See beat: the same egg, the same silent minute. The younger child names what they notice; the older one measures. Split the Make beat: the eight-year-old paints the egg's colors while the thirteen-year-old does the value study.

One talk box can serve both, with different follow-up questions. The older student can practice asking neutral questions about the younger child's work — a real responsibility, and a quiet protection for the younger child against verdicts.

Tools stay banded. When a gouge or a knife is on the table, the younger child works at a different table.

Students who need a different door

This book gives practical moves, not diagnoses. For anything more, talk with your student's own professionals.

- **Fine-motor difficulty or fatigue:** thicker pencils, bigger paper clipped down, shorter Make beats, soft carving block rather than lino, charcoal sticks rather than fine hatching.
- **Color-vision differences:** label the paints, lean on value (Chapter 3), and never test color-naming as a skill.
- **Attention:** keep the five beats short and predictable, use a timer, choose outings that move.
- **Anxiety about being judged:** a private sketchbook, describe-only rules, and the right to decline other people's opinions.
- **Advanced students:** longer observational pieces, a longer master study, a community class. Advanced is not a reason to skip the seeing.

If you feel you can't draw either

Good. You are the right person for this job.

A parent who draws beautifully is sometimes tempted to fix the page. A parent who feels rusty is more likely to ask a question and wait — which is exactly what this book asks of you. Your five-minute warm-ups are private, and nobody grades them. Many parents find that their own ten-minute page, done at the same table on the same object, becomes the most persuasive lesson in the house. An honest ugly page from a grown-up tells a twelve-year-old more about sketching before polishing than any speech could.

When your student's skill outgrows what you can demonstrate — and it may, sooner than you expect — take that as good news. It means the seeing worked. Chapter 10 has ideas for community classes

and teen programs, and you stay on as the person who sets up the object, keeps the rhythm, and keeps the records.

Records without drama

Date every page. Keep every sketchbook, even the ones your student dislikes. Do the monthly unaided drawing and keep those pages together. Keep a short log — date, minutes, what you did, one line. On any transcript or report, the course line is **Art**. Chapter 9 covers the rest.

What to skip for now

Skip the shopping trip until you have run a few Art Hours with what is already in the house. Skip any AI tool until you have read the box in The Art Hour. Skip any chapter you are not ready to teach this month. The map is a path, not a race.

If you only remember five things

Keep this page where you plan the week. When an Art Hour feels scattered, come back here before you add anything new.

1. See before you judge

Look, measure, describe — then decide. That order works on a mug, a master’s painting, and your student’s own page. When your student says “it’s bad,” the next move is not reassurance. It is a question about what they see: *Where is the lightest part? How tall is it compared to how wide?* Judgment is welcome. It just comes fourth, not first.

2. Sketch before you polish

Thumbnails, ugly pages, and quick studies are the work. They are where decisions get made cheaply, before anything is precious. Keep the wrong line and draw the right one next to it. The good paper comes out after the sketch.

3. The sketchbook is theirs

At this age, being watched and judged weighs more than it used to.⁴ So the sketchbook is private by default. You check that pages happen; you read the pages your student offers. Nothing gets shown to anyone — grandparents, co-op, the internet — without your student’s agreement. Opinions about their work come when they ask for them.

4. Tools come with rules

Rules are taught first and demonstrated back by the student before the tool is used. A bench hook under every gouge. Cut away from the body and away from the holding hand. Soft block before lino at 11–12. Craft knives only at 13–14, only if your family chooses, only with an adult at the table and the full protocol — and scissors always work instead. ACMI AP-sealed materials for grade 6 and below. No solvents, no indoor sprays, no home kilns. Count the tools in and out.

5. Their mark, their art

The student's eye and hand are the lesson. A generated image is not their drawing, and a model-written statement is not their words. A traced photo or a master copy is fine when it is labelled honestly. Write down how every portfolio piece was made. Record the year's work simply and truthfully under **Art**.

Those five are the book in miniature. The full safety rules, the talk-box shape, and the AI rules live once in The Art Hour.

The Art Hour



Thirty to fifty minutes. Five beats. A dated page at the end. Stop while your student still wants one more line.

This is the session spine for the whole book. Later chapters say “run the Art Hour” and point here, so you only have to learn the shape once. The talk-box shape, the try-it shapes, the safety rules, and the AI rules also live here, once.

Before you sit down (five minutes, alone)

Put tomorrow's object on the table and turn on the lamp. Look at it yourself for one minute — just look. Then say the chapter's opening question out loud once, so it sounds like your voice and not a script.

Check that the materials are actually out, not still in a cupboard. If anything new is coming out — a paint, an ink, a block — read the label now. If a tool with an edge is coming out, set out the bench hook, the tray, and the count sheet.

Put your phone face down. You are rehearsing a question and a wait, not a lecture.

Setting up the corner

You do not need a studio. You need a table that can stay a little messy for an hour, a light you can aim, and a shelf or box where the art things live.

For the first month, that box holds: a sketchbook for the student (and a cheap one for you); a few graphite pencils in a range from hard to soft (something like 2H, HB, 2B, 4B, 6B); a kneaded eraser; a fine black pen; sticky tabs for Friday reviews; a folder for the monthly unaided drawings; a damp cloth; and a clamp lamp or desk lamp you can point at an object. Add a small tray now, even before any sharp tools arrive, so that “tools live in the tray and get counted” is already a habit when the gouges come.

Everything else arrives chapter by chapter: charcoal in Chapter 3, paints in Chapter 5, blocks and a bench hook in Chapter 6. Read the label on each new material before it comes out. Chapter 10 describes a fuller starter shelf, with free and low-cost options first.

The objects are already in your house. A mug, an egg, a shoe, a chair, a houseplant, a paper bag, a set of keys. Keep a few favorites on the shelf; the same mug drawn in September and again in May is one of the best records you will ever have.

The five beats

1. See (5–8 minutes)

One object, one lamp, one window view, or one real work of art. Silent looking first — a full minute is longer than it sounds. Then measure, squint, or describe. No verdicts yet, from either of you.

What you might say: “Let's both look for a minute before anyone draws.” Then: “What do you actually see?”

If your student starts with “that's easy” or “I can't do that,” bring them back to the object. “Maybe. What do you see first?”

2. Sketch (5–10 minutes)

Thumbnails (small, fast planning sketches, a couple of inches across) or a warm-up: a blind contour, a quick gesture, a strip of values. Ugly is allowed. Ugly is expected. This is where decisions get made while they are still cheap.

What you might say: “Six little ones, fast. None of them count.”

3. Make (15–25 minutes)

The chapter’s named try-it. Your student holds the tool. If you demonstrate, keep it short and do it on a separate sheet — *demo paper* — then move that sheet aside so there is nothing to copy.

When your student gets stuck, use the **rescue order**:

1. **Ask.** “What are you trying to do right there?”
2. **Wait.** A real wait. Look at the object, not at them.
3. **Hint.** “Measure it against the handle.” “Where’s the darkest part?”
4. **Short demo on demo paper.** Ten seconds, one move.
5. **Hand it back.** “Your turn.”

That order keeps the skill and the dignity in the same hour. Grabbing the pencil — even with love — teaches that your hand is the real artist.

4. Talk (5–8 minutes)

The chapter’s talk box. One opening question, a few follow-ups, and waiting. Evidence before verdict. At 13–14, your student may invite your opinion; you ask permission before giving it.

5. File (3–5 minutes)

Date the page if it isn’t dated. Add a one-line process note: what I tried, what changed, or what’s next. If the piece might go in the portfolio, photograph it (see *Photos and privacy* below). Clean up with water. Count the tools back into the tray.

Filing sounds like housekeeping. It is also the habit that turns a year of Tuesdays into a portfolio a stranger can read, and caring for tools and space is part of the craft itself.⁵

One hour, start to finish (an illustration)

Here is a 13–14 hour from Chapter 2, so you can hear the whole shape once. It is a composite, not a real family.

See (6 minutes). A mug sits on the table under the lamp, handle to the right. You both look without talking for a full minute. You ask, “Where does your drawing differ from the object — and how could you measure it?” There is no drawing yet, so your student laughs and says, “Nowhere, I

haven't started." Fair. You ask instead, "How many mug-widths tall is it?" They lock an arm, close one eye, and sight along the pencil. "About one and a third."

Sketch (8 minutes). Four thumbnails, each a couple of inches wide: mug from here, mug from lower, mug cropped close, mug with the lamp moved. One gets a circle. "That one. The handle shadow's better."

Make (22 minutes). Your student draws the circled view at full size, measuring as they go. Around minute ten they groan: the mug looks too fat. You ask, "What are you trying to do there?" They say the width is wrong. You wait. They re-sight, find the drawing is wider than one-to-one-and-a-third, and draw a new edge beside the old one. You did not touch the page.

Talk (6 minutes). "Where does your drawing differ from the object now?" "The ellipse at the top is too round." "What do you see that makes you say that?" "From here it's flatter — like a squashed oval." You say, "I have an opinion about the handle. Would you like to hear it?" "Not today." You leave it. That is allowed.

File (3 minutes). The date is already in the corner. They write underneath: *1 : 1.3. Kept the fat line. Top ellipse flatter next time.* Pencils back in the jar. Forty-five minutes, one honest page, one plan for tomorrow.

The ten-minute page

On days without an Art Hour, your student does one ten-minute page. One object in view — anything in the house or out the window — drawn from life for ten minutes, with the date in the corner. Stop at the timer, even mid-line.

The page is private by default. You check that it exists, not what it looks like, unless your student shows you. At 11–12, you may name the object if the blank page freezes them; they choose the angle. At 13–14, they set their own schedule and choose their own objects.

The ten-minute page is the quiet engine of this book. Ten minutes a day adds up to more drawing than most people do in a year.

Bands inside the hour

11–12. Plan on thirty to forty minutes. You sit nearby and model more. Offer sentence starters for talk ("I see...", "It's darker where..."). One-point perspective before two-point. Soft carving block before lino. Scissors and rotary safety cutters, never craft knives. AP-labelled materials only for students in grade 6 or below. Critique is spoken, with frames.

13–14. Plan on forty to fifty minutes, and let projects run across several sessions. Your student plans more of the week with you and works longer on their own; you check in at the start and the end. Two-point perspective, figure studies of clothed family members who agree, full value range. Lino with a bench hook. A craft knife only if your family chooses it, with an adult at the table and the full protocol. Fuller critique using the Critical Response Process. A written artist statement in the student's own words.

Place by skill, not birthday. Move a student between bands by what they can show you.

The talk-box shape (once for the book)

Every teaching chapter has a talk box. The shape never changes.

The opening question. Each chapter gives you one, word for word. It is a real question with no single right answer, and it always points at the work or the object — never at whether the student is talented. Chapter 1’s opening is: “What do you actually see — before either of us decides if it’s good?”

Three to five follow-ups. One for seeing (“What else do you see near the edge?”). One for measuring or evidence (“How big is that compared to this?” or “What do you see that makes you say that?”). One for process (“What did you try there?”). One that lets them revise (“If you drew it again tomorrow, what would you change first?”).

The evidence question comes from Visual Thinking Strategies, a museum-education method built on three questions: *What’s going on in this picture?* *What do you see that makes you say that?* *What more can you find?* Its guidance for families is to paraphrase what the student says without praising or correcting.⁶ That is good advice for every talk box in this book.

How to wait. After you ask, count a slow three in your head before you say anything. After they answer, wait again — the second wait is where the better answer often shows up. The three-second pause is a classroom convention that grew out of research on teachers’ questioning in school science lessons; we borrow it as craft, not as art research.⁷ If the silence feels long, look at the object, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. Fear of being judged. A question that secretly asked for a verdict (“Do you like it?”). Hunting for the “right” art word. An opinion of yours already hanging in the air. A piece that feels too personal to talk about today. Or simply: still looking. “Not today” is an allowed answer. Try again tomorrow, or describe something yourself, neutrally, to get the talk moving: “I notice the shadow goes all the way to the edge of the towel.”

One “don’t say / say instead” line. Each chapter gives you one. The pattern: trade a verdict for a way of checking. Instead of “That’s wrong,” try “Let’s measure it.”

Opinions, when they come. At 13–14 especially, borrow the last step of Liz Lerman’s Critical Response Process: “I have an opinion about the shadow — would you like to hear it?” The artist may say no, and no is respected.⁸ It feels formal at first. It quickly becomes the most trusted sentence in the house. The broader habit — describe, then analyze, then interpret, and only then judge — is a teaching ladder often credited to the art educator Edmund Feldman, and Chapter 7 teaches it in full.⁹

Try-it shapes (once)

Every named try-it in this book carries the same five fields:

- **Time** — a realistic kitchen-table estimate.
- **Materials** — what needs to be on the table.
- **Mess / safety** — plain and specific, pointing back to the safety rules below.
- **The fun** — why a young person might actually want to do it.
- **The skill** — the seeing or making move being practiced.

In-home try-its use what a house already has: an egg under a lamp, a mug, a chair, a hallway, a cardboard box at the corner of a table, a window, your student's own hand.

Out-of-home try-its carry the same fields plus the venue's rules. The recurring ones:

- **Museums.** Many allow pencils only in the galleries, and some limit sketchbook size or stools. Photography rules vary by gallery. Check the museum's visitor rules before you go.
- **Libraries.** The first studio outside the house: art books, how-to books, interlibrary loan, workshops.
- **Sketching in public.** Face objects and buildings, not strangers. At 11–12, sit together. Move on if anyone seems uncomfortable.
- **Community studios.** Kilns, presses, and wheels belong here, with instructors and the studio's own age and safety rules.
- **Outdoors.** Sun, water, a seat, a clipboard, a buddy — and no trespassing for a better view.

People as subjects

At this age, many students want to draw people. Good. This book's people are: clothed family members who have agreed to pose; the student themselves, in a mirror; the student's own hands; and sculpture — public-domain works in a museum or in free museum image collections. Strangers are not drawn without their agreement, and no photo of another young person gets uploaded anywhere.

The safety rules (once for the book)

Safety in this book is ordinary and non-negotiable. It is said once, here. Later chapters point back.

1. **Labels.** For students in grade 6 or below, use materials carrying the **AP** seal from the Art and Creative Materials Institute (ACMI), and nothing with a cautionary label. The **CL** seal is for grade 7 and up only, with the label read in full with an adult before opening, and only when a project truly needs it — which in this book is rarely.¹⁰ A line saying a product “conforms to ASTM D-4236” means it has been reviewed and labelled for long-term hazards. It is a labelling standard, not a “safe for children” stamp.¹¹
2. **No solvents, at any age, in this book.** No turpentine, paint thinner, mineral spirits, shellac, or solvent-based glues and inks. Everything cleans up with water.
3. **No indoor aerosols.** No spray fixative or spray paint indoors. For a 13–14 charcoal piece that truly needs fixing, an adult sprays it outdoors, following the label — or you skip it and store the piece in a folder.

4. **Dust.** Charcoal and soft pastel make fine dust. Wipe it up with a damp cloth. Never blow it off the page; tap the page over a bin instead. Subtractive charcoal (toning a whole page and erasing out the lights) is a 13–14 technique, done at a ventilated table. Oil pastel is the dust-free alternative. Clean dry clay with a damp cloth, never by sanding indoors.
5. **Sharp tools, every age.** A bench hook — a board that hooks over the table edge and holds the block still — under every gouge. Cut away from the body and away from the holding hand. The holding hand lives *behind* the tool. Keep tools sharp; a dull gouge needs more force and slips more. Store gouges with guards on. Count every tool out at the start and back in at the end.^{11,12,13}
6. **Sharp tools at 11–12.** Scissors and rotary safety cutters for cutting. A soft carving block before linoleum. Gouges only with a bench hook and an adult sitting beside. No craft knives. **Ready 12:** a twelve-year-old whose soft-block cuts are steady, and who can teach you the bench-hook rule without prompting, may move to traditional lino — still with the bench hook, still with you beside them.
7. **Sharp tools at 13–14.** Lino with a bench hook. **Craft knives are optional; it is your family’s call.** If you choose them, the protocol is: an adult at the table; a self-healing cutting mat larger than the cut; a metal safety ruler; the holding hand behind the blade; a cut-resistant glove on the holding hand; a fresh blade; light scoring passes rather than one forced cut; blades counted out and back; the knife closed and stored afterward.^{12,11} Scissors or a rotary safety cutter always work instead, and every knife project in Chapter 6 offers that alternative.
8. **Heat.** Warm stiff lino gently with a hair dryer or a warm (not hot) surface. No open flame. A low-temperature glue gun is a 13–14 tool with an adult present — our practice suggestion, not a published rule. **No home kilns.** Firing happens at a community studio.
9. **The ordinary things.** Food and drinks away from the art table. Wash hands afterward. A first-aid kit on the shelf. Poison Control in the U.S. is 1-800-222-1222.¹¹ After any near-miss — a slip, a gouge heading for a hand — stop the session, reset, and go back to the simpler tool for the rest of the week. That is not a punishment. It is what careful studios do.
10. **Your judgment comes first.** The federal art-safety guide gives no age for craft knives or lino gouges. The bands in this book are our practice rules, not legal ages. You know your student’s hands and attention better than any chart.

Photos and privacy

Photographing finished work is how a portfolio travels, and it is also how a young person’s details leak. Photograph the work, not the student. Crop to the paper. Keep faces, full names, school names, and house details out of the frame, and turn off location tagging where your phone allows. Posting anything publicly is your student’s choice as well as yours. A portfolio can be complete without ever going online.

AI in this book (once)

A helper for you, never the artist.

Your student sees the real object and makes the mark. A generated image is not their drawing. It never goes in the portfolio as their work, and any AI use at all is written on the whose-mark card (Chapter 8).

Who holds the account. At 11–12, you do, and your student sits beside you. Children under thirteen are covered by the federal children’s privacy rule (COPPA), whose updated requirements took full effect in April 2026; in this book, an under-thirteen never has their own account on any chatbot, image generator, or agent.¹⁴ At 13–14, use a parent-linked or shared account only where the service’s terms allow teens. Most consumer services set a minimum of 13 and require a parent’s permission under 18; some are 18 and over only.^{15,16,17,18,19} Turn image generation off and turn the training opt-out on where the settings allow. Stay in the room. Turning thirteen is not a licence.

Good uses — always after your student’s own attempt and own describe-first critique:

1. **A critique partner.** Photograph the finished piece, crop to the paper, no faces. Ask the tool for three neutral questions about it — never a grade, never a “better version.” Read the questions aloud (at 11–12), or let your student read them with you (at 13–14).
2. **Art-history questions.** Then check every date, name, and quote against a museum page or a book. Fluent tools invent references with confidence.²⁰
3. **Reference hunting.** Ask where to find public-domain or open-access works on a theme, or for still-life setups from things in your kitchen. Then go look at the real work or the real objects, and record the credit line.
4. **A “spot the error” image** you have checked yourself — a box with one wrong perspective line, say — used only as something to look at and diagnose.
5. **Explaining an idea to you.** “Explain two-point perspective to me using a cardboard box. List two mistakes a 13-year-old commonly makes.” Useful preparation for the adult.

Not in this book: a tool making the art; a generated image filed as the student’s work or traced for a portfolio piece; a model writing the artist statement or the critique; AI open beside the student during the attempt; an AI companion or agent handed to the student; “in the style of [a living artist]” as a generator task; AI “detectors” used to grade drawings or writing, which are unreliable;²¹ uploading faces, names, or identifying details.

Why the line sits here. The looking and the marking *are* the skill. Two outside bodies happen to draw the same line: the U.S. Copyright Office has said that the mere provision of prompts does not make someone the author of a generated image,²² and the AP Art and Design program prohibits generative AI in final submitted artwork and asks students to disclose any AI use.²³ One caution from far outside art: in a trial with high-school math students, an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left

students worse on the test without it — a different age and a different subject, but the same reason the attempt comes before any tool is opened.²⁴

Uploads are privacy decisions. Some services’ terms give the company a broad licence to whatever you upload; others use uploads to improve their products unless you opt out.^{16,15} Upload only what you would be comfortable sharing widely.

Your own assistant is your tool. If you run a self-hosted agent or a hosted bot, it stays on your side of the table: planning, reference hunting, question lists, logging the week. A shared hosted workspace is not a privacy boundary for a child’s photos.^{25,26}

Platform ages at the time of writing (checked September 2026 — terms change, so check the current page before you sign up):

Service	Minimum age	Teens
ChatGPT (OpenAI)	13	Under 18 needs a parent’s permission; parental controls can remove image generation and opt out of training
Grok (SpaceXAI)	13	13–17 need a parent’s permission; the parent agrees to the terms
Gemini (Google)	13 (to manage your own Google Account in the U.S.)	Under 13 only if a parent turns Gemini on through Family Link
Midjourney	13	A parent agrees to the terms where the teen is under the local age of consent, and is responsible for the teen’s use
Claude (Anthropic)	18	Not for students in this age band

When the hour goes wrong

What you see	What it usually means	First move
“I can’t draw” / crumples the page	Drawing the shape they <i>know</i> ; judging too early; feeling watched	Switch to measuring (Chapter 2); ugly page on purpose; private sketchbook
Endless erasing	Polishing before sketching	Pen-only warm-ups for a week; “keep the wrong line, draw the right one next to it”

What you see	What it usually means	First move
Only copies phone images	Skipping the seeing	Draw from the object first; credit any photo; use photos they took themselves
Flat drawing	No single light source	One lamp, one object; squint (Chapter 3)
“It’s bad” / “it’s good” and nothing else	Verdict first	Describe-only rule for a week; then permissioned opinions
You finished the perspective for them	The rescue reflex	Demo on demo paper; hand the pencil back
Refuses to show any work	Sensitivity to being judged	Private by default; show only chosen pages
A generated image in the folder	Blurry sense of authorship	Whose-mark card; label it; not a portfolio piece
Knife slip or near-miss	A gap in the protocol	Stop; reset the protocol; scissors for the week
Solvent smell or a spray can indoors	Wrong material on the table	Stop; ventilate; check labels against the safety rules

Dose honesty

Two to four Art Hours a week, a ten-minute page on the other days, and an outing every week or two is a full art life at this age. That comes to roughly ninety minutes to two and a half hours a week, plus the pages. Treat it as our practice suggestion; no study tells us the right number of art minutes for a home.

Some states set their own rules. New York, for example, requires art for grades 7 and 8 as one-half unit across the two years, and defines a unit as 6,480 minutes of instruction in a school year.²⁷ That is a New York requirement, not a national dose. If you live in a state with a rule like it, a simple log of dates and minutes will show it. Chapter 9 covers records.

If a day holds only twenty minutes, do See, a short Make, and File. One beat done well beats five rushed.

The rhythm of the habit

Revisit last week’s page before starting a new one. Draw the same object again next month and put the two pages side by side. Keep the sketchbook going over breaks, even at one page a week. Stop while your student still wants one more line.

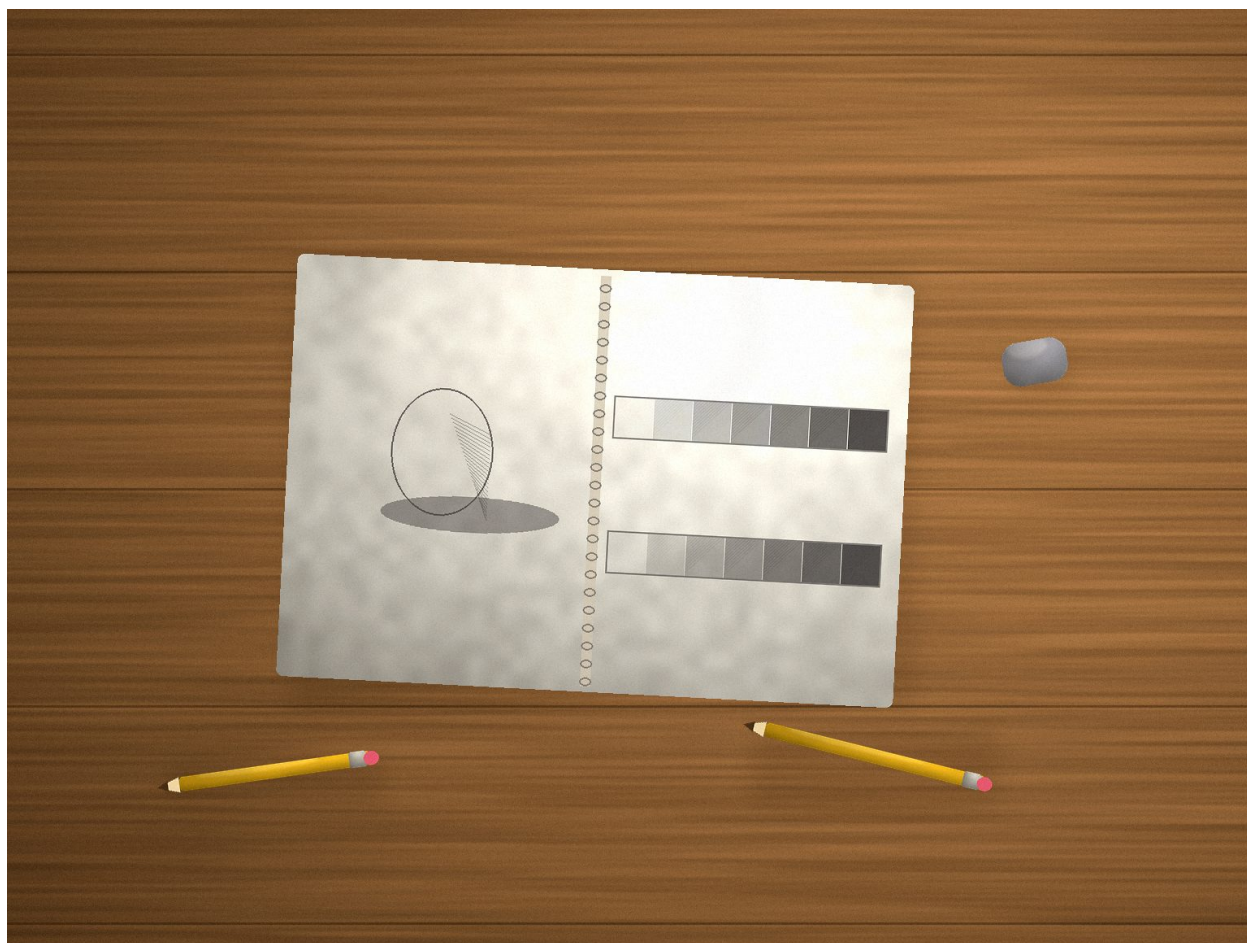
That rhythm lives here, in each chapter’s “done enough” list, and in the records you keep. It does not need its own chapter.

Ready to begin

You have the hour, the ten-minute page, the talk-box shape, the try-it shapes, the safety rules, and the AI box.

Chapter 1 puts *see before you judge* and *sketch before you polish* on the table. Tonight, set out one mug and a lamp. Say the opening question aloud once. Tomorrow, sit down beside your student and ask it.

Chapter 1 — What art looks like at 11–14



Why this matters

Somewhere between eleven and fourteen, most young people start wanting their drawings to look *right*.

Not “nice.” Right. The chair should look like a chair you could sit in. The face should look like the person. The street should go back into the distance the way real streets do. This is a wonderful appetite. It is also the moment when many capable students look at their page, see the gap between

what they wanted and what they got, and quietly decide they “can’t draw.”

That decision is usually wrong, and this chapter is here to keep it from being made.

Here is the student you actually have. They can sustain real work — thirty, forty, fifty minutes, and projects that stretch across several days. They are hungry for realism, and they want the tools that make it possible: measuring, light and shadow, perspective. They are quick to judge their own page, often harshly. They are more sensitive to being watched and evaluated than they were at nine. And they are ready for real tools, with rules.

Every one of those traits is useful. The appetite for realism gives you a reason to teach seeing. The harsh self-judgment tells you exactly where the lesson is. The sensitivity to being watched tells you how to protect the work while it is still growing. The readiness for tools tells you it is time to hand them over, carefully.

This chapter installs the two habits that carry the whole book:

See before you judge. Look, measure, and describe before deciding whether anything is good.

Sketch before you polish. Thumbnails and ugly pages first; the good paper after the decisions are made.

It also sets up the rhythm you will use all year — the Art Hour and the ten-minute page — and gives you a baseline: one dated, unaided drawing that shows where your student is starting. That page will be worth more to you in June than any grade.

Why the struggle is worth it. Learning to see is uncomfortable at first. The blind contour looks ridiculous. The first measured drawing looks stranger than the guessed one. The silent minute feels long. That discomfort is the learning. A student who gets through a month of it has something many adults never got: the knowledge that drawing is a skill you build, not a verdict you receive.

You do not need to be an artist to teach this chapter. You need to set out an object, ask one good question, and wait.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many parents reading this were told, at about this same age, that they couldn’t draw. If that was you, you are in good company, and this chapter is partly for you too. Your job is not to become an art teacher overnight. Your job is to learn one idea well enough to hear when your student has skipped the seeing — and to ask the question that sends them back to it.

The everyday picture: learning to drive

Think about a new driver. On the first day, they look at the road and decide they are terrible. They are not terrible. They are new, and they are watching the wrong things — the steering wheel, their own hands, the car in the next lane — instead of the road ahead.

A good driving teacher does not say “you’re a natural” or “some people just can’t drive.” They say, “Eyes up. Look where you want to go.” Then they take the new driver to an empty parking lot and

let them practice badly, where nothing is at stake, before they ever see a highway.

That is this chapter. *See before you judge* is “eyes up — look at the road before you decide you’re a bad driver.” *Sketch before you polish* is the parking lot. The sketchbook is where your student practices badly, safely, and privately, before anything goes on the good paper.

The precise picture: what goes wrong when people draw

When researchers asked adults to draw what they saw and then looked closely at where the drawings went wrong, the main culprit was not the hand. It was the eye — more exactly, it was misjudging what the object really looked like. Unsteady hands turned out to be a very small part of the problem.¹

That was a study of adults drawing from photographs, not of eleven-year-olds at a kitchen table. So treat it as a map of how drawing goes wrong, not as a promise about your student. But the map is very useful, because it points to a specific cause: **what we know about an object crowds out what we actually see.**

You know a tabletop is a rectangle. So when you draw a table, you draw a rectangle. But from where you are sitting, the tabletop is not a rectangle at all. The far edge looks shorter than the near edge. The corners are not square. The shape your eyes actually receive is closer to a trapezoid. The *known* shape wins, and the drawing looks wrong — even though your hand did exactly what you told it to.

The same thing happens with an eye (drawn as the almond everyone learned in fourth grade), the top of a mug (drawn as a circle when it looks like a flattened oval), and a hand (drawn as a mitten with five sausages). None of these is a hand problem. Each is a seeing problem. And seeing problems have seeing fixes: measuring, slow contour drawing, drawing the empty spaces between things, checking the drawing against the object. Chapter 2 teaches those fixes in detail. This chapter gets the habit started.

So when your student says “I can’t draw,” you can hear it differently. Usually it means: *I drew what I know instead of what I see, and I judged it before I finished looking.* Both halves of that sentence are teachable.

Where this age sits on the map

Art educators have long described how young people’s drawing changes as they grow. A widely used map comes from Viktor Lowenfeld, who described a stage beginning around eleven to thirteen that he called the stage of reasoning, or the pseudo-naturalistic stage. In it, young people become much more critical of their own work and much more concerned with making it look realistic.²⁸ Different editions and summaries give slightly different ages, so hold the years loosely.

Use this as a map, not a verdict. It explains why your articulate, capable twelve-year-old might suddenly refuse to draw a horse they would have drawn happily at eight: the bar went up before the tools arrived. The answer is to bring the tools. Measuring, value, and perspective are conventions — techniques with names that can be taught and practiced — and the studio research that informs this book lists them plainly as craft.⁵ Your student wants realism at exactly the age when these tools make sense. That is a gift of timing.

Older books sometimes sorted students into “visual” and “haptic” types. You will not need that sorting here. Every student in this book looks, measures, and makes.

Why the sketchbook is private

Research on adolescence finds that young people at this age respond more intensely to being watched and evaluated than children or adults do.⁴ That research is not about art critique. But it lines up with what many parents see at the table: the student who draws freely alone and freezes when someone looks over their shoulder.

So this book keeps the sketchbook private by default. You check that pages happen; you read what your student offers. Critique of anything they make is invited, not imposed, and it starts with description. Chapter 7 teaches that kind of critique in full. This week, you only need the first step: describe before you decide.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

These are the five you will hear most often in the first month. Each has a usual meaning and a next move.

1. **“I can’t draw.”** Usually means: they drew the shape they know rather than the shape they see, and judged it before they finished. Next move: an ugly page on purpose (below), then a measuring or contour exercise. Leave the talent question alone entirely.
2. **Crumpling the page after two minutes.** Usually means: judging before sketching. The first marks were treated as the final drawing. Next move: thumbnails first, and the rule “keep the wrong line; draw the right one next to it.”
3. **“That’s ugly” about a master’s painting.** Usually means: a verdict before any description. This is not rudeness; it is the same habit they apply to their own page. Next move: three minutes of describe-only. The verdict can come later, with reasons.
4. **“I’ll just trace a picture from my phone.”** Usually means: skipping the seeing, and often skipping the credit. Tracing is not forbidden in this book; it is a tool, and it gets labelled. But a traced phone photo does not teach seeing. Next move: draw from the real object first; if a photo is used, it gets a credit line.
5. **“I made this” about a generated image.** Usually means: a blurry sense of what making is. Next move: a calm, plain conversation. A picture a program made is not their drawing. It can be looked at and discussed; it does not go in the folder as their work. (Chapter 8’s whose-mark card makes this routine rather than suspicious.)

Your five-minute warm-up (alone, before the first lesson)

Put a mug on the table. Set a timer for five minutes. Draw the mug without stopping, erasing, or judging it — no sighing allowed.

When the timer goes off, put the pencil down and write three things you *saw* while drawing that you had never noticed about that mug. The handle might be thinner where it joins the body. The rim might catch a bright line of light. The shadow might be darker right under the base.

That is the whole warm-up. If your drawing is bad, excellent. Keep it. You may want to show it to your student this week — an honest ugly page from a parent is one of the best lessons in this book.

How to teach it this week

This week's focus

One idea: **see before you judge; sketch before you polish.** Every try-it this week practices one half of it or both.

The first try-it

Start with three short moves in your first Art Hour, in this order:

1. **Ugly Page on Purpose (SKB-03)** — five to ten minutes of fast, deliberately bad drawings of one object. No erasing.
2. **Blind Contour Warm-Up (OBS-01)** — three to five minutes drawing the edge of a hand or a shoe without looking at the page.
3. **Five-Minute Silent Look (LOOK-01)** — five minutes looking at one real work of art and listing what they see, with no verdicts.

In your second Art Hour, do the **baseline drawing** (AS-01, below). Full try-it cards for all of these are in the next section.

Exact wording you can use

Try these sentences as written. They are short on purpose.

- Opening (locked): “What do you actually see — before either of us decides if it’s good?”
- Starting the ugly page: “Fast and bad. The worse, the better. Fill the page.”
- When they reach for the eraser: “Keep the wrong line. Draw the right one next to it.”
- Before blind contour: “Eyes on your hand, not the paper. It’s supposed to look strange.”
- When they say “it’s bad”: “Maybe. Tell me what you see first.”
- Handing over the sketchbook: “This sketchbook is yours. I’ll check that pages happen. I’ll read the ones you show me.”
- After a long silence: “I notice the shadow goes darker right under the edge. What do you see?”
- Closing: “Date it. One line underneath: what you tried.”

How to fade your help

- **First week:** sit beside your student for the whole Art Hour. Do your own ugly page next to theirs. Model the silent look by actually doing it.
- **Second week:** sit nearby for the See beat and the Talk beat. During Make, busy yourself with something quiet in the same room.
- **Third week and after:** check in at the start (“What’s today’s object?”) and at the end (“Show me anything you want to show me”). The ten-minute pages happen without you.

At 11–12, you will probably stay closer for longer, and that is fine. At 13–14, many students are glad to take the Make beat alone by the second week.

When to stop talking

Once the pencil moves, stop. Advice given mid-line is almost always heard as criticism at this age. Save it for the Talk beat, and even then, ask before you give an opinion.

If you catch yourself narrating (“Ooh, careful with that handle...”), put your own pencil on your own paper. It gives your hands and your mouth something to do.

Band moves

11–12. More modeling, shorter sits, and sentence starters for talk. Try: “I see.” *“It’s darker where .”* “The part that surprised me was ____.” You name the object for the ten-minute page if the blank page freezes them; they choose the angle. The baseline drawing can be a simple object: a mug, a shoe, a piece of fruit.

13–14. The student sets their own ten-minute-page schedule for the week and writes it on the inside cover. Introduce one piece of critique vocabulary from the Critical Response Process: the *permissioned opinion*. Model it once: “I have an opinion about the shoelace — would you like to hear it?” Let them say no.⁸ The baseline drawing can be a slightly harder object: a shoe with laces, a chair, a bunch of keys.

Ready 12, or 13 and new to all this? Place by the baseline drawing, not the birthday. A thirteen-year-old who has never drawn from life takes the 11–12 moves this month. An eleven-year-old who already measures instinctively can take the 13–14 moves.

A sample week

Day	What happens
Monday	Art Hour: ugly page on purpose, blind contour of a hand, one-line note
Tuesday	Ten-minute page (any object)
Wednesday	Art Hour: five-minute silent look at one real work; baseline drawing (AS-01)

Day	What happens
Thursday	Ten-minute page; start Same Object, Seven Days if your student wants a challenge
Friday	Describe-only on a postcard or open-access image; sketchbook review (three tabs)
Weekend	Pocket sketchbook outing, if it fits

That is a full week. If life only allows two Art Hours, keep Monday and Wednesday.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it below uses the shape from The Art Hour: time, materials, mess and safety, the fun, and the skill. The safety rules there apply throughout; this chapter's materials are gentle — pencils, pens, paper.

In-home — Ugly Page on Purpose (SKB-03)

- **Time:** 5–10 minutes
- **Materials:** Cheap paper or a sketchbook page; pen or pencil; one object
- **Mess / safety:** None to speak of
- **The fun:** Permission to be bad on purpose is surprisingly freeing. Students often laugh.
- **The skill:** Separating making from judging; loosening the hand; sketching before polishing

Steps. Put one object on the table — a mug, a sneaker, a banana. Say, “Fill this page with fast, bad drawings of it. The worse, the better. No erasing.” Set a timer. When it rings, ask your student to write one line at the bottom: *what got easier by the end?*

Stuck → **move.** If they won't start, do one yourself, on your own page, beside theirs. Make it genuinely bad. That usually does it.

In-home — Blind Contour Warm-Up (OBS-01)

- **Time:** 3–5 minutes
- **Materials:** Pen and paper; the student's own non-drawing hand, or a shoe
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** The results are gloriously strange. Everyone's looks like a map of a coastline.
- **The skill:** Slowing the hand to the speed of the eye; looking at the object instead of the page

Steps. A contour is a line that follows an edge. In a blind contour, the student keeps their eyes on the object the whole time and never looks at the page. They put the pen on the paper, fix their eyes on one edge of their hand, and move the pen slowly as their eyes creep along that edge — every wrinkle, every bump. The drawing will not look like a hand. That is fine. The point is the looking.

Stuck → **move.** Peeking is normal. If it keeps happening, poke the pen through the center of a paper plate so the plate hides the drawing hand and the page.

In-home — Five-Minute Silent Look (LOOK-01)

- **Time:** 5–8 minutes
- **Materials:** One real work of art — a museum postcard, a library art book, or a large image from a free museum collection such as the National Gallery of Art or The Met (see Chapter 10); a sketchbook for the list
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** It feels impossible at first, then turns into a treasure hunt.
- **The skill:** Seeing before judging, applied to someone else’s work

Steps. Cover the title and label if there is one. Both of you look silently for a full minute. Then your student lists twenty things they see — objects, colors, shapes, where the light is coming from, what is in the corners. No opinion words: no “pretty,” “weird,” or “boring.” After the list, uncover the label and read it together.

Stuck → move. If the list stalls at five, ask, “What’s in the corners?” Then, “What’s the darkest thing?” Most students find ten more.

In-home — Describe Only (CRIT-01)

- **Time:** 3–5 minutes
- **Materials:** Any image — a postcard, an old family photo of a place (no faces needed), a picture in a book
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** A word game with a rule: no opinions allowed.
- **The skill:** The first rung of every critique method this book teaches

Steps. Three minutes of describing only what can be seen. If an opinion word slips in — “nice,” “creepy,” “bad” — your student replaces it with a noun or a measurement. “Creepy” becomes “the windows are dark and the sky is grey-green.” You play too.

Stuck → move. If opinions keep sneaking in, turn it into a point game: one point for every opinion word the other person catches.

In-home — Same Object, Seven Days (SKB-04, starting this week)

- **Time:** 10 minutes a day for seven days
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; one object that will stay put (a shoe, a plant, a coffee grinder)
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** By day four, students start noticing things they could swear were not there on day one.
- **The skill:** Sustained looking; the discovery that the same object keeps giving

Steps. Draw the same object once a day for seven days, from a new angle, in new light, or with a new tool each day. Date each page. On day seven, your student chooses two: the best one and the one they learned most from. They are often different pages.

Stuck → **move**. Boredom around day three is normal. Change the medium or the size, not the object.

In-home — Unaided Observational Check (AS-01, your baseline)

- **Time:** 10 minutes, once this week and then once a month
- **Materials:** One ordinary object you will keep using (the same mug, the same shoe); pencil; sketchbook or a separate folder of check pages
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** Honestly, it is not the fun part this week. It becomes the fun part in about four months, when the pages go side by side.
- **The skill:** A snapshot of where your student’s observational drawing is right now

Steps. Put the object on the table under steady light. Say, “Ten minutes, from life, no help from me. This isn’t graded. It’s a snapshot so we can see how far you’ve come later.” Set a timer. Stay out of it. When the timer ends, the student dates the page and writes the object’s name. File it where you will find it next month.

Stuck → **move**. If they want to redo it, gently decline: “It’s a snapshot, not a performance. Next month there’s another one.” At 11–12, you can sit nearby doing your own; at 13–14, many students prefer you in another room.

How to read it. Look for seeing, not polish. Does the drawing measure — is the mug roughly as tall compared to wide as the real one? Is there any light and shadow at all? Are the shapes observed, or are they the known shapes (a circle for the rim, a rectangle for the body)? That tells you where Chapter 2 needs to start. It does not tell you anything about talent.

Out-of-home — Pocket Sketchbook Outing (SKB-05)

- **Time:** 15–30 minutes
- **Materials:** A small sketchbook that fits a pocket or a bag; a pen
- **Mess / safety:** Ordinary outing care. Face objects and buildings, not strangers. At 11–12, sit together.
- **The fun:** Drawing in the world feels like a small secret. Nobody knows what you are doing unless you tell them.
- **The skill:** Taking the sketchbook habit out of the house

Steps. Carry the sketchbook somewhere ordinary: a park bench, a library table, a porch, a bus stop, a café window. Your student draws one thing that is there — a bike rack, a lamppost, a fire hydrant, a cup. One page. Date it and write where you were.

Stuck → **move**. Feeling self-conscious in public is very common at this age. Face a wall, a tree, or a parked bike instead of open space. Sit together. Choose a quieter corner. It gets easier with every outing.

A note on outings. Many homeschool families already use these places. In a 2022–23 national survey, parents of about half of homeschooled students (53 percent) reported a library visit in the

past month, and 43 percent reported a visit to an art gallery, museum, or historical site.²⁹ If you are already going, bring the pocket sketchbook.

Out-of-home — A silent look in the wild (LOOK-01 at a museum or library)

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes
- **Materials:** Pocket sketchbook; pencil (many museums allow pencils only — check the visitor rules before you go)
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules; hands off the art
- **The fun:** One work only. No race through every room.
- **The skill:** The silent look, somewhere with real paintings or a real shelf of art books

Steps. At a museum, your student chooses one work. At a library, they choose one image in one art book. Silent minute. The list of twenty. Then read the label. If there is time, one quick sketch of one detail. Chapter 7 grows this into a full museum sit.

Talk box — this chapter

Opening (locked): “What do you actually see — before either of us decides if it’s good?”

Use it on anything: the egg, the ugly page, a master’s painting, a sibling’s drawing, your own warm-up mug.

Follow-ups:

1. **Seeing:** “Where’s the lightest part?”
2. **Measuring:** “How big is that compared to this?”
3. **Evidence:** “What do you see that makes you say that?”
4. **Process:** “What did you try?”
5. **Revise:** “What would you try next time?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three in your head. After they answer, wait again. The second answer is usually the better one. If the silence feels heavy, look at the object, not your student.

What stuck silence usually means. At this age, most often: fear of being judged. Your student may suspect that the “what do you see?” is a trap with a verdict hidden inside it. It can also mean they are hunting for the “right” art word, or that one of your opinions is already hanging in the air (“I love this one” said a moment too early). Answer silence by describing something yourself, neutrally: “I see three windows, and one’s darker than the others.” That shows the question is safe. And “not today” is an allowed answer.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “That’s really good!” (or “Hmm, that’s not quite right”). Say instead: “Tell me what you see first.”

Praise and criticism both skip the seeing. At this age, even generous praise can land as evaluation — and evaluation is exactly what makes a sensitive student go quiet.

Blocked and mixed practice

Blocked — for the new habit. Three days in a row of blind contour, each at the start of an Art Hour or ten-minute page. Short and repetitive on purpose. By day three, the slow eye-and-hand speed starts to feel normal.

Mixed — for when to use it. Later in the week, combine: a blind contour warm-up, then describe-only on a real work, then a ten-minute page from the same object you described. Your student practices choosing which habit to use when.

Retrieval. On Friday, ask without notes: “What are the two halves of the focus?” and “What does the blind contour practice?” Short spoken answers are enough.

One incorrect example to diagnose

Draw this for your student on demo paper, or describe it and let them draw it. (This is an illustration, not a real student’s page.)

Two eyes, side by side. The first is the eye everyone learns early: a pointed almond, a circle in the middle, a dot inside that, and five eyelashes sticking straight up like a fence. The second is drawn from a real eye in a mirror: the upper lid is a heavy curve that overlaps the top of the iris; the lower lid is a lighter, flatter line; the iris is partly hidden; the corner near the nose dips down; the lashes are a dark edge, not separate sticks.

Ask: “**Which one was seen?**”

Let your student explain how they know. They will point at the almond, the full circle, the fence of lashes. Those are *known* shapes. The second eye has overlaps, hidden parts, and edges that change weight — the evidence of looking.

Then, gently: “Most of us draw the first one. It’s the eye we know. This month, we’re practicing drawing the one we see.”

For the student

This section is for you, the artist. Your parent can read it too, but it is written to you.

Here is the idea. Most people who say they can’t draw are drawing what they *know* instead of what they *see*. That is not a talent problem. It is a seeing problem — and seeing can be practiced, like anything else.

The whole book comes down to two habits:

See before you judge. Look carefully, measure, and describe before you decide whether something is good or bad. That goes for your own drawing and for any painting in any museum.

Sketch before you polish. Fast, ugly first drawings are where the real decisions happen. The careful version comes later.

A tiny worked example. Look at a table from where you are sitting. You know it is a rectangle. Now look at it as if you had never seen a table before. The edge farthest from you looks shorter than the edge closest to you. The sides slant inward as they go back. The corners aren't square. The shape your eyes are actually getting is closer to a trapezoid — a four-sided shape with one pair of sides slanting in. If you draw the rectangle you *know*, the table will look like it is tipping toward you. If you draw the trapezoid you *see*, it will sit flat on the floor.

That is the entire trick of observational drawing, over and over again: noticing the gap between what you know and what you see, and drawing what you see.

Try 1 — Blind contour of your hand. Put your non-drawing hand on the table in an interesting pose. Put your pen on the paper. Now look only at your hand — not the paper — and slowly trace its edges with your eyes, moving the pen at the same speed. Go into every wrinkle. Take at least three minutes. When you look at the drawing, it will be strange. That is correct. Now look at your hand again. You probably see things you never noticed before.

Try 2 — Your first ten-minute page. Pick one object in the room. Write today's date in the corner. Draw it for ten minutes from life. When the timer goes off, stop, even in the middle of a line. Write one sentence underneath: something you noticed that surprised you.

Your sketchbook is yours. It is a place to practice badly. Your parent will check that pages happen, but they will only read the pages you choose to show them. Nobody else sees it unless you say so. If someone wants to give you an opinion about your work, you are allowed to say “not today.”

Explain it back. In your own words, tell someone (or write it on the inside cover): *What's the difference between seeing and judging?*

Challenge — Same Object, Seven Days. Pick one object that will stay put for a week. Draw it every day for seven days — a new angle, new light, or a new pencil each time. Date every page. On day seven, pick two pages: your best one, and the one you learned the most from. They might not be the same page. Notice which one you are prouder of.

One honest warning: the first week of this can feel worse than just drawing the way you always have. That is normal. You are learning to notice things your hand has never been asked to draw. It gets better, and the dated pages will show you exactly how much.

If it isn't clicking

Snag 1: they won't start

The blank page stays blank. Or they say “I don't know what to draw” and mean “I'm afraid of how it will look.”

Next move. An ugly page on purpose — with you drawing one too, right beside them. Make yours genuinely bad. Laugh at it, kindly. Then shrink the task: “Just the handle. Two minutes.” Starting is usually the whole hurdle.

Snag 2: they erase everything

Every line gets rubbed out before it has a chance. The paper wears thin. Nothing gets finished.

Next move. A pen-only week. No pencils, no erasers, for every ten-minute page and every warm-up. Add the rule: “Keep the wrong line; draw the right one next to it.” Point out that many artists’ drawings show several attempts at the same edge, and those extra lines are the record of looking, not mistakes to hide. After a week, bring the pencil back.

Snag 3: they mock their own work

“This is garbage.” “I’m so bad at this.” Said with a laugh, or not.

Next move. A describe-only rule for a week, applied to their own pages too. Before anyone says anything about a drawing — including the artist — three things get described first. “The handle is thicker at the bottom. The shadow is on the left. The rim is an oval.” Keep the sketchbook firmly private. Mocking your own work is often protection: if I say it’s bad first, nobody else can. Privacy lowers the need for that armor.

An illustration: the screen artist

(A composite, not a real family.) A fourteen-year-old draws only anime characters, copied from screens, and draws them well. Any suggestion to draw a mug is met with a long look.

Respect the interest; it represents real hours of practice and real skill. Add one observational ten-minute page a day, from any real object they choose. Ask for a credit line on screen references (“after [show], episode __”). And consider a bridge: a labelled study of a Japanese woodblock print from a free museum collection, which connects the linework they love to a long tradition of drawing from life. Nothing is taken away. Something is added.

When to slow down, go ahead, or find a teacher

Slow down if the baseline drawing shows only known shapes and the student is distressed. Spend another two weeks on ugly pages, blind contour, and describe-only before moving to Chapter 2’s measuring.

Go ahead when your student can do a blind contour without much fuss, uses describe-only on a real work without prompting, and has at least four dated ten-minute pages.

Find a human teacher when your student wants more than you can give them — more demonstration, more technique, other students to draw with. A community drawing class, a museum teen program, or an open studio is a gift, not a sign that you failed. Chapter 10 has ideas for finding one.

Tools, including AI

The full rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour. In this chapter, the tool is for you, not the student.

One useful job: ask a chatbot to help *you* prepare. For example: “I’m teaching an 11-year-old to describe a painting without giving opinions. Give me five neutral follow-up questions about light, shapes, and where things are placed.” Then you ask those questions yourself.

Your student’s page stays theirs. No tool is open during the drawing, and nothing generated goes in the sketchbook as their work.

What “done enough” looks like

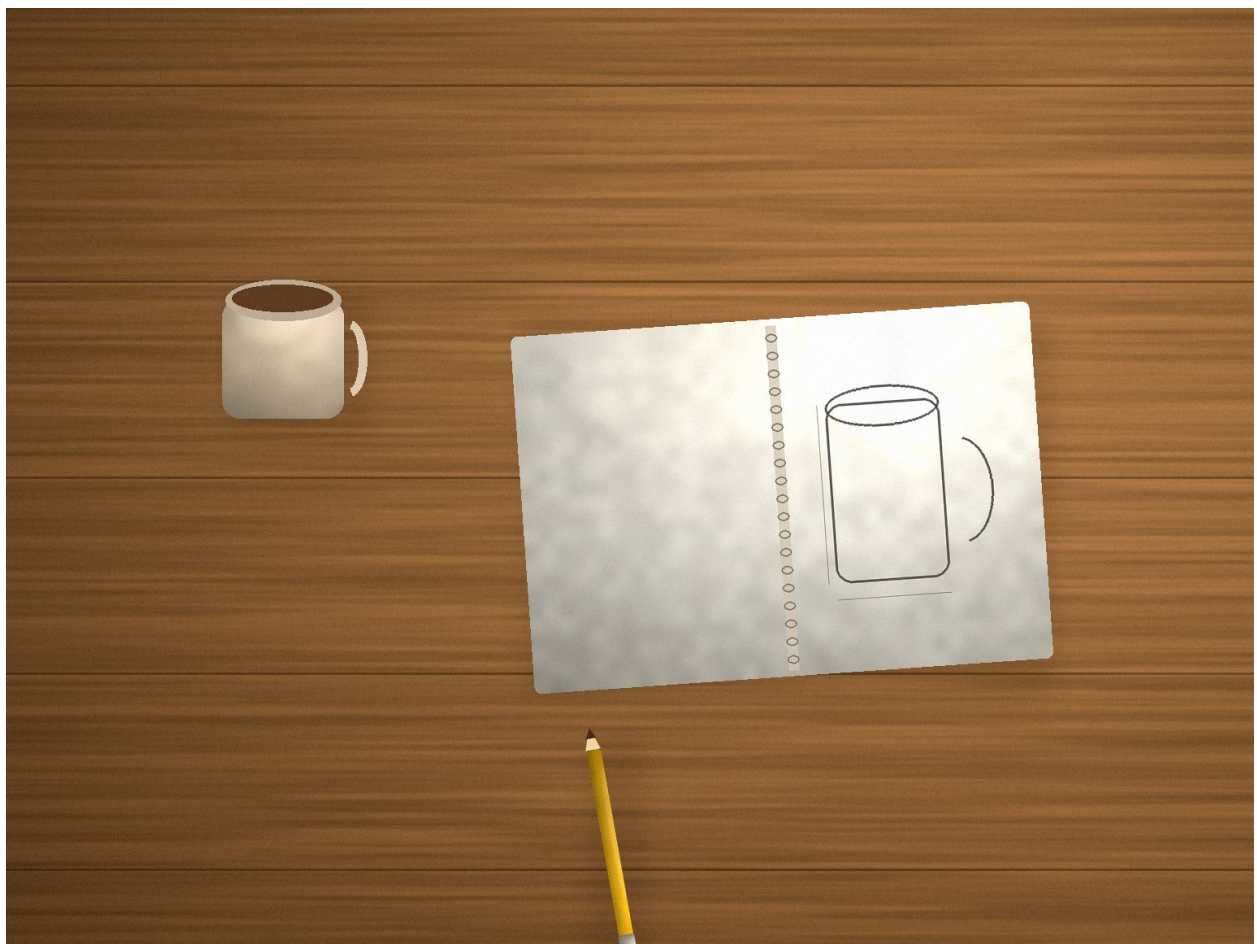
Before moving on to Chapter 2, check:

- ☐ A dated baseline drawing (AS-01) is filed where you will find it next month.
- ☐ At least four dated ten-minute pages exist this week. You checked that they exist; you read only what was offered.
- ☐ Your student has done at least one ugly page and at least three blind contours.
- ☐ Your student can say the focus — *see before you judge; sketch before you polish* — in their own words, and can explain what each half means.
- ☐ One describe-only session happened on a real work of art, spoken or written.
- ☐ You used the locked opening question at least once and waited through the silence afterward.
- ☐ One pocket sketchbook outing or one silent look away from home happened, or is on the calendar.
- ☐ Nothing generated is in the sketchbook as your student’s work.

Placement by skill. Use the baseline drawing, not the birthday, to decide how Chapter 2 starts. If the baseline shows mostly known shapes, begin with contour and negative space. If it already shows some measuring, move quickly to sighting. A “grade 7 art” book is a publisher’s scope, not a legal level.

Done enough is not perfect. It is: seeing happened, sketching happened, a baseline is filed, and the rhythm has started.

Chapter 2 — The sketchbook and observational drawing



Why this matters

This chapter hands your student two things they will use for the rest of their lives as artists: a private place to practice, and a set of tools for seeing.

The private place is the sketchbook. From now on it is their studio — the parking lot from Chapter

1 where they practice badly, try things, and keep the evidence. It is dated, it is kept, and it is theirs.

The tools are the moves of observational drawing: contour, gesture, negative space, and sighting. Observational drawing just means drawing from what is actually in front of you, rather than from memory or imagination. The moves sound technical, and they are. But each one is simple, and each one fixes a specific seeing problem. Contour slows the hand to the speed of the eye. Gesture catches movement before details get in the way. Negative space tricks the mind out of drawing the object it thinks it knows. Sighting measures, so the drawing can be checked against the object instead of against a feeling.

That last one matters more than it looks. Many students — and many adults — believe that “real” artists draw by instinct, and that measuring is a kind of cheating. The opposite is closer to the truth. Artists have measured for centuries. The pencil held out at arm’s length is one of the oldest tools in the studio. Measuring is how you see, not a way around seeing.

For an eleven- to fourteen-year-old who wants their drawings to look real, this is the chapter where that wish starts to come true. Not all at once. The first measured drawing often looks stranger than the guessed one, because it disagrees with what they expected. That disagreement is the whole point. For the first time, the drawing is being corrected by the object instead of by what they already knew.

Everything later in the book stands on this chapter. Value needs accurate shapes to shade. Perspective is measuring with rules. Critique is describing what you see. The sketchbook holds all of it.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You do not need to draw well to teach this chapter. You do need to understand one measuring move well enough to ask the right question when a drawing drifts. Ten minutes of practice this week will get you there.

The everyday picture: tailoring

A tailor measures before cutting. The tape measure does not insult the fabric. Nobody thinks a tailor who measures is less skilled than one who guesses; the one who guesses wastes a lot of cloth.

Observational drawing works the same way. Your student measures the object — not in inches, but in comparisons: *how many widths tall is it?* — and then checks the drawing against the same comparison. When the drawing is off, the measurement says where and by how much. The fix is a new line, not a new verdict.

The precise picture: four seeing tools

Here are the tools in plain words. Each has a try-it later in the chapter.

Contour. A contour is a line that follows an edge. In a *blind* contour (from Chapter 1), your student never looks at the page. In a *modified* contour, they look mostly at the object and glance at the page

only to place the next bit of line — something like eighty percent object, twenty percent page. Both slow the hand down to the speed of careful looking.

Gesture. A gesture drawing is a fast drawing of movement or pose, usually thirty seconds to two minutes. Instead of starting with an outline, the student starts with one line that captures the action — the curve of a spine, the lean of a body — and hangs everything else on it.

Negative space. Negative space is the shapes between and around things: the air between the legs of a chair, the gap between a hand and a hip. Drawing those shapes instead of the object is a powerful trick, because the mind has no “known shape” for the air between chair rungs. It has to look.

Sighting. Sighting means measuring with a pencil at arm’s length to compare sizes and angles. Here is how it works:

1. Hold a pencil straight out at arm’s length with the elbow locked. (The locked elbow keeps the pencil the same distance from the eye every time. A bent arm makes every measurement different.)
2. Close one eye. (Two eyes see two slightly different views; one eye gives a flat picture you can measure.)
3. Line up the tip of the pencil with one edge of the object — say, the top of a mug — and slide your thumb down the pencil until it lines up with the bottom. That length on the pencil is now your *unit*.
4. Keeping your thumb in place, turn the pencil sideways and compare. Is the mug as wide as it is tall? Wider? About three-quarters?
5. Write the comparison down: “1 wide, 1.3 tall.” Then make the drawing match the *ratio*, at whatever size fits the page.

Angle sighting (a 13–14 move, ready 12) uses the same arm position with the pencil held perfectly upright or perfectly level. The student compares a slanted edge — the side of a tabletop, the roofline of a house — to that straight pencil, and sees how far it tilts. Then they copy that tilt on the page, often with a light upright line drawn first as a reference.

Why these tools work

In Chapter 1 we met the research finding that most drawing errors come from misjudging the object, not from the hand.¹ Each tool above is a way of judging the object more accurately. Contour and negative space slow the eye and bypass the known shape; sighting checks the eye against a measurement.

There is older research with children pointing the same way. A study from the 1960s found that training children to pay attention to contours and to the most informative points of what they were drawing improved their drawings, with clearer gains among older elementary students than younger ones.³⁰ We use it for its direction, not its numbers. It is a useful study, not a promise that every home will see the same result.

The studio research that informs this book names “Observe” as one of the core habits artists practice — learning to look more closely than ordinary looking requires.⁵ That is the habit this chapter is

building.

The sketchbook: what it is and how you check it

What kind. Any bound book of plain drawing paper will do. Many students like a medium one (roughly 8 by 10 inches or 9 by 12) for home and a small pocket one for outings. Spiral or sewn is a matter of taste. Cheap is fine; a sketchbook too nice to ruin is a sketchbook that stays empty.

What goes in it. Everything. Ten-minute pages. Thumbnails. Ugly pages. Blind contours. Notes on a museum visit. Measurements in the margin. Master studies, labelled. Failed attempts, kept. Every page gets a date.

Private by default. In Chapter 1 we set the rule: the sketchbook is theirs. You check *that* pages happen — you can flip past and see dates — but you read only the pages your student chooses to show you. At this age, being watched weighs heavily, and a private book is where honest practice lives.

Friday review. Once a week, your student tabs three pages with sticky notes: *best*, *most learned*, and *try again*. You see those three. If they want to show you more, wonderful. If “none are good,” change the question: “Which one did you learn the most from?” There is always an answer to that one.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **The known shape.** An almond for an eye, a rectangle for a tabletop, a circle for the top of a mug seen from the side. Usually means: the mind drew the idea instead of the object. Next move: sight the actual shape, or draw the negative space around it.
2. **Proportions that drift.** The mug is getting taller and thinner with every measurement. Usually means: the arm bends between measurements, so the unit keeps changing. Next move: “Lock your elbow — every time, same distance.” Sometimes it means the student moved their chair. Mark where the chair goes with tape.
3. **A tight outline around an empty middle.** A careful, dark edge all the way around, and nothing inside it — no fold, no seam, no shadow shape. Usually means: the student thinks drawing *is* outlining. Next move: modified contour that is allowed to travel inside the object (along a seam, a fold, the edge of a shadow). Chapter 3 goes further with light and shadow.
4. **Drawing people who haven’t agreed.** On an outing, your student quietly draws a stranger at the next table. Usually means: people are interesting, and nobody mentioned the rule. Next move: explain it plainly — in this book, we draw people who have agreed to be drawn. In public, we draw objects and buildings. At home, family members who say yes, a mirror, or sculpture.
5. **A traced photo, with no seeing and no credit.** Usually means: the student wanted the result without the looking. Tracing is a tool, and in this book it is allowed when it is labelled. But tracing a phone photo does not practice seeing. Next move: draw from the object first. If a photo is used as a reference, it gets a credit line (“from my photo,” “after [artist, title]”).

Your five-minute warm-up (alone)

Put a mug on the table and sit where your student will sit. Hold a pencil out at arm's length, elbow locked, one eye closed. Line the tip up with the top of the mug and slide your thumb to the bottom. Turn the pencil sideways without moving your thumb. How many of those heights make the width?

Write the ratio on a scrap of paper — something like “1 wide, 1.3 tall.” Then do it again, deliberately bending your arm this time, and notice how much the number changes.

That is it. You now know sighting well enough to teach it — and to hear, the first time your student's mug starts to stretch, that the elbow bent.

How to teach it this week

This week's focus

One move: **sighting for proportion**. The rest of the week's practice — negative space, the hand, the ten-minute pages — circles around it.

The first try-it: Pencil Sighting on one mug (OBS-05)

Set a mug on the table under steady light, handle to one side. Sit beside your student, not across from them, so you see roughly the same view.

1. **See.** A silent minute. Then: “How many mug-widths tall do you think it is? Just guess.”
2. **Model once, on demo paper.** Show the locked arm, the closed eye, the thumb sliding down the pencil. Say out loud what you're doing. Get a number. Then put your demo paper face down.
3. **Their turn.** “Lock your elbow. One eye. How many mug-widths tall?” Let them find their own number. If it differs from yours, that's fine; you're sitting in slightly different places.
4. **Draw.** They draw the mug at a comfortable size, measuring as they go, and write the ratio in the margin. Encourage them to find a second ratio — the handle's height against the mug's, perhaps, or the width of the base against the width of the rim.
5. **Check.** When they think they're done, they sight the *drawing* the same way (holding the paper upright, at the same arm's length) and compare its ratio to the mug's.

Exact wording you can use

- “Lock your elbow. One eye. How many mug-widths tall?”
- “Guess first, then measure. Were you close?”
- “Glance, don't stare, at the page.”
- “Draw the air, not the chair.” (for negative space)
- “Your drawing says one-to-one-and-a-half. The mug says one-to-one-and-a-third. Which one wins?” (The mug always wins.)
- “Keep that line. Draw the corrected one next to it.”
- “What did you measure?”

How to fade your help

- **First session:** you model once on demo paper, then only ask the measuring question.
- **Second session:** you ask, “What will you measure first?” and let them choose.
- **By the end of the week:** you say nothing about measuring at all. Watch for the moment the pencil goes up to arm’s length without prompting. That is the moment to stop talking.

When to stop talking

When they start measuring on their own. Resist the urge to confirm every measurement (“Yes! That’s right!”). The object confirms it; your job is to have asked the question in the first place.

Band moves

11–12. This month’s core: blind and modified contour, negative space, sighting for proportion with the arm straight, and the hand in five poses. Keep sessions to thirty or forty minutes. You sit nearby for most of the Make beat. Name the object for ten-minute pages if needed; they choose the angle. Gesture drawing is a good warm-up, with a family member who agrees to pose, a pet, or a sculpture image.

13–14. Add angle sighting, gesture sequences, and longer observational drawings that stretch across two or three sessions. Your student chooses most of their own ten-minute-page subjects. Offer a **mirror self-portrait** as an option: a mirror propped at the table, one light from the side, and the same sighting tools applied to their own face. Keep the self-portrait in the sketchbook unless they choose to share it, and it never gets photographed or uploaded without their say. Gesture sequences can use family members who agree to pose, clothed, or public-domain sculpture — in a museum or from a free museum image collection.

Ready 12? A twelve-year-old who sights proportions confidently can try angle sighting this month. If they struggle, it will come around again in Chapter 4.

Two sample weeks

11–12:

Day	What happens
Monday	Art Hour: Pencil Sighting on a mug (OBS-05)
Tuesday	Ten-minute page
Wednesday	Art Hour: Negative-Space Chair (OBS-04)
Thursday	Ten-minute page; library art-book hunt if the week allows
Friday	Sketchbook review (SKB-06); done-enough check

13–14:

Day	What happens
Monday	Art Hour: Angle Sighting on a table corner (OBS-06)
Tuesday	Ten-minute page (student's choice)
Wednesday	Art Hour: Thirty-second gestures, then a longer observational drawing begins
Thursday	Ten-minute page; continue the longer drawing if they want
Friday	Sketchbook review; Sketch in Public outing (OUT-02) if it fits

Practice that actually builds learning

Here are the sketchbook and observation try-its. Pick one or two a week. The safety rules from The Art Hour apply throughout; this chapter is mostly pencil and paper, with one note about charcoal dust for gesture drawing.

The sketchbook bank

Ten-Minute Page (SKB-01) — *both bands; the habit behind every chapter*

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; pencil or pen
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** It's short. It ends at the timer, whatever happens.
- **The skill:** Daily drawing from life, without pressure

Date the page. Pick one object in view. Draw for ten minutes. Stop at the timer. If the blank page freezes them, you name the object; they pick the angle. Done enough: a dated page exists.

Thumbnail Strip (SKB-02) — *both bands*

- **Time:** 8–12 minutes
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; pen
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** Six tiny drawings, none of which count.
- **The skill:** Sketching before polishing; making choices cheaply

Draw six boxes about two inches across. In each, draw a different arrangement or crop of the same subject: closer, lower, off-center, from above, with the object cut off by the edge. Circle one, and write one reason. If all six come out the same, change just one thing per box.

Ugly Page on Purpose (SKB-03) — *both bands; card in Chapter 1*

Keep using it whenever perfectionism creeps back.

Same Object, Seven Days (SKB-04) — *both bands; longer at 13–14; card in Chapter 1*

This month, try it with a harder object: a shoe with laces, a crumpled paper bag, a houseplant.

Pocket Sketchbook Outing (SKB-05) — *both bands; card in Chapter 1*

Keep it going. It pairs with Sketch in Public, below.

Sketchbook Review Friday (SKB-06) — *both bands*

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** The week's pages; three sticky tabs
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** The student decides what gets seen.
- **The skill:** Reflection; noticing growth

Your student tabs three pages: *best, most learned, try again*, with one sentence each on a sticky note. You see the tabbed pages only, unless invited. If they say none are good, ask for “most learned” instead of “best.”

The observation bank

Blind Contour Warm-Up (OBS-01) — *both bands; card in Chapter 1*

Keep it as a three-minute warm-up at the start of any Art Hour this month.

Modified Contour — Glance 20/80 (OBS-02) — *both bands*

- **Time:** 10–15 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil; an object with interesting edges (a sneaker, a pair of scissors, a pinecone)
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** It looks much more like the object than a blind contour, but keeps the same strangeness.
- **The skill:** Contour with just enough checking to place the line

The student looks mostly at the object, glancing at the page only to decide where the next line goes. The line can travel inside the object along seams, folds, and the edges of shadows. Afterward, they note one “surprise edge” they would have missed. If the drawing turns into quick symbols, slow the pen down to the speed of the eye.

Thirty-Second Gesture (OBS-03) — *both bands*

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** Charcoal pencil or crayon; cheap newsprint or printer paper
- **Mess / safety:** Charcoal dust gets a damp wipe, never a blow (see The Art Hour).
- **The fun:** Fast, loose, and nothing has to be good.
- **The skill:** Catching movement and pose before detail

A family member who has agreed to pose — clothed, and willing to hold a pose for thirty seconds — or a sleeping pet, or a sculpture (in person or a museum image). Ten poses, thirty seconds each. For each, the student draws one curved line for the spine or the main action first, then adds head and limbs quickly. At the end, circle the liveliest. If they start with a careful head outline, stop and start with the spine curve.

Negative-Space Chair (OBS-04) — *both bands*

- **Time:** 15–20 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil; a chair or stool with legs and rungs
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** The chair appears without ever being drawn. It feels like a magic trick.
- **The skill:** Bypassing the known shape; seeing the spaces between

Put a chair where the spaces between its legs and rungs are easy to see — against a plain wall is ideal. The student draws only the shapes of the air: the space between the front legs, the gap under the seat, the window between the rungs. Shading those shapes lightly can help. When the spaces are done, the chair is there. Afterward, one line: “What I saw that I’d missed.”

If they keep drawing the chair itself, ask them to shade the spaces instead of outlining anything.

Pencil Sighting for Proportion (OBS-05) — *both bands; the first try-it above*

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil; an object; arm locked straight
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** It feels like a secret technique, because it is one.
- **The skill:** Measuring proportion by comparison

Done enough: a drawing with two measured ratios written in the margin.

Angle Sighting (OBS-06) — *13–14, ready 12*

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil; a table corner, a box, a door frame, or a roofline
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** Suddenly the table stops looking like it’s sliding off the page.
- **The skill:** Measuring slants against true upright and level

The student holds the pencil perfectly upright (or perfectly level) at arm’s length and compares a slanted edge to it. How far does the tabletop edge tilt from level? They transfer that angle to the page, drawing a light upright or level reference line first. Done enough: two corrected angles marked on the drawing. If angles keep drifting, the reference line is the fix.

Upside-Down Copy as a Study (OBS-07) — *both bands*

- **Time:** 15–20 minutes
- **Materials:** A public-domain line drawing by a master, printed or on screen, turned upside down; pencil; sketchbook
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** It feels like drawing a puzzle. Then you turn it over.
- **The skill:** Drawing shapes and edges without the known shape getting in the way

Find a line drawing — a figure, an animal, a plant — in a free museum collection such as the National Gallery of Art’s open-access images or The Met’s public-domain collection.^{31,32} Turn it upside down. The student copies it as a set of lines and shapes, working from one edge to the next,

without turning it right side up. At the end, turn both over. Most students are startled by how good it looks. Label the page: “Study after [artist, title, date]” and add the credit line.

You may have read this exercise described as switching to the “right side of the brain.” It does not need that story, and the brain science behind it does not hold up.³³ Turning the picture over interrupts the known shapes, so your student draws what is there. That is all it has to be: a seeing exercise.

Hand in Five Poses (OBS-08) — both hands

- **Time:** 20 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil; sketchbook; the student’s own non-drawing hand
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The fun:** A model who never gets bored and is always available.
- **The skill:** Sighting and negative space on one of the hardest subjects there is

Five poses on one page: open flat, a fist, pointing, holding a pencil, relaxed on the table. Use sighting to compare finger lengths against the palm. If the fingers come out as stiff sausages, draw the negative spaces between them first. Circle the best pose.

Out-of-home — Sketch in Public (OUT-02)

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes
- **Materials:** Pocket sketchbook; pencil or pen
- **Mess / safety:** Ordinary outing care. Objects and buildings, not people who haven’t agreed. At 11–12, sit together. Move on if anyone seems uncomfortable.
- **The fun:** The world is full of things nobody has drawn today.
- **The skill:** Sighting and contour outside the controlled light of the kitchen

Choose a café, a library, a park, or a bench on a main street. Your student draws one object or one piece of architecture: a bicycle, a bench, a lamppost, a doorway, a stack of books, a cup. Encourage one measurement in the margin, even outdoors. One page, dated, with the place written underneath.

Self-consciousness is very common. Sit beside them, draw your own page, and choose something still and unremarkable. It gets easier fast.

Out-of-home — Gesture from sculpture (OBS-03 at a museum)

- **Time:** 30–45 minutes
- **Materials:** Pocket sketchbook; pencil (check the museum’s rules — many allow pencils only)
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules; hands off the art
- **The fun:** The model never moves, never gets tired, and is often hundreds of years old.
- **The skill:** Gesture and proportion from the human figure, with no one asked to pose

Find a sculpture of a figure. Walk slowly around it and choose three viewpoints. From each, do a two-minute gesture: one line for the action first, then the rest. Then choose the best view and try a ten-minute sighted drawing. Write down the artist, title, and date from the label for the credit line.

Talk box — this chapter

Opening (locked): “Where does your drawing differ from the object — and how could you measure it?”

This question does something clever: it assumes the drawing differs (every drawing does) and moves straight to the fix. There is no verdict in it.

Follow-ups:

1. **Seeing:** “Which line surprised you?”
2. **Measuring:** “What did you measure?”
3. **Evidence:** “Where did you look most — at the object or at the page?”
4. **Process:** “What did you do when the measurement didn’t match?”
5. **Revise:** “What would you change first?”

How to wait. Ask, then a slow three. After they answer, another. If they go to re-measure in the middle of answering, that is the best possible response. Let them.

What stuck silence usually means. With this chapter, the drawing itself often feels exposed. Your student may hear “where does it differ?” as “what’s wrong with it?” If that happens, take the pressure off the page: “Let’s both look at the mug for a second.” Look at the *object* together instead of the drawing. Then ask again, gently. And “not today” is still allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “The handle’s too big.” Say instead: “Let’s measure the handle against the mug.”

Blocked and mixed practice

Blocked — for the new move. Sighting every day for a week: the first two or three minutes of every ten-minute page and every Art Hour. One measurement written in the margin each time. The repetition makes the locked arm automatic.

Mixed — for when to use it. In the second week, give your student a new object and let them decide which tool to reach for. A chair? Negative space. A mug? Sighting. A hand? Both. Then add a warm-up gesture before a longer measured drawing. The skill being practiced is choosing.

Retrieval. On Friday, without the book: “Why do we lock the elbow?” “What’s negative space?” “Name two ways to check a drawing against the object.” Short spoken answers.

One incorrect example to diagnose

Here are two chairs. (An illustration, not a real student’s work. You can draw them on demo paper or describe them.)

The first chair was drawn from memory. All four legs are the same length and hang straight down. The seat is a rectangle seen from above, with all four corners showing. The back is a perfect rectangle standing straight up. It looks like a diagram of a chair.

The second chair was drawn from the negative spaces of a real chair. The legs closer to the viewer come down lower on the page than the legs farther away. The seat is a slanted, lopsided shape because it is seen from an angle. One back leg is partly hidden behind a front leg. The spaces between the rungs are all different shapes.

Ask: “**Which one was seen? What gives it away?**”

Let your student find the clues: the equal legs, the rectangle seat, the missing overlaps. Then ask, “What would you do to turn the first chair into the second?” The answer is not “be more talented.” It is “look at the spaces, and measure.”

For the student

This section is for you.

Here is the idea. Sighting means using your pencil as a measuring tool at arm’s length. You’re not measuring in inches — you’re comparing. *How many times does the width fit into the height?* Then you make your drawing match that comparison.

Artists have done this for centuries. It’s not cheating. It’s how you catch the difference between what you *think* an object looks like and what it *actually* looks like.

How to sight:

1. Hold your pencil straight out, arm fully extended, elbow locked.
2. Close one eye.
3. Line up the tip of the pencil with the top of the object. Slide your thumb down until it lines up with the bottom. That’s your unit.
4. Keep your thumb still. Turn the pencil sideways. How many units wide is the object?

A tiny worked example. You sight a mug. It’s 1 unit wide and about 1.3 units tall — a little taller than it is wide. You want to draw it about 4 inches wide on your page. So it should be about $5\frac{1}{4}$ inches tall ($4 \times 1.3 = 5.2$). You draw it, then hold your paper up and sight your drawing the same way. Your drawing comes out 1 wide and 1.5 tall — too tall. So you draw a new bottom edge a bit higher. You don’t have to erase the first line; drawing the correction next to it is fine.

The first time you do this, the measured drawing might look *wrong* to you — too short, too wide. That’s your brain arguing for the mug it remembers. Trust the measurement.

Try 1 — A mug. Sight a mug. Write the ratio in the margin. Draw it. Then sight your drawing and compare. Write down whether you were close.

Try 2 — A shoe. Shoes are harder: they’re long, low, and seen at an angle. Measure the height of the shoe against its length. Then find one more comparison — how far back the laces start, for example. Write both ratios in the margin.

Explain it back. Why do you have to lock your arm when you sight? (Try it both ways and see what happens to your numbers.)

Challenge — The negative-space chair. Put a chair against a plain wall. Draw only the shapes of the air — between the legs, under the seat, between the rungs. Don't draw the chair at all. When you're done, the chair should be there anyway.

Your sketchbook. This is your studio. Date every page. Keep the bad ones — especially the bad ones, because they're how you'll see how far you've come. You decide which pages anyone else sees. If you draw in public, draw things and buildings, not people who haven't said yes.

If it isn't clicking

Snag 1: the measurements keep coming out wrong

The ratio changes every time they measure, or the drawing never matches.

Next move. Check three things, in order. Is the elbow locked, every time? Is one eye closed? Is the student sitting in exactly the same place? (Tape a mark on the floor for the chair if needed.) Then shrink the task: one object, one ratio, height against width, nothing else. Once that is reliable, add a second.

Snag 2: boredom

"I've drawn this mug five times." By day three of the week, the object has lost its charm.

Next move. Change the scale or the medium, not the object. Draw the mug tiny. Draw it huge, filling the page. Draw it in pen, in charcoal, with the non-drawing hand. Draw it from directly above. The same object seen differently is still new. If they truly need a change, switch to something that challenges the same skill: a teapot, a vase, a water bottle.

Snag 3: anxiety about sketching in public

Your student likes drawing at home but freezes outside. Someone might look.

Next move. Face objects, not people, and sit where no one is behind you. Sit together. Use a pocket-sized book that closes quickly. Start somewhere quiet — a library corner, a back porch, a park on a weekday morning. The first outing can be five minutes. Nobody has to know what they're doing; most people assume anyone with a notebook is writing.

When to slow down, go ahead, or find a teacher

Slow down if sighting still produces random results after a week of practice. Go back to contour and negative space for another week, and try sighting again.

Go ahead when your student sights without prompting, can explain why the elbow locks, and has a negative-space drawing in the sketchbook.

Find a human teacher if your student is ready for more than this book can give — longer observational sessions, figure drawing with an instructor, a drawing group. Many community centers

and museums run drawing classes for teens. Check each venue's age rules. A class is a gift, not a failure.

Tools, including AI

The full rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour.

Two allowed uses fit this chapter, both for you. First, ask a chatbot to explain sighting *to you* before you teach it: "Explain pencil sighting for proportion in plain language. What are two mistakes a 12-year-old commonly makes, and how would I notice them?" Second, use a tool for reference hunting: "Where can I find public-domain line drawings of hands or figures in museum open-access collections?" Then go to the collection yourself, choose the image, and record the credit line.

Your student draws from the real mug, the real chair, and their own hand. No tool is open during the drawing.

What "done enough" looks like

Before moving on to Chapter 3, check:

- ☐ At least seven dated sketchbook pages from this chapter.
- ☐ One drawing with two measured ratios written in the margin.
- ☐ One negative-space drawing (a chair, a stool, a plant, a bicycle).
- ☐ Your student can explain sighting in their own words, including why the elbow locks.
- ☐ At least one contour drawing (blind or modified) and one set of gestures.
- ☐ Any master study or photo reference carries a credit line.
- ☐ One out-of-home page: a public sketch, a pocket outing, or a sculpture gesture.
- ☐ 13–14 (or ready 12): one drawing with two corrected angles marked.
- ☐ Friday sketchbook reviews happened, with three tabs each week.
- ☐ Next month's unaided check (AS-01) is on the calendar, using the same object as the baseline.

Placement by skill. If your student can sight proportions reliably but struggles with angles, go on to Chapter 3 anyway; angles return in Chapter 4. If proportions are still unreliable, stay a little longer. Chapter 3 depends on shapes accurate enough to shade.

Done enough is not perfect. It is: the sketchbook is a habit, the pencil goes up to arm's length without being asked, and your student knows how to check a drawing against the object.

Chapter 3 — Value, light, and form



Why this matters

Put an egg on a dark cloth. Switch off the overhead light. Turn on one desk lamp and aim it from the side. Now look.

The egg is not white anymore. One side glows. A soft band of grey slides around its middle. The far side goes surprisingly dark, and then, right at the bottom edge, it lightens again. Under it, a shadow stretches across the cloth, darkest where egg meets table. None of that is an outline. All of

it is light.

That is what this chapter teaches: **value**, which is simply how light or dark something is, and how value makes **form**, the feeling that a flat drawing has weight and roundness and could be picked up. At eleven to fourteen, this is often the skill students have been waiting for without knowing its name. They want their drawings to look real. They have been drawing careful outlines and filling them in evenly, and the result looks like a sticker. Value is the missing piece. When a twelve-year-old shades her first egg and it suddenly sits on the page, you will see her face change. That moment is worth the whole month.

Value also trains the eye in a way that carries into everything else in this book. You cannot shade what you have not seen, and you cannot see value while you are busy naming things. “Egg” says white. The eye says three greys and a black. The focus line of this book, **see before you judge; sketch before you polish**, gets very concrete here. Seeing means squinting and comparing two spots. Sketching means a quick value thumbnail before the careful drawing. Polish, the smooth blending, comes last.

Value is learnable. It does not require a special talent, a special pencil, or a parent who can draw. It needs one lamp, one object, a seven-step scale, and the habit of asking where the light is. Chapter 1 made the case that most drawing trouble is seeing trouble.¹ Value is the clearest proof: once students learn to look for the lightest light and the darkest dark, their drawings change within a week or two. Not every home will move at that pace, and that is fine. The direction is what matters.

This chapter also brings the first materials that need a little care: charcoal and soft pastel, which make dust. The rules are short, and they are the same ones you met in the safety spine in *The Art Hour*. You will see them again below, in context, where they belong.

What your student can try today: a seven-step value scale in ten minutes. What you can learn this week: the five parts of light on a round object, well enough to hear when a drawing is missing one.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You do not need to shade well to teach shading. You need to see value well enough to ask good questions. That part is quick to learn, and you can practice it at the kitchen sink.

The everyday picture. Shine a flashlight on a ball in a dark room. One side is bright. A darker band runs across the middle where the ball turns away from the light. There is a shadow on the table. If you look hard, the darkest side of the ball is a little lighter at the very bottom edge, because light bounces up off the table. That is the whole idea. Every round object under a single light does roughly the same thing.

The precise picture. Artists name five parts of light on a rounded form. Here they are, in plain words:

- **Highlight:** the brightest spot, where the light hits most directly. On a shiny object it is a small, sharp dot; on a matte egg it is a soft, broad patch.
- **Halftone:** the middle greys on the lit side, where the form begins to turn away from the light.

- **Core shadow:** the darkest band *on the object itself*, just past the turn. This is the band that makes things look round. Students almost always leave it out or put it at the very edge.
- **Reflected light:** a slightly lighter zone inside the shadow side, caused by light bouncing back from the table or cloth. It is always darker than anything on the lit side. Students tend to make it too bright, which turns the egg into a donut.
- **Cast shadow:** the shadow the object throws onto the surface. It is darkest and sharpest right where the object touches the table and softens as it moves away.

Two tools make these parts visible. The first is the **squint**. Squinting blurs detail and merges similar values, so you see big masses of light and dark instead of texture and edges. Artists squint constantly. It looks odd. It works. The second is the **value scale**: a strip of boxes that runs from paper white to the darkest dark your pencil can make, in even steps. Seven steps is the house standard. The scale gives you and your student a shared vocabulary: “Is that shadow a 5 or a 6?” is a much better question than “Is it dark enough?”

Two more terms appear at 13–14. A **high-key** drawing lives mostly in the light end of the scale; a **low-key** drawing lives mostly in the dark end. Both are choices, not mistakes. And **subtractive** drawing means you tone the whole page grey first and then *remove* the lights with an eraser, working from the middle out.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear. When you look at a value drawing, these are the five patterns worth knowing by sight. Each one tells you what to ask next.

1. **An outline with even shading inside.** The student drew the edge, then colored the inside one flat grey, maybe darker near the edge. This usually means there was no single light source to look at, or the student is drawing what they know about eggs rather than what the lamp is doing. Next move: one lamp, overhead lights off, and the question “Where’s the lightest light?”
2. **Everything mid-grey.** The drawing has no real whites and no real darks. It usually means timidity, a soft pencil pressed lightly, or fear of “ruining it.” Next move: have them find the darkest dark first and put it down at full strength. Then compare two spots at a time.
3. **The shadow on the wrong side.** The cast shadow falls toward the lamp, or the dark side of the egg faces the light. It usually means the student drew from memory halfway through and stopped looking. Next move: draw a small arrow in the page corner showing where the light comes from.
4. **Charcoal smudged into mud.** Every value has been blended with a finger until it is one soft grey. This usually means blending became the goal instead of the value. Next move: fewer passes, lift lights with an eraser, and blend only where the form actually turns softly.
5. **Blowing on the charcoal.** The student puffs the dust off the page. This one is a safety habit, not a drawing problem. Next move: tap the page into a bin and wet-wipe the table. More on dust below.

Your five-minute warm-up. Do this alone, before the first lesson, on scrap paper. Draw seven boxes in a row. Leave the first one white. Make the last one as dark as your pencil will go. Fill the five between in even steps. It will not be even the first time; the jump in the middle is almost always too big. Squint at it and fix one box. Then put your coffee mug under a lamp and squint at it for sixty seconds. Find the core shadow on the mug. Find the reflected light. That is all. You are

now ready to ask the questions in this chapter, and you have a scale of your own to show if your student wants to see that grown-ups' first scales are lumpy too.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. Keep the five beats of the Art Hour: See, Sketch, Make, Talk, File. This week the See beat is about light. Plan two to four Art Hours, a ten-minute sketchbook page on the other days, and one outing this week or next (the nature value study below). On Friday, the student tabs three sketchbook pages and you run one short check: a seven-step scale made without help.

The first try-it: Egg Under a Lamp (VAL-02). Most families start here, even before the value scale, because the egg gives the scale a reason to exist.

Set up before the student arrives. Put a dark cloth or dark T-shirt on the table. Set a raw or hard-boiled egg (or a white ball) on it. Place one lamp to the side and slightly above, about the height of the student's head. Turn off overhead lights and close the blinds if you can. The simpler the light, the easier the seeing.

Exact words for the See beat.

"Before we draw anything, let's just look for a minute. No talking."

Wait the full minute. Then:

"Where's the lightest light?"

Let them point. Then:

"Where's the darkest dark? Is it on the egg or under it?"

Then the question that does the most work:

"Where does the shadow turn?"

If they point to the edge of the egg, that is normal. Ask them to squint. "Squint until it goes blurry. Now where's the dark band?" Most students will find the core shadow once they squint. If they do not, touch nothing. Move the lamp a little lower so the band gets stronger, and ask again.

The Sketch beat. Three small thumbnails, each the size of a matchbox: just the egg shape, the dark band, and the cast shadow, in three values only (white paper, a middle grey, a dark). Two minutes each. These are ugly on purpose. They decide where the darks go before any careful drawing happens.

The Make beat. Now the real drawing, on sketchbook paper, twenty minutes or so. Say:

"Draw the egg's shape very lightly, then forget the outline. Shade the shapes of light and dark you see. Start with the darkest dark."

If your student asks for an eraser, say yes. Erasers are drawing tools in value work, not only fixers. If they reach for a heavy outline, say, "Try it with no outline this time. Let the dark shadow make the edge."

One good question. Near the end of the Make beat, ask only this: “What would make it rounder?” You are not hinting at an answer. Some students will darken the core shadow; some will soften the halftone; some will notice the reflected light. Any of those is a real answer.

Name the five parts once, then stop naming. After the first drawing, go through the five parts of light together, pointing at the real egg: highlight, halftone, core shadow, reflected light, cast shadow. Let the student label their drawing in small letters. That is the only lecture this week. After that, you only ask, “Where does it turn?”

How to fade your help. Day one, you set the lamp and ask every question. Day two, the student sets the lamp and you ask the locked opening only. By day three or four, you should hear the student squint without being asked. That is your cue to stop talking. Your job becomes protecting the quiet minute and filing the dated page.

When to stop talking. While they shade. The Make beat is the student’s time with the object. If you notice a mistake, write it on a sticky note for yourself and bring it up in the Talk beat, as a question. “I noticed the shadow’s on this side. Where’s the lamp?” usually does more than any correction.

The rescue order. If your student is stuck, use the house order from *The Art Hour*: ask, wait, give a hint, give a short demonstration on separate demo paper, then hand the pencil back. For value, the demonstration is rarely a drawing. It is usually you turning the lamp so the shadow gets stronger.

Band moves

11–12. Work in graphite pencil. A single HB or 2B is enough to start; a small set from 2H to 6B is nice to have and not required, because one pencil can make a full scale with pressure. Teach crosshatching (layers of parallel lines, which build value without smudging) and notan (a two-value design, explained below). Keep materials AP-labelled if your student is in grade 6 or below, as set out in the safety spine. Vine charcoal and soft pastel can wait, or can be used with the wet-wipe rule and an adult nearby. Oil pastel is a good dust-free alternative for a student who wants a soft, dark medium.

13–14. Add charcoal for a full value range: vine charcoal (soft, easy to erase) and compressed charcoal (darker, harder to lift). Try subtractive charcoal (VAL-04), which is one of the great satisfying techniques of this age: tone the whole page, then pull the lights out with an eraser. Try a high-key drawing of a white object and a low-key drawing of a dark one. Subtractive charcoal happens only at this band and only at a ventilated table, with the dust rules below.

Ready 12. A careful twelve-year-old who has done the egg well and handles the wet-wipe routine without reminders may try a small subtractive study at 13–14 rules, with you at the table. Place by skill, not birthday.

Dust, air, and charcoal (a short point back)

The safety spine in *The Art Hour* covers dust and air in full. Here is what applies to this chapter. Federal guidance for students through grade 6 says to avoid processes that make airborne dust and

to avoid self-pressurized containers such as spray cans.¹¹ This book extends both habits to every age:

- Tap charcoal dust into a bin. Never blow it off the page.
- Wet-wipe the table and hands after charcoal or soft pastel. No dry sweeping.
- Subtractive charcoal only at 13–14, at a table with a window open or good airflow.
- Spray fixative stays out of the house. At 13–14 an adult may use it outdoors following the label, or you can skip it and slip the drawing into a sleeve. At 11–12, skip it.
- Food and drinks off the art table.

Check each new charcoal or pastel for its label, as described in the safety spine.¹⁰ If your student is in grade 6 or below, AP-labelled materials only.

Practice that actually builds learning

Practice in this chapter moves in a clear order. First, **blocked practice**: the same move repeated until it feels ordinary (three eggs, three lamp positions). Then **mixed practice**: a new object, a new light, and the student decides what to do. Along the way, brief **retrieval**: “Name the five parts of light” without looking at the notes. And one incorrect example, which is often where the understanding finally clicks.

In-home — Seven-Step Value Scale (VAL-01)

- **Time**: 10–15 minutes
- **Materials**: Pencil (one pencil with pressure, or a small range from 2H to 6B); ruler; sketchbook
- **Mess / safety**: Low
- **The fun**: It looks like nothing until it works, and then it looks like a tool.
- **The skill**: Controlling pressure; seeing even steps; building a shared vocabulary for value.

Steps. Rule seven boxes in a strip, each about one inch square. Box 1 stays paper white. Box 7 is the darkest the pencil can make. Box 4 is the halfway grey. Fill in 2, 3, 5, and 6 so every jump looks the same size. Squint at the finished strip. Where one jump looks bigger than the others, adjust.

Stuck → move. The jump between boxes 3 and 5 is almost always too big. Squint and add a step. If box 7 is not dark enough, it is usually because the pencil is too hard; switch to a softer pencil or add layers.

Exit. Tape or glue the scale inside the sketchbook cover. It becomes a reference for every value drawing from now on.

In-home — Crosshatch Ladder (VAL-05)

- **Time**: 10–15 minutes
- **Materials**: Fine pen (ballpoint works); sketchbook; a cup
- **Mess / safety**: Low

- **The fun:** Pen means no erasing, which is freeing once you get used to it.
- **The skill:** Building value with line; patience; committing to a mark.

Steps. Make seven boxes again. Box 1: empty. Box 2: one layer of parallel lines. Box 3: add a second layer crossing the first. Keep adding layers in new directions, closer together, until box 7 is nearly solid. Then shade a small cup with the same method, following the cup's curve with the lines if the student wants a challenge.

Stuck → **move.** Scribbles instead of lines: "Parallel strokes only. One direction per layer." Lines too far apart: "Half the gap."

Exit. The ladder and a small cup on one page.

In-home — Squint Test (VAL-03)

- **Time:** 3 minutes
- **Materials:** Any value drawing and the object it came from
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** It feels like cheating. It isn't.
- **The skill:** Comparing values directly, instead of by guess.

Steps. Put the drawing beside the object. Squint at both. Find two places where the drawing's value does not match the object's. Mark them with a small dot. Fix one.

Stuck → **move.** "Everything looks grey." Compare only two spots at a time: "Which is darker, the cast shadow or the core shadow?"

Exit. Two dots, one correction.

In-home — Notan Two-Value Thumbnail (VAL-06)

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** Black marker; three small boxes in the sketchbook
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Bold shapes; it feels like designing a poster.
- **The skill:** Seeing the big light and dark masses; composition through value.

Notan is a word artists borrow from Japanese for a design made only of light and dark. It trains the eye to see the big shapes before the small ones.

Steps. Pick a scene: a kitchen corner, a plant by a window, a pile of shoes. Squint hard. Draw three small thumbnails in which every area is either pure black or pure white. No greys. Choose the one that reads most clearly.

Stuck → **move.** Too many tiny shapes: "Merge anything that's about the same value." Everything black: "Squint again. Where's the lightest big shape?"

Exit. Three notans; one circled for a later drawing.

In-home — Subtractive Charcoal (VAL-04), 13–14 and ready 12

- **Time:** 25–35 minutes
- **Materials:** Vine or compressed charcoal; a kneaded eraser and a white plastic eraser; paper towels; wet wipes; a small bin; a simple still life (a mug and an egg) under one lamp; a ventilated table
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; dust. Window open or good airflow. Tap dust into the bin, never blow. Wet-wipe when done. No spray fixative indoors.
- **The fun:** Pulling light out of darkness, like switching on a lamp inside the drawing.
- **The skill:** Thinking in value masses; working from the middle value outward; controlling edges.

Steps. Tone the whole page an even middle grey with the side of the charcoal. Smooth it gently with a paper towel. Now squint at the still life. With the eraser, lift out the lightest shapes first: the highlight, the lit side, the lit tablecloth. Then add the darkest darks with charcoal: core shadow, cast shadow. Adjust. Stop at three clear values before trying for more.

Stuck → **move.** Dust cloud: stop, tap into the bin, wipe, restart gently. Mud: “Fewer passes. Lift with the kneaded eraser instead of rubbing.”

Exit. A still life in at least three values. Photograph it for the portfolio candidates folder if the student likes it.

Out-of-home — Nature Value Study (OUT-05)

- **Time:** 20 minutes on site
- **Materials:** Small sketchbook, pencil, a clipboard or stiff backing; water, sun protection
- **Mess / safety:** Low; stay on paths; a buddy; no trespassing for a view. Pick a time with strong sun if you can.
- **The fun:** Bark and stones in hard sunlight are full of drama. Nobody else in the park knows you are doing a drawing exercise.
- **The skill:** Simplifying a complicated surface into three values; finding value outdoors, where the light is not under your control.

Steps. Find a tree trunk, a pile of stones, or a big leafy plant in direct sun. Squint until the detail disappears. Draw only three values: paper white, one middle grey, one dark. Ignore texture for the first ten minutes. Add a little texture only in the last few minutes, and only in the middle grey.

Stuck → **move.** Detail overload is the usual problem outdoors. Squint. “If you can’t see it while squinting, leave it out.”

Exit. One dated page, with the place and the time of day written in the corner.

A good extension, if a museum is nearby: sit with one still-life painting and do a notan of it in the sketchbook, where the museum’s rules allow pencils. Check the visitor rules before you go.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “Where is the lightest light and the darkest dark — and where does the shadow turn?”

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Seeing:** “Where’s the light coming from? Point to the lamp, then to the brightest spot.”
2. **Measuring:** “Squint. What disappears? What’s left?” Or, with the scale in hand: “Is the table a 3 or a 5?”
3. **Evidence:** “What do you see that tells you that part is round?”
4. **Process:** “What did you put down first, and would you do it in the same order next time?”
5. **Revise:** “What would make it rounder?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three in your head before you say anything else. This pause is a classroom-origin habit, borrowed from research on how long teachers wait after asking a question, not an art study.⁷ It still helps. If silence feels long, look at the egg, not at your student. That tells them the object is the point, not their answer.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. They are afraid the drawing is bad and the question is a trap. They are hunting for the “right” art word (like “core shadow”) and do not want to guess. They are still looking. Or your face already said something about the drawing. Give it a moment, then offer a smaller question: “Just point to the darkest spot on the real egg.” “Not today” is an allowed answer; you can come back to it tomorrow.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “That’s too light.” Say instead: “Let’s squint and compare it to the real one.”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked (first week or so). Three eggs, three lamp positions: light from the left, light from above, light from low and behind. Same object, same paper size, same five parts to find. The student learns that the five parts move when the lamp moves, but never disappear.

Mixed (the week after). A new object with a new light: a white mug, a lemon, a folded towel, a shoe. The student sets up the lamp, chooses the view, and decides whether to work in pencil, pen hatching, or charcoal (13–14). You only ask the locked opening.

Retrieval (two minutes, any day). “Without looking at your notes, name the five parts of light.” Or: “Show me box 5 on your scale.” Quick, low stakes, and then back to drawing.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This one is an illustration, not a real student’s work. Draw it yourself on demo paper, or describe it aloud:

A circle drawn with a firm dark outline. Inside, the whole circle is shaded an even medium grey, a little darker near the outline all the way around. No shadow underneath. A small white dot in the exact center.

Ask your student: “What’s missing? What would a lamp do to this ball?”

Most students will find at least two of the problems: there is no light direction (the darkening goes all the way around), there is no cast shadow, the outline flattens it, the highlight is in the center as if the light were coming from the viewer’s own eyes. The best students notice that the even darkening near the edge is a guess, not something seen. Let them redraw it correctly beside the wrong version, with an arrow showing where the light comes from. Keep both on the page. The pair teaches more than either drawing alone.

The ten-minute page this week

On non-Art-Hour days, the ten-minute sketchbook page (SKB-01) takes on this chapter’s theme. Suggestions: a value scale in a new medium; one object near a window in afternoon light; a notan of the view from a chair; the same mug three days running under different light. The page is dated and private by default. You check that it exists, not how it looks, unless your student invites you in.

For the student

This section is for you.

Value means how light or dark something is. That is all. It is not a talent, and it is not a mystery. It is something you can see, measure, and practice.

Here is why it matters. When you draw an outline and fill it in evenly, the drawing looks flat, like a sticker. When you draw the lights and darks you actually see, the drawing starts to look solid, like something you could pick up. That jump is one of the most satisfying things in drawing, and it usually happens faster than people expect.

A tiny worked example. Put an egg on a dark cloth under one lamp. Turn the other lights off.

- Find the **highlight**: the brightest patch, facing the lamp.
- Find the **core shadow**: the darkest band *on the egg*, where it turns away from the light. It is usually not at the very edge. It is a little way in.
- Find the **reflected light**: a slightly lighter area on the shadow side, near the bottom, where light bounces up from the table. It is lighter than the core shadow, but still darker than anything on the lit side.
- Find the **halftone**: the middle greys between the highlight and the core shadow.
- Find the **cast shadow**: the shadow on the cloth. It is darkest right under the egg.

Now draw the egg’s shape very lightly. Start shading with the darkest dark. Leave the paper white for the highlight. Work outward. No heavy outline; let the shadow make the edge. When you think you are done, squint at the egg and at your drawing. Fix the one spot that does not match.

Try 1. Make a seven-step value scale. Seven boxes in a row. Box 1 is white paper. Box 7 is as dark as you can make it. Make the five in between even. Squint. If one jump looks bigger than the others, fix it. Tape it inside your sketchbook cover.

Try 2. Move the lamp to a new position (above, or low and behind) and draw the egg again. Label the five parts in small letters. Compare your two drawings. What moved? What stayed the same?

Explain it back. In your own words, what is reflected light, and why should it be darker than the lit side of the egg? Say it out loud to someone, or write two sentences in the margin.

Challenge. Draw a white object on a white cloth. A white mug on a white towel works well. There is almost no color to help you, so everything depends on value. It is hard. Your first attempt will probably look pale and flat. Squint, find the darkest dark (there is always one, usually in the cast shadow right under the object), and push it. Then try again.

A few honest things. Your first scale will have a lumpy middle. Almost everyone's does. Charcoal will get on your hands and probably your face; wash with soap and water, and wet-wipe the table instead of blowing the dust away. Blowing sends dust into the air you breathe. Your sketchbook pages are yours. Nobody needs to see them unless you want to show them. If a drawing goes muddy, that is information, not failure: it usually means you blended too much. Lift some lights with an eraser and keep going.

You are allowed to squint at things in public. Artists do it all the time.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: Everything is mid-grey. The drawing is timid. No whites, no darks, all soft middle tones.

Next move: Have the student find the single darkest spot on the real object and put it down at full strength first, before anything else. Then compare pairs: "Is this darker or lighter than that?" If the problem continues, switch to pen hatching for a week (VAL-05). Pen commits, and commitment often unlocks value. A softer pencil (4B or 6B) can also help; a hard pencil simply cannot get dark.

Diagnostic 2: Charcoal turns to mud. Every drawing ends up a smeared grey.

Next move: Fewer passes. No fingers for blending this week; a paper towel only, and only on halftones. Lift lights with a kneaded eraser instead of rubbing. At 11–12, go back to graphite, which is more forgiving, and try charcoal again next month.

Diagnostic 3: The light source gets lost halfway through. The drawing starts correctly and then shadows appear on both sides.

Next move: Draw a small arrow in the page corner before starting, pointing the direction the light travels. Check the arrow every few minutes. If the student is drawing from memory (looking at the page more than the object), go back to the modified-contour habit from Chapter 2: eyes on the object most of the time, a quick glance at the page to place the next mark.

When to slow down. If the seven-step scale still has a big jump after three tries, stay with scales and eggs for another week. That is not falling behind. Value is foundational, and it pays to have it steady before perspective.

When to go ahead. When the student can shade an egg with all five parts visible and can find the

core shadow on a new object without being told, move on. Value will come back in every chapter that follows.

When to find a human teacher. If your student wants to go further than you can demonstrate, for example into long charcoal studies or drawing plaster casts, a community drawing class is a gift, not a failure. See Chapter 10 for how to find one.

Keep corrections kind and specific. “The core shadow’s over here on the real egg. Want to find it on yours?” is always better than “that’s wrong.”

Tools, including AI

The physical tools for this chapter are simple: a desk lamp with a movable head, a dark cloth, an egg or a white ball, pencils, a kneaded eraser, a fine pen, and, at 13–14, vine and compressed charcoal with wet wipes and a bin. A grey card or a printed value scale can help at first; the student’s own scale is better once it exists.

For AI, the rules are in the AI box in *The Art Hour*, and they apply here unchanged: the student makes every mark, tools stay closed during the attempt, and any use goes on the whose-mark card.

One use fits this chapter well. After the student has done their own egg and their own squint test, you may prepare a “flat value” image as a find-the-problem object: a ball with an outline, even shading, and no cast shadow. You can draw it yourself, or generate one and check it before showing it. Label it as a looking object. It is something to diagnose, never a reference to copy.

You might also ask a chatbot to explain the five parts of light *to you* in plain language before the first lesson, then check the explanation against a real egg under a real lamp. The egg is always right.

What “done enough” looks like

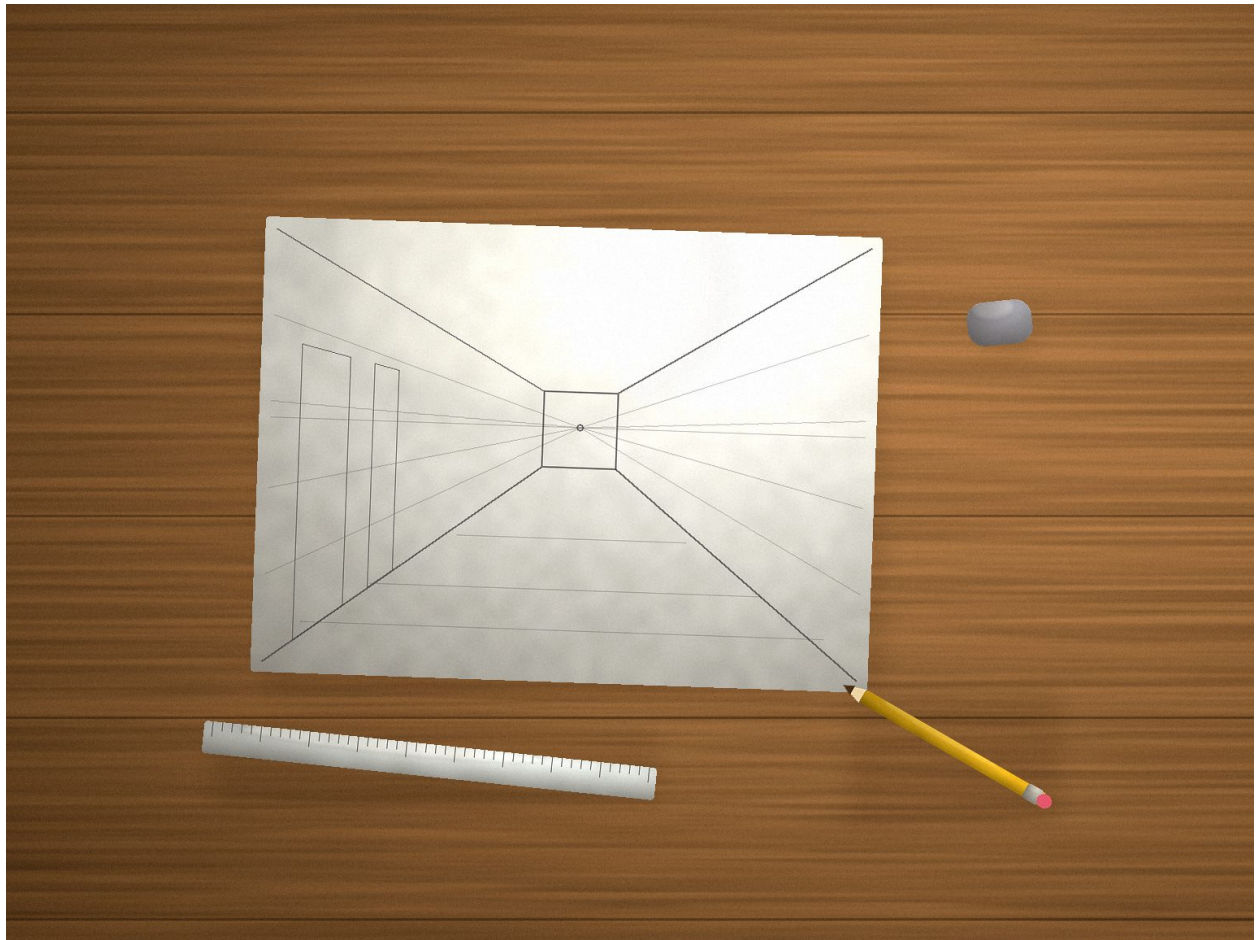
Before moving on to Chapter 4, check these with your student. They do not need to be perfect. They need to be steady.

- ☐ A seven-step value scale made without help, with no big jump in the middle.
- ☐ An egg (or ball) under one lamp, shaded with all five parts of light visible and labelled.
- ☐ One still life in at least three clear values: pencil at 11–12; charcoal, including one subtractive study, at 13–14.
- ☐ The student squints without being reminded, at least some of the time.
- ☐ The student can name the five parts of light from memory and point to them on a new object.
- ☐ One out-of-home value study (OUT-05), dated.
- ☐ Charcoal dust handled with the wet-wipe rule, every time, without argument.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice, and the student answered by pointing at the object.
- ☐ Ten-minute pages happening on most non-Art-Hour days.

Place by skill, not birthday. A thirteen-year-old new to drawing may spend five weeks here. An eleven-year-old who takes to it may be done in three. Both are on track.

Keep the value scale inside the sketchbook cover. It will come back when Chapter 4 asks which hills are farther away, and again in Chapter 5, when color turns out to have value too.

Chapter 4 — Space and perspective



Why this matters

Stand at one end of a long hallway and look down it. The ceiling slopes down. The floor slopes up. The walls lean in. The door at the far end is tiny, even though you know it is the same size as the one beside you. Nothing is actually slanting. Your eye is simply telling the truth about distance.

This chapter is about putting that truth on flat paper. **Space** in art means the sense of depth in a picture: near and far, in front and behind. **Perspective** is the set of methods artists use to show it.

Some methods are simple and ancient: put one thing in front of another, make far things smaller, place them higher on the page. Others are more precise and satisfying in a different way: a horizon line, a vanishing point, and a ruler, and suddenly a hallway opens up on the page and you could walk into it.

Eleven- to fourteen-year-olds tend to love this. It is realism with rules they can check. A one-point room is either right or it isn't, and the student can find out with a ruler without asking anyone. That independence matters at this age. So does the quiet pleasure of a drawing that finally looks the way the world looks.

Perspective is a convention, which means it is a method artists developed and passed on, not a talent some people are born with. The *Studio Thinking* researchers, who studied what serious art teachers actually teach, list perspective by name among the artistic conventions that students learn as craft.⁵ That is good news for you. A convention can be taught step by step, and you can learn it alongside your student in an afternoon.

Perspective also keeps the focus of this book honest. **See before you judge** means finding your actual eye level, not guessing it. It means noticing that a tabletop seen from a chair is not a rectangle. **Sketch before you polish** means ruling light guidelines first and darkening only the lines that belong.

A word on rulers. Some people feel that using a ruler is cheating. It isn't. Artists have used straightedges, grids, and measuring for centuries. A ruler is a tool, not a rule. Freehand sighting is allowed too. The point is to see the lines correctly, whatever helps.

What your student can try today: trace a street on a window with one eye closed and watch the lines meet. What you can learn this week: where your own eye level is in any room, and why every line going away from you heads toward it.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You do not need to draw a cityscape. You need to understand three ideas well enough to spot the common mistakes: eye level, vanishing points, and ellipses. You can learn all three standing at a window.

The everyday picture. Picture railway tracks running straight away from you across a flat landscape. The two rails are parallel; you know they never touch. But in your view they get closer and closer until they meet at a point on the horizon. That point is at the height of your eyes. If you crouched, the horizon (and the point) would drop with you. If you stood on a chair, it would rise. The horizon follows your eyes.

The precise picture.

- **Horizon line / eye level.** In a perspective drawing, the horizon line is the same thing as your eye level: a horizontal line across the page at the height of your eyes. Indoors you cannot see the real horizon, but the line is still there. Hold a pencil level at your eyes; everything it lines up with is on your eye level.

- **Vanishing point.** Parallel lines going away from you seem to meet at a single point on the horizon line. That point is the vanishing point.
- **One-point perspective.** When you look straight at the front of a box, a room, or a hallway, the front faces stay flat (horizontals horizontal, verticals vertical), and every line going *away* from you runs to one vanishing point.
- **Two-point perspective.** When you look at a box corner-first, there are two sets of lines going away, one to the left and one to the right. Each set runs to its own vanishing point on the horizon line. Vertical lines stay vertical. This is the rule students most often break.
- **Above and below eye level.** Things below your eye level show their tops (you see the top of a table). Things above your eye level show their bottoms (you see the underside of a shelf). Things right at eye level show neither.
- **Ellipses.** A circle seen at an angle (the rim of a cup, the top of a bowl) becomes an **ellipse**, a flattened circle. At exactly eye level, the rim flattens into a straight line. The farther below eye level, the rounder (fuller) the ellipse. An ellipse has rounded ends, never points.

Beyond linear perspective, the book teaches four simpler depth tools, which students often skip because they seem too easy:

- **Overlap:** the object in front hides part of the one behind.
- **Size:** things of the same real size look smaller farther away.
- **Placement:** for things on the ground below eye level, farther things sit higher on the page.
- **Atmospheric perspective:** faraway things (distant hills, a city skyline) look lighter, less contrasty, less detailed, and often bluer, because of the air between you and them.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear. Each has a usual meaning and a next question.

1. **Lines that are supposed to meet, but head to different points.** In a one-point room, the floor lines go to one spot and the ceiling lines go somewhere else. It usually means the student drew each line by eye without checking. Next move: “Every depth line goes to the one dot. Check each with the ruler.”
2. **Two eye levels in one drawing.** The table is drawn from above (you see its top clearly) but the chair beside it is drawn from straight-on. It usually means the student drew each object separately, from memory of what that object “looks like.” Next move: “Where is your eye level? Draw it as a light line first.”
3. **Tilted verticals in two-point.** The corners of the box lean like a falling tower. It usually means the student sent the verticals to a vanishing point too. Next move: “Verticals stay vertical. Check with a pencil held straight up.” (A plumb line, the student can check against the page edge.)
4. **Pointed “football” ellipses.** The cup rim comes to sharp points at each end. It usually means the student drew two curves meeting instead of one continuous oval. Next move: “Ellipses are round at the ends. Draw it in one looping motion, lightly, several times.”
5. **Everything in a row along the bottom edge.** Three objects sit side by side on the page floor, same size, no overlap. It usually means the student has not yet used any depth tool. Next move: SPC-01, the overlap–size–placement page below.

A sixth one, which you met in Chapter 2: the **rectangle tabletop**. A table seen from a chair is drawn as a perfect rectangle, because that is what we *know* a table is. Research on adult drawing

suggests that this kind of error comes mostly from misperceiving the object, knowledge crowding out what the eye actually sees, rather than from the hand.¹ The fix is measuring: hold a pencil level, compare the angle of the table's far edge, and draw the trapezoid you actually see.

Your five-minute warm-up. Stand at a window with a view of a building, a street, or even a fence. Close one eye. Keep your head still (rest your chin on your hand or a stack of books on the sill). With a dry-erase marker, trace three or four edges of the building that go away from you. Now step back and look at the glass. Extend the lines lightly. They meet, or nearly meet, at a point. Hold a pencil level at your eye: that point is at your eye level. Wipe the glass with a damp cloth. You now understand perspective better than most adults.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. Two to four Art Hours with the usual five beats, the ten-minute page on other days, and one out-of-home perspective walk this week or next. Friday: sketchbook review (the student tabs three pages) and a short check (one small room in one-point, or a box from life in two-point at 13–14).

The first try-it. Start with the Overlap–Size–Placement Page (SPC-01, described in Practice below). It takes fifteen minutes and reminds everyone that depth does not begin with a ruler. Then, in the same hour or the next:

- **11–12:** the One-Point Hallway (SPC-03).
- **13–14:** the Cardboard Box Two-Point from Life (SPC-04), after a quick one-point review.

Exact words for the See beat (one-point). Stand with your student at the end of a real hallway, or at the doorway of a room, looking straight in.

“Hold your pencil level at your eyes, like a tiny shelf. What does it line up with on the far wall?”

“That’s your eye level. Now look at where the ceiling meets the wall on the left. Which way does that line go as it goes away from you?”

“And the floor line on the same side?”

“If those lines kept going, where would they meet?”

Let them point. It will be roughly straight ahead, at eye level. That is the vanishing point.

The Sketch beat. Two quick thumbnails of the hallway, freehand, no ruler: one horizon line, one dot, a few lines to the dot. Ugly is fine. These decide where the eye level sits on the page. Low eye level makes a tall, looming room; high eye level makes a room you seem to look down into.

The Make beat (one-point hallway). On sketchbook or drawing paper, with a ruler and a light pencil:

1. Draw a light horizontal line across the page. That is the horizon, your eye level.
2. Put one dot on it. That is the vanishing point.
3. Draw a rectangle around the dot. That is the far wall of the hallway.

4. From each corner of the rectangle, rule a light line out toward the page corners, lining up with the dot. Those are where the walls meet the floor and ceiling.
5. Add a door on one side wall: its vertical edges are vertical; its top and bottom edges run to the dot.
6. Add a window on the other side, the same way.
7. Darken only the lines that belong. Erase or leave the light guidelines; both are fine.

Exact words during the Make beat. Keep them few.

“Every depth line goes to the dot.”

“Check it with the ruler.”

“Verticals stay vertical.”

One good question. When the room is roughed in, ask: “Where would a person standing in the doorway at the far end come up to on your horizon line?” This question sneaks in a big idea: in a drawing where the eye level is at standing height, the heads of standing people on level ground sit roughly on the horizon line, near or far. Let the student test it. It is surprising and fun, and it is the kind of thing an artist figures out by looking, not by being told.

The Make beat (two-point box, 13–14). Put a cardboard box on the table so a corner points toward the student. Their eye should be above the box, so they can see its top.

1. Find eye level: pencil held level at the eye. Draw a light horizon line on the page at about that height relative to the box.
2. Draw the front vertical corner of the box first, as a single vertical line.
3. Sight the angle of the bottom-left edge with a pencil held horizontally, as in the angle-sighting drill from Chapter 2. Draw it, and extend it lightly until it hits the horizon line. That is the left vanishing point. Do the same on the right.
4. The vanishing points will often land off the page. That is normal. Tape the paper to a larger sheet or to the table with masking tape, and put the vanishing points there.
5. Build the rest of the box: every edge going left runs to the left point; every edge going right runs to the right point; every vertical stays vertical.
6. Compare the drawing to the real box. Squint. Adjust.

How to fade your help. Day one, you ask every question and hold the ruler steady if they want. Day two, you ask only “Where’s your eye level?” Day three, you say nothing until the Talk beat. The moment the student checks their own lines with the ruler without being asked, stop pointing at the vanishing point. That is the real sign of learning.

When to stop talking. While they rule lines. Perspective looks like it needs constant correction; it does not. A wrong line is easy to find later, and finding it themselves is the lesson.

The rescue order, and one strong temptation. Perspective is the chapter where parents most often take over. You see the line going wrong, you know how to fix it, and before you know it you are holding the pencil. Use the house order: ask, wait, give a hint, then a short demonstration on separate demo paper, then hand the pencil back. Never on their page. If you catch yourself drawing on their drawing, say so, cheerfully: “I just drew on your page. That’s yours. Let me show you on scrap instead.” That sentence is a gift. It tells your student that their page is theirs.

Band moves

11–12. Overlap, size, and placement; atmospheric hills; one-point rooms and hallways; ellipses at and just below eye level. Rulers welcome. Sighting with a locked arm for proportions (from Chapter 2). The two-point box can be introduced as a looking exercise (“see how the corner has two sets of lines?”) without requiring a finished drawing.

13–14. Two-point from life (the real box, then a real street corner). Angle sighting. Ellipses at several heights. Vanishing points off the page. A cityscape or streetscape from observation, drawn on site or from the student’s own photo with the source credited. Foreshortening attempts (a book held tilted toward you, a shoe from the toe end) as studies, where a little distortion is expected and fine.

Ready 12. A twelve-year-old who has a correct one-point room and wants more may try the two-point box at 13–14 rules. Place by skill, not birthday.

Practice that actually builds learning

Practice in this chapter runs from simple depth tools to linear perspective, then back out into the world. **Blocked** practice first (three one-point rooms in a row). **Mixed** practice after (a real street corner, where the student has to decide which system applies). Short retrieval along the way (“Where’s the horizon in a drawing? What happens to verticals in two-point?”). And one incorrect example with a planted error.

In-home — Overlap–Size–Placement Page (SPC-01)

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil, sketchbook, three objects (a mug, an apple, a book)
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Three panels, three ways to fake depth, and a vote on which works best.
- **The skill:** Understanding that depth has several causes; composing with depth in mind.

Steps. Divide a page into three panels. In the first, draw the three objects using **overlap** only: each partly in front of the next, all the same size. In the second, **size** only: no overlap, one object drawn much smaller. In the third, **placement** only: no overlap, same size, one object placed higher on the page. Then ask the student which panel reads deepest.

Stuck → move. All three objects in a row: “Move one object farther back on the real table and look again.”

Exit. Three panels; one sentence naming which reads deepest and why.

In-home — Atmospheric Hills (SPC-02)

- **Time:** 20 minutes
- **Materials:** Watercolor or diluted acrylic (AP-labelled for grade 6 and below; see the safety spine)¹⁰, brush, water jar, heavier paper

- **Mess / safety:** Low to medium; water cleanup only; food off the table
- **The fun:** It looks like a real landscape in twenty minutes.
- **The skill:** Showing distance with value, detail, and color strength.

Steps. Paint four bands of hills, one above another, from nearest (at the bottom) to farthest (at the top). Each farther band is lighter, less intense, bluer or greyer, and less detailed than the one in front of it. Paint the farthest band first and let it dry.

Stuck → **move.** All bands the same strength: “Add water for each farther band.” Too much detail far away: “Farther means simpler.”

Exit. Painted strip and one sentence about what changed from front to back.

In-home — One-Point Hallway (SPC-03)

- **Time:** 25–30 minutes
- **Materials:** Ruler, pencil, eraser, paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** It looks like a stage set. Students often add their own details: a rug, a picture on the wall, a cat.
- **The skill:** Horizon line, vanishing point, depth lines, doors and windows in one-point.

Steps are in “How to teach it this week” above. Once the room works, invite additions: a rug (its side edges go to the dot), a picture frame on the side wall (top and bottom edges to the dot), a second door farther down (smaller because farther).

Stuck → **move.** Lines don’t meet: “Every depth line goes to the one dot. Line up the ruler with the dot before you draw.”

Exit. A room with at least one door and one window.

In-home — Cardboard Box Two-Point from Life (SPC-04), 13–14 and ready 12

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** A real cardboard box at a corner view; pencil; long ruler; masking tape; a larger sheet for vanishing points off the page
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** The drawing looks like the box. That is surprisingly thrilling.
- **The skill:** Two-point from observation; sighting angles; vertical discipline.

Steps are in “How to teach it this week” above.

Stuck → **move.** Box looks tilted: “Verticals stay vertical. Hold your pencil straight up and check.” Vanishing points too close together (the box looks stretched): “Sight the angles again. Your points are probably far apart, maybe off the page.”

Exit. Box from life, with both vanishing points marked (on the page or the taped extension).

In-home — Window Trace (SPC-05)

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Dry-erase marker; a window with a view of a building, street, fence, or even a long table indoors; damp cloth
- **Mess / safety:** Low. Test the marker on a corner of the glass first. No climbing on sills.
- **The fun:** Drawing directly on the world.
- **The skill:** Seeing convergence with your own eyes; finding eye level.

Steps. One eye closed; head still (chin on a stack of books). Trace the edges of a building or street on the glass. Step back and extend the lines lightly. Find where they meet. Hold a pencil level at the eye to check it matches eye level.

Stuck → **move.** Head moves and the lines wander: “Rest your chin on the books and don’t lift it until you’re done.”

Exit. A photo of the trace, and the student names where the vanishing point landed.

In-home — Ellipse Rim Study (SPC-06)

- **Time:** 15–20 minutes
- **Materials:** Three cups or bowls; books to stack them at different heights; pencil
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Watching a circle turn into a line as it rises to eye level.
- **The skill:** Drawing ellipses that are round at the ends and change with eye level.

Steps. Set one cup well below eye level, one just below, and one right at eye level (stack books under it). Draw each rim. Notice that the low one is fullest, the middle one flatter, and the eye-level one almost a straight line. Draw each ellipse with a loose, looping motion, going around several times lightly before darkening one.

Stuck → **move.** Pointed ends: “Ellipses are round at the ends. Loop it, don’t stitch two curves.”

Exit. Three ellipses that fatten correctly as they drop below eye level.

Out-of-home — Architecture Perspective Walk (OUT-03)

- **Time:** 30 minutes on site
- **Materials:** Small sketchbook, pencil, a clipboard or stiff backing
- **Mess / safety:** Stay on sidewalks and out of the road; out of doorways and driveways; an adult with the student at 11–12 and nearby at 13–14. Draw buildings, not people who haven’t agreed.
- **The fun:** Once you see converging lines, you see them everywhere. Streets turn into drawing lessons.
- **The skill:** Finding eye level and vanishing points in the real world, where nothing is set up for you.

Steps. Walk a street with buildings, a long fence, a row of parked cars, or a covered walkway. Stop somewhere safe with a view down the street. Hold a pencil level at the eye and note what it lines up

with: that is eye level. Find two or three edges going away (a roofline, a curb, a row of windows). Sketch the street in ten or fifteen minutes. Mark the horizon line and the vanishing point.

Stuck → move. Can't find the vanishing point: "Pick two edges on the same side of the street and extend them lightly. Where do they cross?"

Exit. A street sketch with eye level and a vanishing point marked, dated, with the location in the corner.

If your family visits a museum, look for a painting of a street, a room, or an interior and do the same hunt with your eyes: find the horizon, find where the lines go. Check the museum's visitor rules before sketching.

Talk box

Opening (locked): "Where is your eye level — and what do the lines do as they go away from you?"

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Seeing:** "Where do they meet?"
2. **Measuring:** "What stays vertical? Check it with your pencil held straight up."
3. **Evidence:** "What happens to the rim when you look down on the cup? And when it's right at your eye?"
4. **Process:** "Which line did you draw first, and how did you know where the dot went?"
5. **Revise:** "Which part feels deepest? What would make another part feel deeper?"

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three before you speak. That pause is a habit borrowed from classroom research on wait time, not an art study, and it still earns its place.⁷ In perspective, the student often needs to check something (hold up a pencil, line up the ruler) before answering. Let them.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. They know something is off and do not know what, and they do not want to guess wrong. They are hunting for the word "vanishing point." Or they sense you have already spotted the mistake. Give them something to do instead of something to say: "Put your ruler on this line. Where does it go?" "Not today" is allowed; a perspective drawing will still be there tomorrow.

Don't say / say instead. Don't say: "That line's wrong." Say instead: "Put the ruler on it. Where does it go?"

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. Three one-point rooms in a row, over a week: a hallway, a bedroom with a bed (the bed's side edges go to the dot), and a room with the eye level placed low, as if the viewer were sitting on the floor. The student learns that moving the horizon changes the whole room, and the dot is always on it.

Mixed. A real street corner, or the view across your kitchen. Now the student decides: is this one-point (looking straight at a wall) or two-point (looking at a corner)? Are there ellipses (plates, lamp shades)? Are there objects above and below eye level? You only ask the locked opening.

Retrieval (two minutes, any day). “Where’s the horizon line in a drawing?” “What do verticals do in two-point?” “What happens to an ellipse at eye level?” Quick answers, then back to drawing.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not a real student’s work. Draw it on demo paper, carefully, with one deliberate mistake:

A one-point room drawn neatly with a ruler. The horizon line is across the middle. All the floor lines and ceiling lines run correctly to one vanishing point. But the door on the right-hand wall has its top edge running to a different point, well above the horizon.

Ask your student: “Something in this room is wrong. Can you find it and explain the fix?”

If they find it quickly, add a harder version next week: a two-point box with one vertical edge leaning slightly. If they cannot find the error, point to the area (“It’s on the right wall”) and let them check each line with a ruler. Keep the corrected version beside the wrong one.

You can also prepare an error image with an AI tool, as long as you check it yourself before showing it, label it as generated, and use it only as a looking object. Generated images often contain perspective errors of their own, which, oddly, makes them good practice, but you need to know where every error is before your student does. Chapter 8 returns to planted-error hunts as a progress check.

The ten-minute page this week

Suggestions for non-Art-Hour days: the corner of a room in two-point (13–14) or one-point (11–12); three ellipses on the kitchen table; the view down a staircase; a row of books on a shelf from one end. Dated, private by default, and checked only for existence unless your student invites you to look.

For the student

This section is for you.

Perspective is how artists make flat paper look deep. It is a method, not a gift. Once you understand three ideas, you can check your own drawing with a ruler and know if it is right.

Idea 1: The horizon line is your eye level. Hold your pencil level at your eyes, like a tiny shelf. Whatever it lines up with is on your eye level. In a drawing, the horizon line is a horizontal line at that height. If you sit down, it drops. If you stand on a chair, it rises.

Idea 2: Lines going away from you meet at a vanishing point on the horizon. Railway tracks never touch in real life, but in your view they meet in the distance. That meeting point is the vanishing point.

Idea 3: Verticals stay vertical. Door edges, wall corners, table legs: in most drawings at this level, they go straight up and down.

A tiny worked example: a one-point hallway.

1. Draw a light horizontal line across the page. That is your horizon.
2. Put one dot on it. That is your vanishing point.
3. Draw a rectangle around the dot. That is the far wall.
4. From each corner of the rectangle, rule a line toward the page corners, lined up with the dot. Those are the edges of the floor and ceiling.
5. Add a door: vertical sides stay vertical; the top and bottom of the door run toward the dot.

That's it. You just drew a hallway you could walk into.

Try 1. Draw the hallway above, then add a rug on the floor (its side edges go to the dot) and a window on the other wall. Check every depth line with the ruler. Do they all go to the same dot?

Try 2. Set a cup well below your eye level and draw its rim. Now stack books under the cup until the rim is at eye level and draw it again. What happened to the ellipse? (An ellipse is a circle seen at an angle. It should be round at both ends, never pointed. Your first few will look like footballs. Everyone's do. Loop the pencil around several times lightly and the points go away.)

Explain it back. Why does the horizon line in a drawing move when the artist sits down? Say it out loud or write it in the margin.

Challenge. Draw your own street, or the view from your front step, in two-point perspective. Find your eye level. Find a corner of a building (or a fence, or a parked car) with two sets of lines going away. Extend them to find the two vanishing points; they may land off your page, so tape your paper to a bigger sheet. Keep every vertical vertical. It will take more than one try.

A few honest notes. Perspective can feel fussy at first. Your first room might have lines that miss the dot by a little. That's normal, and it is easy to find with a ruler. Rulers are tools, not cheating. Artists have measured for centuries. Freehand sighting is allowed too, and many artists use both. If someone tries to fix your drawing by drawing on it, you are allowed to say, "Can you show me on scrap paper instead?"

Once you understand eye level, you will start seeing vanishing points everywhere: hallways, roads, rows of windows, even the lines of a bookshelf. That is your eye getting better. It does not switch off.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: Lines keep missing the vanishing point. The room looks warped.

Next move: Before drawing each depth line, line up the ruler with both the corner and the dot, then draw. If the line is already drawn, extend it lightly with the ruler to see where it actually goes. Most "missed" lines are drawn by eye and then left unchecked. One check fixes most of them.

Diagnostic 2: Two-point feels abstract. The student can recite the rules but the drawings do not look like anything.

Next move: Stop drawing from the rules and draw from a real box on a table corner. Then a real corner of a real room. Two-point makes sense when the student can hold a pencil up and see the angle for themselves. If that still does not land, go back to the window trace (SPC-05): it shows convergence in the real world, no theory needed.

Diagnostic 3: Frustration with rulers. The student hates rulers, finds them fiddly, or feels their drawings look stiff.

Next move: Freehand sighting is allowed. Try a week of loose, freehand perspective sketches from life: a street corner, a room, a staircase. The goal is correct convergence, not perfect lines. Rulers can come back for a finished piece. Some students love precision and some love looseness; both can learn perspective.

When to slow down. If one-point is not yet reliable, stay with one-point rooms before starting two-point. That is not being behind. It is building on something solid.

When to go ahead. When the student can draw a correct one-point room without help and can find eye level on a walk, move to two-point (at 13–14 or ready 12) or on to Chapter 5.

When to find a human teacher. A student who falls in love with perspective, cityscapes, or architecture may want more than this chapter offers. A community drawing class, a library book on perspective, or an urban sketching group that welcomes families can take them further. See Chapter 10.

Tools, including AI

The physical tools: a ruler (a longer one for two-point), a good eraser, masking tape, a dry-erase marker for window tracing, a real cardboard box, and a few cups. A clipboard for the walk.

For AI, the rules are in the AI box in *The Art Hour*. The student makes every mark; tools stay closed during the attempt; any use goes on the whose-mark card.

Two uses fit this chapter. First, you may ask a chatbot to explain two-point perspective *to you* in plain language, using a cardboard box on a table, and to list two common mistakes you should watch for. Then check the explanation against a real box. Second, as described above, you may prepare a planted-error image as a looking object, checked by you and labelled as generated. Never use a generated image as a reference to trace for a portfolio piece.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on, check these with your student. Steady, not perfect.

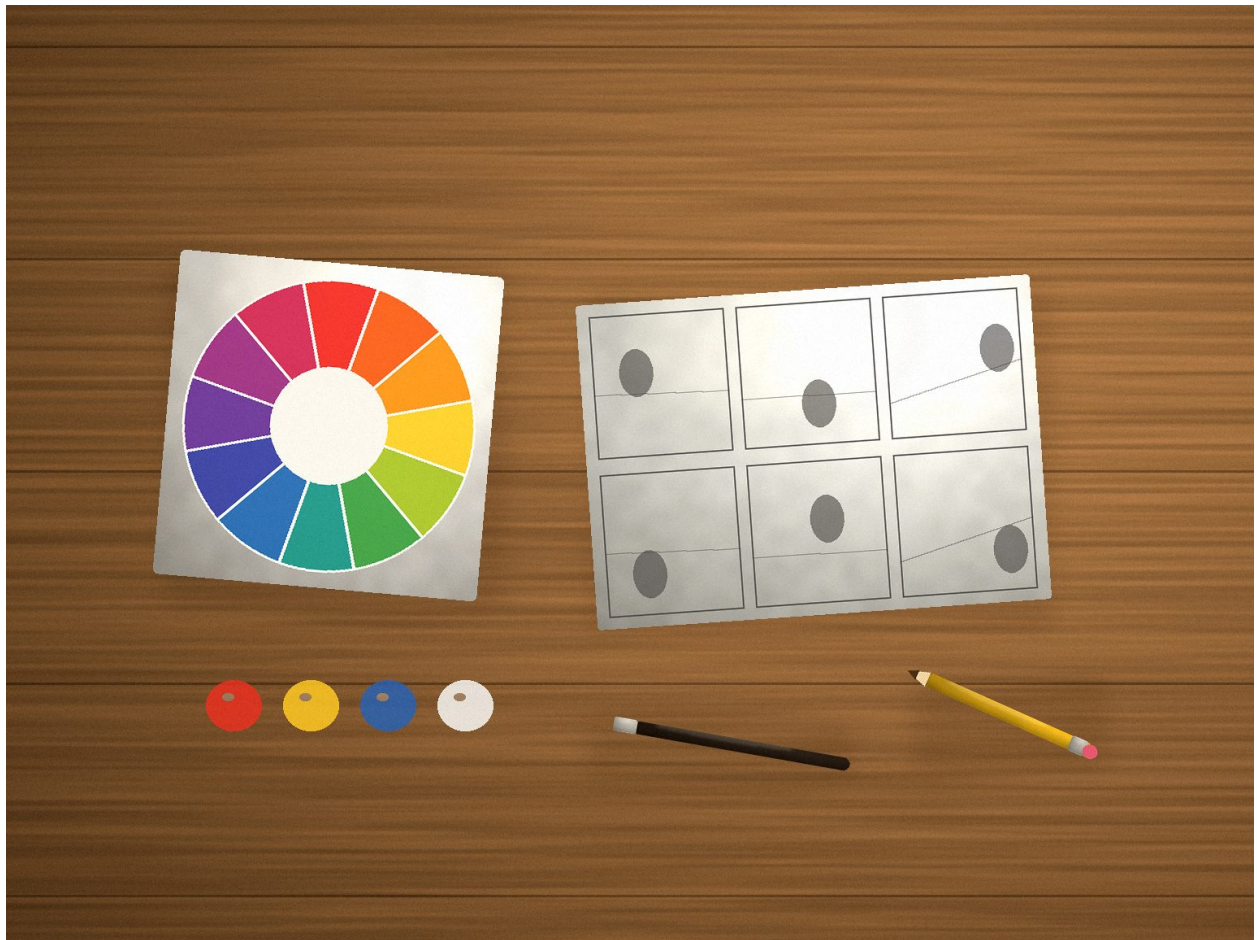
- ☐ An overlap–size–placement page, with the student able to say which reads deepest.
- ☐ A correct one-point room with a door and a window, every depth line going to one dot.
- ☐ Three ellipses that fatten correctly as they drop below eye level, with round ends.

- ☐ At 13–14 (or ready 12): a cardboard box in two-point from life, verticals vertical, both vanishing points marked.
- ☐ The student can find their eye level indoors and outdoors with a level pencil.
- ☐ One out-of-home perspective walk (OUT-03), with a dated street sketch.
- ☐ One planted-error example found and explained.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice.
- ☐ Ten-minute pages happening on most non-Art-Hour days.
- ☐ No drawing on the student's page by anyone but the student.

Place by skill, not birthday. A thirteen-year-old new to drawing may do one-point for a month before two-point makes sense. An eleven-year-old may race to two-point in a week. Both are fine.

The value scale from Chapter 3 comes along: distant hills are lighter, and a two-point box under a lamp has three values on its three faces. Chapter 5 will add color, and the same squint.

Chapter 5 — Color and design



Why this matters

Squeeze out a red, a yellow, and a blue. Mix a little red into the yellow. You get orange, which everybody expects. Now try a different red, one that leans slightly toward purple, with a yellow that leans slightly toward green. The orange that comes out is duller, browner, quieter. Same “red,” same “yellow,” different result.

That small surprise is where this chapter begins. Color is not a list of names. It is a set of relation-

ships you can mix, test, and control. At eleven to fourteen, students are ready to stop grabbing the tube that seems closest and start *making* the color they see. A student who can match the skin of a pear on a palette is doing something real and measurable. It is closer to careful observation than to magic.

The second half of the chapter is **design**, which here means **composition**: how the parts of a picture are arranged, and where the viewer's eye goes first. A poster where every word is the same size, a drawing where the subject sits dead center every time, a painting where every color shouts at full strength: these are design problems, and they have design solutions. Emphasis, balance, a path for the eye, a clear order of importance. These are decisions, and decisions can be practiced with small, cheap thumbnails before anyone touches the good paper.

Color and design belong together in one chapter because both are about **choice on purpose**. The focus of this book fits neatly. **See before you judge**: mix a swatch and hold it against the real object before deciding it's right. **Sketch before you polish**: six thumbnails before the final layout.

Color mixing is also a convention in the same sense that perspective is: something artists have developed and passed on as craft. The *Studio Thinking* researchers, who studied what serious art teachers actually teach, name "color mixing" alongside perspective among the conventions students learn.⁵ You do not need an artist's eye to teach it. You need three primaries, white, a clean water jar, and patience with a little mud along the way.

One thing this chapter leaves out on purpose. You may have seen charts claiming that particular colors produce particular feelings or behaviors. This book does not make those claims. What we can see and test on the page is what a color does next to other colors: whether it looks brighter or duller, nearer or farther, louder or quieter. Meaning comes from the whole picture and from the person looking at it. That is plenty to work with.

What your student can try today: mix orange two ways and compare. What you can learn this week: how to dull a color without black, and how to spot a poster that doesn't know what it wants you to read first.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You do not need to paint well. You need three ideas about color and a handful about design, and one short warm-up with paint to feel them in your hands.

The everyday picture. Think about setting a table for guests, or arranging a shelf. Without thinking about it, you decide what the eye hits first: the flowers in the middle, the one tall vase on the shelf. You leave space around the important thing. You don't put five competing centerpieces on one table. That is design. And when you choose a tablecloth that makes the food look good and not garish, you are making color decisions. You already do this. This chapter gives it names.

The precise picture: color. Every color has three qualities.

- **Hue**: the color family: red, orange, yellow, green, blue, violet, and everything between.
- **Value**: how light or dark it is. This is the same value from Chapter 3. Yellow is naturally light; violet is naturally dark. Squint at a painting, or take a black-and-white photo of it, and

you see its values. Many “color problems” are really value problems.

- **Intensity** (also called saturation): how bright or dull it is. A fire-truck red is high-intensity. A brick red is lower. A grey-brown is very low.

And three ways to change a color:

- **Tint:** add white. Lighter, often softer.
- **Shade:** add black. Darker. Use very little; black overpowers quickly and can shift some colors (yellow plus black tends to go greenish).
- **Tone:** add grey. Duller, same general value.

Then the idea that unlocks most mixing: **complements**. On a color wheel, each color has an opposite: red and green, blue and orange, yellow and violet. Adding a little of the complement dulls a color toward neutral. Add a drop of green to red and it becomes a quieter, earthier red. Add more and it heads toward brown-grey. This is how painters make natural-looking colors without reaching for black.

Finally, the **split primary** idea behind the warm-up. Each primary comes in versions that lean one way or the other. A red can lean toward orange (warmer) or toward violet (cooler). A yellow can lean toward orange or toward green. A blue can lean toward green or toward violet. When you mix two colors that lean toward each other, you get a clean, bright secondary. When they lean away, each brings a little of the third primary along, and the mix gets duller. That is why the two oranges in the opening came out different.

The precise picture: design.

- **Emphasis:** the area the eye goes to first. You create it with contrast (the lightest light next to the darkest dark, or the one bright color among dull ones), isolation (one thing with space around it), or placement (where it sits on the page).
- **Balance:** how visual weight is spread. **Symmetrical** balance mirrors left and right. **Asymmetrical** balance uses different things that feel equal: one large shape balanced by several small ones.
- **Visual path:** the route the eye takes through a picture, led by edges, lines, and value contrasts.
- **Hierarchy:** in lettering and posters, the order of importance. One big message, one medium, one small.
- **Pattern and rhythm:** repetition, and the variation within the repetition that keeps it lively.
- **Thumbnails:** small, fast sketches that test compositions cheaply. Six before a final is the house habit.

You may also see the rule of thirds: divide the page into a tic-tac-toe grid and place the subject near a line or crossing. It is one useful tool among several, not a law.

You may meet lists of “the elements and principles of art” presented as a national standard. Texas, for example, writes a specific list into its state art standards for middle school: the elements of art (line, shape, color, texture, form, space, and value) and the principles of design (emphasis, repetition/pattern, movement/rhythm, contrast/variety, balance, proportion, and unity).³⁴ It is a fine teaching list. It is one state’s map, not a national rule. This chapter uses the ideas that help your student make decisions, whatever list they appear on.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear.

1. **Mud.** Every mix turns grey-brown. It usually means overmixing, dirty water, a dirty brush, or too many colors in one mix. Next move: clean water, wipe the brush, mix small amounts, and add dark into light a little at a time.
2. **Every color at full intensity.** The painting shouts everywhere, and nothing stands out because everything does. It usually means the student hasn't yet learned to dull a color. Next move: COL-03, complement neutralizing. "What's quiet so something else can shout?"
3. **Subject dead center, every time.** Every drawing is a bullseye. It usually means centering is the default no one has questioned. Next move: the viewfinder crop hunt (DES-01), with one crop placing the subject on a third line.
4. **A poster with every word the same size.** The eye doesn't know where to start. It usually means the student hasn't planned a reading order. Next move: "Three sizes only. What's the one thing someone must read from across the room?"
5. **"Complementary colors vibrate," repeated as a rule without looking.** The student uses a slogan instead of checking. It usually means rules got learned before looking. Next move: paint the pair side by side and ask, "What do you actually see where they meet?" Sometimes the edge looks lively; sometimes it doesn't. Record what you see.

Your five-minute warm-up. Get out AP-labelled paints (acrylic, gouache, or watercolor), a brush, water, and scrap paper. Mix orange two ways. First: an orange-leaning red with an orange-leaning yellow. Second: a violet-leaning red with a green-leaning yellow. Paint a swatch of each side by side. Compare. If you only have one red and one yellow, mix orange, then add the tiniest touch of blue to half of it and compare. Either way, you have just felt the difference between a clean mix and a dull one. That is the idea your student will learn this week.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. Two to four Art Hours with the five beats; the ten-minute page on other days; one outing this week or next (the color-match walk below, or a museum color study). Color and design can easily fill two separate weeks; many families do color first and design second. Friday: sketchbook review, and a short check (one labelled mixing chart, or five thumbnails for one idea).

Materials and safety (a short point back). Use AP-labelled acrylic, gouache, or watercolor if your student is in grade 6 or below, and read every new label at any age, as set out in the safety spine in *The Art Hour*.¹⁰ Water cleanup only. No solvents, no oil paints in this book (they need solvent cleanup; *Art for Homeschooling* covers them for older students), and no spray paint indoors.¹¹ Wash brushes before acrylic dries on them. Food and drinks off the art table. Paint stains clothes; an old shirt helps.

The first try-it: Primary Triad Mixing Chart (COL-01). Set out a warm and a cool version of each primary (six tubes) plus white, a palette or plate, two water jars (one for rinsing, one clean), paper towels, and heavier paper. If you only have three primaries, the chart still works.

Exact words for the See beat. Put one piece of fruit (an orange, a lemon, a pear) beside the paints.

“Before we mix anything, look at this. What colors do you actually see in it? Not what it’s called, what you see.”

Let them list. There will be more than one: yellow, green near the stem, a brownish spot, a pale highlight. Then:

“Which part is the most intense? Which part is the dullest?”

The Sketch beat. On scrap paper, the student draws a rough color wheel in pencil (a circle with six segments) and labels where they think each mix will go. Two minutes. It is a plan, not a test.

The Make beat. On the good paper, paint swatches in a grid:

1. Each primary alone, at full strength.
2. Secondaries: each pair of primaries mixed. Try the “clean” combination (both leaning toward each other) and the “dull” one, side by side.
3. Tertiaries: a primary mixed with a neighboring secondary (yellow-orange, blue-green, and so on).
4. Label every swatch in pencil with what went into it.

Exact words during the Make beat.

“Mix small.”

“Dark into light, a little at a time.”

“Clean water, clean brush.”

One good question. Near the end, ask only: “What would dull that?” Point at the brightest swatch. If they answer “black,” that’s fine; say, “Try its opposite on the wheel instead, just a drop.” Watch them discover complements.

The design follow-up: Viewfinder Crop Hunt (DES-01). In the same week, cut a small window in a card to make a viewfinder: fold an index card in half and snip a rectangle from the fold with scissors. (At 11–12, you cut it; at 13–14, the student can.) The student holds it at arm’s length and moves it around a room, finding five different crops. Each gets a thumbnail. Then:

“Where does your eye go first in this one?”

“What would happen if you moved the frame so that thing sat off-center?”

How to fade your help. Day one, you name hue, value, and intensity once, and say the three short phrases. Day two, you ask only “What would dull that?” By day three or four, you should see the student reach for the complement unprompted. That is your cue to stop talking about mixing.

When to stop talking. While they mix. Color mixing needs trial and error, and some of the error is mud. Mud is information. If you rescue every muddy swatch, the student never learns what caused it.

Rescue order. Ask, wait, hint, short demonstration on your own scrap paper, hand the brush back. For color, the demonstration is usually one swatch: “Watch what happens with clean water and a tiny amount.”

Band moves

11–12. Mixing charts; tint–shade–tone strips; the warm/cool test; viewfinder crops; the balance see-saw with cut paper (scissors); a poster with three levels of hierarchy. Simple, labelled, and repeated.

13–14. A limited-palette still life (three colors plus white); complement neutralizing in full rows; color matching from life; visual path analysis of a real work; a color scheme chosen on purpose, with the student saying in words what they were going for. That last one matters: the student states their intention, and then the talk box checks whether the picture does what they meant.

Ready 12. A twelve-year-old who mixes cleanly and wants a bigger challenge may try the limited-palette still life. Place by skill, not birthday.

Color and value, together

Before leaving color, run one test that ties this chapter to Chapter 3. Take a phone photo of the mixing chart and switch it to black and white. Which swatches look the same value even though they are different hues? Students are often amazed that a bright red and a mid green can turn out almost the same grey. This is why a painting with lots of color can still look flat: the values are all the same. It is also why value-first painting works for every viewer, including people who see color differently. If your student has a color-vision difference, label the paints, lean on value, and never test color-naming as a skill. Mixing by recipe and checking by value works beautifully.

Practice that actually builds learning

Blocked practice first (three mixing charts, each cleaner than the last). **Mixed** practice after (a limited-palette still life, or a poster, where the student decides what to use). Brief retrieval (“How do you make a color less intense without black?”). And one incorrect example: a poster with no hierarchy.

In-home — Tint–Shade–Tone Strip (COL-02)

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** One color, white, black, grey (mixed from black and white), brush, paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low to medium; water cleanup
- **The fun:** One color turns into twelve.
- **The skill:** Changing value and intensity deliberately.

Steps. Paint a strip: pure color in the middle; tints stepping lighter to one side (more white each step); shades stepping darker to the other (a tiny touch more black each step). Below it, a second row of tones: the pure color with increasing grey.

Stuck → **move.** Shades go black too fast: “Black in tiny amounts. Less than you think.”

Exit. Strip glued in the sketchbook.

In-home — Complement Neutralizing (COL-03)

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Complement pairs: red/green, blue/orange, yellow/violet
- **Mess / safety:** Low to medium; water cleanup
- **The fun:** Watching a loud color calm down.
- **The skill:** Controlling intensity without black; making natural-looking colors.

Steps. Paint a swatch of pure red. Next to it, red with one drop of green. Then two drops. Then three. Repeat with the other pairs. At 13–14, extend each row until the middle turns a neutral grey-brown, and notice that the neutral from each pair is slightly different.

Stuck → move. Goes brown too fast: “Smaller additions. Half a drop.”

Exit. Three rows of at least three steps.

In-home — Warm/Cool Space Test (COL-05)

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Paint or colored pencil; a neutral grey or tan background
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** An experiment with no right answer.
- **The skill:** Testing a painters’ convention with your own eyes.

Many painters say warm colors (reds, oranges) seem to come forward and cool colors (blues, greens) seem to sit back. It is a studio convention, worth testing rather than assuming.

Steps. On a neutral background, paint the same shape twice: once warm, once cool, same size. Step back. Which seems nearer? Try again with the warm one duller and the cool one brighter.

Stuck → move. “They both look the same.” That is a real result. Write it down.

Exit. The swatch pair and one honest sentence about what you saw.

In-home — Color Match from Life (COL-06)

- **Time:** 15–20 minutes
- **Materials:** A piece of fruit or a vegetable (pear, apple, eggplant); paints; a small card strip
- **Mess / safety:** Low to medium; keep the fruit out of the paint and the paint out of the fruit bowl
- **The fun:** A swatch that disappears against the real thing feels like a magic trick.
- **The skill:** Mixing to match what you see; controlling hue, value, and intensity at once.

Steps. Mix a color you think matches one spot on the fruit’s skin. Paint a small swatch on a card strip. Hold it right against the fruit. Does it disappear, or does it stand out? Adjust: lighter or darker (value), duller or brighter (intensity), warmer or cooler (hue). Repeat for two more spots.

Stuck → move. Too bright: “Add a drop of the complement, or a touch of grey.” Too dark: “Add the lighter color, not white first.”

Exit. Three swatches taped next to a photo of the fruit.

In-home — Limited-Palette Still Life (COL-04), 13–14 and ready 12

- **Time:** 35–45 minutes, often across two sessions
- **Materials:** Three colors plus white (for example, a warm red, a cool blue, a yellow ochre or other earthy yellow); a simple still life under one lamp; heavier paper or canvas board
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; water cleanup
- **The fun:** A tight limit makes the painting look unified almost automatically.
- **The skill:** Mixing everything you need from very little; value and color together.

Steps. Start with a quick value thumbnail (Chapter 3). Paint the still life using only the three colors and white. Every color in the painting must be mixed from them.

Stuck → **move.** Reaches for a fourth tube: “Mix it, or leave it out.”

Exit. The painting, plus a photo of the palette at the end.

In-home — Emphasis Three Ways (DES-02)

- **Time:** 20 minutes
- **Materials:** Any medium; three small boxes in the sketchbook
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** Three ways to make one thing the star.
- **The skill:** Creating a focal point on purpose.

Steps. Choose a simple subject (a row of five cups, a group of stones). In the first box, make one element the focal point by **contrast** (darkest, or brightest color). In the second, by **isolation** (space around it). In the third, by **placement** (off-center, where lines lead to it).

Stuck → **move.** Everything shouts: “Quiet everything else.”

Exit. Three small studies, each labelled with the method.

In-home — Hand-Lettered Poster with Hierarchy (DES-05)

- **Time:** 30–40 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil, markers, ruler, poster paper
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** It gets used. A real poster for a real family event (a birthday, a bake sale, a backyard movie night) goes on a real wall.
- **The skill:** Hierarchy; reading order; planning with thumbnails.

Steps. List the information. Decide the one big message (what someone must read from across the room), one medium line, and the small details. Three thumbnails first. Then pencil guidelines with a ruler. Then letters. Then color, used to support the big message, not compete with it.

Stuck → **move.** All the same size: “Three sizes only.”

Exit. The poster, and the student states the reading order out loud: “First you read..., then..., then...”

More from the banks

Choose one or two of these for a second week:

- **Balance See-Saw (DES-03).** Cut paper shapes (scissors). Arrange a symmetrical composition and glue it; then an asymmetrical one that still feels balanced. If asymmetry looks “wrong,” balance one big shape with several small ones.
- **Visual Path (DES-04), 13–14 and ready 12.** Put tracing paper over a reproduction of a master work and draw arrows for the route your eye takes. Then plan a path for your own next piece.
- **Pattern and Rhythm Tile (DES-06).** Design a small square tile on squared paper. Repeat it four times, rotating it for rhythm. The edges must line up at the same points or the seams show.

Out-of-home — Color-Match Walk

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes
- **Materials:** A strip of card with ten to twelve painted or colored-pencil swatches made at home (a range of greens, browns, reds, blues); a pencil
- **Mess / safety:** Low. In a store, look without handling produce more than you’d buy; in a garden or park, stay on paths and leave plants as you found them.
- **The fun:** A hunt with a card. Nobody else knows what you’re doing.
- **The skill:** Seeing that “green” is dozens of greens; matching by eye in changing light.

Steps. At the grocery store, a garden, or a park, find a match for each swatch: this green matches the underside of that leaf; that brown matches the bark. Write the match next to the swatch. Notice which swatches found no match and why (too bright, usually; nature is full of dull, complex color).

Stuck → move. “Nothing matches.” Look for the closest, and note whether the real thing is lighter, darker, duller, or brighter than the swatch.

Exit. The swatch card with notes, dated.

Out-of-home — Museum Color Study

At a museum, sit with one painting for ten minutes. Where does your eye go first? What is the most intense color in it? Where are the duller areas? Note it in words or a quick sketch, using colored pencils only where the museum’s rules allow. Many museums allow pencil only in the galleries; check the visitor rules before you go. At home, try a small study of the painting’s palette: mix the five main colors you remember seeing, label them “study after [artist, title],” and compare with the museum’s image online.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “Where does your eye go first — and what did you do to send it there?”

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Seeing:** “What’s the most intense color in it? Where is it?”
2. **Evidence:** “What’s quiet so something else can shout?”
3. **Measuring:** “Squint. Where’s the strongest light–dark contrast? Is that the same place your eye goes first?”
4. **Process:** “Which thumbnail won, and why?”
5. **Revise:** “What would happen if you dulled that color? Or moved that shape off-center?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three before speaking. The habit comes from classroom research on wait time, not from art studies, and it helps here too.⁷ With color and design, the student may need to step back from the table before answering. Let them.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. The student isn’t sure their choices were choices, and “what did you do” sounds like a test. Or they are looking for the right design word. Or the question feels like it wants a verdict. Make it smaller: “Just point to where your eye lands first.” If the answer is “I don’t know what I did,” that’s honest and useful: next time, the thumbnail step will make the choice visible. “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “That’s too bright.” Say instead: “What would happen if you dulled it a little?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. Three mixing charts over a week or two, each with cleaner swatches and better labels. Then three tint–shade–tone strips with three different colors. The move repeats until mixing feels ordinary.

Mixed. A limited-palette still life (13–14) or a poster for a real event (both bands). Now the student chooses which colors to mix, what to dull, where the emphasis goes, and how the eye travels. You only ask the locked opening.

Retrieval. “How do you make a color less intense without black?” “What’s a tint?” “Name three ways to create emphasis.” Quick, then back to making.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This one is an illustration, not a real student’s work. Make it yourself on scrap paper: a poster for a pretend event.

BACKYARD MOVIE NIGHT, SATURDAY, 7 PM, BRING A BLANKET, POPCORN PROVIDED, AT THE GREEN HOUSE ON ELM STREET. Every line is the same size, the same color, centered, with equal space between lines. A small star drawing in each corner.

Ask: “Stand across the room. What do you read first? What should someone read first?”

Most students see the problem immediately: nothing leads. Let them redesign it with three thumbnails and three sizes: the event name big, the day and time medium, the details small. Maybe one color used only on the big message. Keep the before and after side by side in the sketchbook. The pair teaches hierarchy better than any explanation.

The ten-minute page this week

Suggestions: a tint strip of one color; three thumbnails of the same kitchen corner cropped differently; a notan (from Chapter 3) of a magazine layout; one object drawn with only two colored pencils. Dated and private by default.

For the student

This section is for you.

Color is not a list of names. It is something you mix, test, and control. And design is how you decide where someone's eye goes first. Both are choices you can make on purpose.

Every color has three qualities: **hue** (its color family, like red or blue-green), **value** (how light or dark it is, same as Chapter 3), and **intensity** (how bright or dull it is).

A tiny worked example: orange two ways.

Mix a red that leans toward orange with a yellow that leans toward orange. Paint a swatch. Now mix a red that leans toward purple with a yellow that leans toward green. Paint a second swatch beside the first.

The first orange is bright and clean. The second is duller, a little brownish. Why? Because the purple-leaning red and the green-leaning yellow each carry a hint of blue, and blue is orange's opposite on the color wheel. Opposites dull each other. That is the whole secret.

Try 1. Make a mixing chart. Paint each primary, then each pair mixed (the secondaries), then a primary mixed with its neighbor (the tertiaries, like yellow-orange). Label every swatch with what went into it. Some will go muddy. When one does, write down what you think caused it: dirty water, too much of one color, too many colors.

Try 2. Take the brightest color on your chart. Next to it, paint the same color with one drop of its opposite (red and green, blue and orange, yellow and violet). Then two drops. Then three. Watch it get quieter.

Explain it back. How do you make a color less intense without using black? Say it out loud or write it in the margin.

Challenge. Paint a small still life using only three colors plus white. Every color you need, you mix. It will feel limiting at first. Then you'll notice that the painting looks unified, as if it belongs together, and that is the point of a limited palette.

For design. Make a small viewfinder: fold an index card and snip a window out of the fold with scissors. Hold it up and move it around a room until you find five different compositions. Sketch

each one small. In at least one, put the most interesting thing off-center. Which one makes you want to keep looking?

Some honest notes. Your first mixing chart will have muddy swatches. Everyone's does. Mud usually means dirty water, a dirty brush, or overmixing. Mix small, clean often, and add dark colors into light ones a little at a time. If you see color differently from other people, that is fine: label your paints and lean on value, which works for every viewer.

You might hear that certain colors make people feel certain things. This book leaves that out. What you can test with your own eyes is what colors do next to each other on the page. That is where your decisions live.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: Everything turns to mud. Every mix goes grey-brown.

Next move: Two water jars (one to rinse, one clean). Wipe the brush on a paper towel between colors. Mix small amounts. Mix only two colors at a time for a week. Add dark into light, a little at a time, never the other way. If mud persists with watercolor, try gouache or acrylic, which are more forgiving for beginners.

Diagnostic 2: Every composition is centered. Every thumbnail has the subject in the middle.

Next move: Treat the rule of thirds as one tool: draw a light tic-tac-toe grid on three thumbnails and put the subject on a different line in each. Then ask which one feels most alive. Sometimes it's the centered one, and that's a real choice. The goal is that centered becomes a decision, not a default.

Diagnostic 3: "I'm not a color person." The student feels color is a gift they don't have.

Next move: Color matching is measurement. Do COL-06: mix a swatch, hold it against the fruit, adjust, repeat. Three adjustments later, it matches, and it matched because they looked and tested, not because of a gift. This is the same seeing-before-judging move as the rest of the book, with paint.

When to slow down. If mixing charts are still mostly mud after two weeks, stay with two-color mixes before the limited palette. It's worth getting clean.

When to go ahead. When the student can dull a color with its complement, match a real object in three adjustments, and plan a poster with three clear levels, move on to Chapter 6.

When to find a human teacher. A student who falls for painting may be ready for a community painting class, where an instructor can demonstrate brush handling you may not be able to. See Chapter 10. That is good news, not a sign you ran out of help.

Tools, including AI

Physical tools: AP-labelled paints (acrylic, gouache, or watercolor), a few brushes, a palette or old plate, two water jars, paper towels, heavier paper, an index card for a viewfinder, markers and a

ruler for lettering, colored pencils for outings.

For AI, the rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour. The student makes every mark; tools stay closed during the attempt; any use goes on the whose-mark card.

One use fits this chapter. A chatbot may suggest still-life setups from things you already own (a lemon, a blue bowl, a folded towel) or explain complements *to you* before the lesson. Generated color schemes or “palette ideas” are not assignments; the student’s own mixing chart is the palette. Never use an image generator to make a color study or a poster for the student.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on, check these with your student. Steady, not perfect.

- ☐ A labelled primary-triad mixing chart with secondaries and tertiaries.
- ☐ At 11–12: a tint–shade–tone strip. At 13–14 (or ready 12): one limited-palette still life, with a photo of the palette.
- ☐ Complement neutralizing done at least once; the student can explain how to dull a color without black.
- ☐ One color match from life, three swatches held against the real object.
- ☐ Five thumbnails for one composition, with one chosen and a reason given.
- ☐ One emphasis study done three ways (contrast, isolation, placement).
- ☐ A poster with three clear levels of hierarchy, with the reading order stated aloud.
- ☐ One out-of-home color outing (color-match walk or museum color study).
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice.
- ☐ Ten-minute pages happening on most non-Art-Hour days.

Place by skill, not birthday. Some students fly through mixing and need longer on design; others are the reverse. Both are normal.

The value scale is still in the sketchbook cover. Color turned out to have value too. Chapter 6 brings new tools, and every print and build will need a design decision before the first cut.

Chapter 6 — Cut, print, and build: tools with rules



Why this matters

There is a moment in printmaking that never gets old. You have carved a block, rolled a thin layer of ink over it, laid paper on top, and rubbed the back with a wooden spoon. Now you lift one corner and peel the paper away. For a second you don't know what you will see. Then there it is: your image, crisp and reversed, pulled from a block you cut with your own hands. Eleven- to

fourteen-year-olds often go quiet at that moment. Then they want to pull another one.

This is the chapter where new tools arrive. Carving gouges for printing blocks. Craft knives, at 13–14, for families who choose them. Air-dry clay built with slabs and coils. Cardboard, wire, found objects. These are real tools and real materials, and students this age are ready for them, with rules. Not a ban, and not a shrug. Rules, taught first, demonstrated back, and then trusted.

That order matters, and it is the main job of this chapter. Rules come first so that the joy can come safely after. A student who can teach you the bench-hook rule, count the tools back into the tray without being asked, and stop the moment a hand drifts in front of a blade has earned more freedom. You can sit beside instead of hovering. That trust is one of the quiet gifts of this age, and tools are one of the clearest places to give it.

The focus of this book fits naturally here. **See before you judge:** look at what the block or the clay actually did before deciding the print is ruined. Blotches and cracks are information. **Sketch before you polish:** a drawing comes before the carve, and a profile sketch before the coil. You cannot erase a gouge cut, so the sketch does the deciding.

Printing and building also teach something drawing does not: working in reverse, planning in three dimensions, and letting a material answer back. A block prints backwards. Clay slumps if the walls are too thin. Wire springs. Each surprise is a small lesson in how materials behave, and working with materials is as much a part of art as drawing is.

What your student can try today: teach you the bench-hook rule and carve one line in a soft block. What you can learn this week: where the holding hand goes, why sharp tools are safer than dull ones, and how to run a tool count in two minutes.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You do not need to be a printmaker. You need to know the rules well enough to see when one is being broken, and to understand the basic process well enough to help when a print comes out blotchy.

The everyday picture. Think of a kitchen knife. Before you ever learned to dice an onion quickly, someone showed you where your other hand goes: fingers curled, knuckles guiding the blade, never in front of it. You learned the rule for the other hand before the skill of the cutting hand. Carving tools work exactly the same way.

The precise picture: relief printing. A **relief print** is a print made from a raised surface. You carve away everything you *don't* want to print. Ink sits on what's left. When you press paper onto the inked block, only the raised surface prints. The white parts of the finished print are the parts you carved away. And the print is a mirror image of the block, so any lettering must be carved backwards.

The block can be several materials:

- **Foam plate or foam sheet:** you press lines in with a pencil. No blade at all. Ideal for a first print.

- **Soft carving block:** a rubbery block that cuts easily, like firm cheese. Needs a gouge, but less force than lino.
- **Easy-cut or softer lino:** a middle step that some suppliers sell.
- **Traditional linoleum:** firmer, holds fine detail, and needs a sharp gouge and more control. Stiff lino cuts more easily if warmed gently.

A **gouge** is the carving tool: a handle with a small V- or U-shaped blade. V gouges cut fine lines; U gouges clear wider areas. A **brayer** is a small roller for spreading ink. A **baren** (or the back of a wooden spoon) rubs the back of the paper to transfer the ink.

A **bench hook** is a flat board with a lip on the bottom edge that hooks over the front of the table, and a lip on the top edge that the block pushes against. It holds the block still while you carve away from yourself, so your holding hand doesn't have to grip the block in front of the blade. It is the single most important safety tool in this chapter.

The rules, sourced. Federal guidance on relief printing says to avoid cuts by carving away from the body, using bench hooks, and storing tools with their guards on; to use water-based, non-toxic inks and water-soluble glues; and to warm linoleum only at low temperatures, with no open flame.¹¹ The same guide recommends metal-mesh or Kevlar gloves when using sharp tools or knives.¹¹ A UK art-teachers' professional body adds two points worth knowing: always carve away from yourself and away from your holding hand, and keep tools sharp, because a blunt tool makes you push harder, and pushing harder is how slips happen.¹² A public-library printmaking tutorial gives the same practical advice from the working side: use a bench hook, always carve away from yourself, start with light cuts, and warm stiff lino with a hair dryer.¹³

Tool ages are house rules. The federal safety guide gives no age for carving tools or craft knives.³⁵ The bands below are this book's practice rules, built from the sourced protocols above. Your judgment of your student's hands and attention comes first, and "not yet" is always an acceptable answer.

Tools with rules at a glance

This table is the detailed tool plan for this chapter. General safety (labels, solvents, dust, heat, emergencies) lives in the safety spine in *The Art Hour*; the key points are repeated only where a project needs them.

	11–12	Ready 12	13–14
Cutting paper and card	Scissors; rotary safety cutter	Scissors; rotary safety cutter	Scissors; rotary safety cutter; craft knife optional, only under the full routine (SAFE-03) with an adult at the table
Craft knives	None	None	Optional; adult at the table; scissors alternative on every such project

	11–12	Ready 12	13–14
Printing blocks	Foam plate, then soft block with gouge, bench hook, and an adult beside	Lino allowed, with bench hook and an adult beside	Lino with bench hook
Every gouge, every age	Bench hook; carve away from body and holding hand; holding hand behind the tool; cut-resistant glove on holding hand; guards on in storage; tools counted in and out	Same	Same
Ink and glue	Water-based ink and glue; AP-labelled if grade 6 or below	Same	Water-based; read every label
Warming lino	—	Hair dryer or warm spot; no open flame	Hair dryer or warm spot; no open flame
Heat for building	Water-based glue and tape; no glue gun	Same	Low-temperature glue gun with an adult (practice suggestion)
All ages	No solvents. No indoor aerosols. No home kilns. Water-based inks only. Poison Control 1-800-222-1222.		

Wrong answers you should be able to hear (or see). These are the five tool patterns to know by sight.

1. **The holding hand in front of the gouge.** The student steadies the block by holding it at the far end, with the blade heading toward their fingers. Stop the session calmly, every time. Next move: back to the bench hook; the holding hand goes behind the tool; rotate the block instead of moving the hand.
2. **The block chasing across the table.** Every cut pushes the block away, so the student grips harder and pushes harder. It means there is no bench hook, or the block isn't seated against the lip. Next move: seat the block against the hook's top lip before every cut.
3. **Forcing a dull tool.** The student leans their weight into a cut and the gouge skips. It means the tool is blunt, the lino is cold and stiff, or the cut is too deep. Next move: sharper tool, warmer block, shallower cut.
4. **Backwards lettering in the print.** The name on the finished print reads in mirror image. It means the lettering was carved the right way round on the block. Next move: the reverse-it test (PRT-04) before carving.

5. **A missing blade nobody noticed.** At clean-up, one gouge or one knife blade isn't in the tray. It means the count didn't happen at the start or the end. Next move: stop and find it before anything else happens. Then make the count automatic (SAFE-05).

Your five-minute warm-up. Before the lesson, sit alone with the bench hook, a soft block, and one V gouge. Hook the board over the table edge. Push the block against the top lip. Put your holding hand flat on the block *behind* the gouge. Carve one shallow line, away from you. Turn the block (not your hand) and carve a curve. Feel how little force a sharp tool needs. That's all. Now you know what your student will feel, and you will recognize a hand in the wrong place from across the room.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. This chapter usually takes longer than others, and slower is fine. A typical first week: two or three Art Hours with the five beats, the ten-minute page on other days, and a community studio visit sometime in the chapter. The tools come out only during the Make beat, and the File beat now includes a tool count and a studio reset every time.

The first try-it: the student teaches you the rule (SAFE-02), then carves (PRT-02). Before anyone carves anything, you demonstrate the bench-hook rule once, slowly, saying each step aloud. Then you hand everything to your student and say:

“Now teach it to me. Show me each step and tell me why.”

This is the heart of the chapter. A student who can teach a rule understands it. Listen for four things: the block seated against the hook, the holding hand behind the tool, the cut going away from the body, and the tool put down (guard on) before reaching for something else. If a step is missing, ask about it: “Where does your other hand go?” Let them repeat until they can teach it without prompting.

Exact words for the See beat. Put a finished relief print (from a library book, a museum postcard, or one you made) beside the soft block.

“Look at this print. Which parts do you think were carved away? Which parts were left standing?”

Wait. Most students figure out that the white is carved and the ink is the surface. If not, say it once, plainly.

The Sketch beat. Two or three thumbnails of a simple image: a leaf, a fish, a house, a single initial (reversed; see PRT-04). Bold shapes, few details. Then the student chooses one and draws it on the block in pencil, darkening the areas that will *print*.

The Make beat. The student carves. You sit beside them. Short phrases only:

“Show me where your other hand goes.”

“Away from you, always.”

“Shallow first.”

“Turn the block, not your hand.”

When the carving is done, ink it: squeeze a little water-based block ink onto a tray, roll it out with the brayer until it looks smooth and even, roll it onto the block in a thin layer, lay paper on top, and rub with a baren or wooden spoon. Lift one corner to check. Pull.

One good question. After the first pull, ask the locked opening (in the talk box below): “What did the block do that you didn’t plan — and what’s your next cut?”

Close the hour with the count. “Count the tools back in.” Every gouge goes back in the tray with its guard on. The student says the number out loud. You check it matches the number that went out. Then wash the brayer and tray with water, cover the ink, and wash hands.

How to fade your help. The step that earns independence is the student teaching the rule back without prompting. Once that happens, you move from hovering to sitting beside. Once the tool count happens without reminders for two weeks, you can be across the table instead of beside (at 13–14; at 11–12, an adult stays beside for all gouge work). The adult rules in the table above never fade.

When to stop talking. While they carve. Carving needs concentration, and a running commentary is a distraction next to a blade. Watch the holding hand. If it’s in the right place, say nothing.

When to stop the session. Any time a hand moves in front of a blade, a tool slips toward a hand, or a blade goes missing. Stop calmly: “Tools down. Let’s reset.” Talk through what happened without blame. At 13–14, after a craft-knife slip or near-miss, the knife goes away for the week and the student uses scissors or a rotary safety cutter; run the full routine (SAFE-03) again before the knife comes back. After a gouge near-miss at any age, re-teach SAFE-02 and go back to a softer block for a session. Stopping is not a punishment. It is exactly what careful artists do.

Band moves

11–12. Foam plate prints first, then the soft block with a gouge, a bench hook, and an adult beside for every cut. Collagraph plates. Air-dry clay: slab and coil. Cardboard relief cut with scissors or a rotary safety cutter. Wire bent with pliers. No craft knives. No glue gun; water-based glue and masking tape instead. Materials AP-labelled if the student is in grade 6 or below.

Ready 12. A twelve-year-old who has done soft-block carving well, teaches the bench-hook rule without prompting, and runs the tool count unasked may carve traditional or easy-cut lino, with a bench hook and an adult beside. Still no craft knife. Place by skill, not birthday.

13–14. Traditional or easy-cut lino with a bench hook. An edition of five. The lino mark sampler. A craft knife is optional, and only with an adult at the table and the full routine (SAFE-03); every project that could use a knife also has a scissors or rotary-safety-cutter alternative, and choosing the alternative is never a lesser choice. Assemblage with a low-temperature glue gun and an adult (practice suggestion). A community studio for a press or a kiln.

A student of any age who is nervous about tools stays on softer materials longer. There is no rush to lino.

Practice that actually builds learning

Blocked practice first: the sampler before the image, the practice slab before the box. **Mixed** practice after: a two-color print or a built piece from the student's own drawing, where they decide which marks and which methods to use. Brief retrieval: "Say the bench-hook rule in one sentence." And incorrect examples: a print with reversed lettering, a box with unscored seams.

The three safety routines

These three cards come first because they run under every cutting project.

SAFE-02 Bench Hook and Cut-Away Rule (both hands). - **Time:** 5 minutes, then at the start of every carving session - **Materials:** Bench hook, block, gouge, cut-resistant glove for the holding hand - **Steps:** Hook the board over the table edge. Seat the block against the top lip. Glove on the holding hand. Holding hand flat on the block, *behind* the gouge. Cut away from the body and away from the holding hand. To change direction, rotate the block, not the hand. Tool down with its guard on before reaching for anything else. Tools stored with guards on. - **Stuck** → **move:** Hand creeps forward during a long cut: stop, rotate the block, reposition the hand behind. - **Exit:** The student demonstrates the whole routine to you, and explains each step.

SAFE-05 Tool Count In and Out (both hands). - **Time:** 2 minutes, at the start and end of every session with sharp tools - **Materials:** A tool tray; a line in the sketchbook or a card for the count - **Steps:** Count gouges (and, at 13–14, knife blades) as they come out of the tray. Write the number. Count them back in at the end. Say the number out loud. - **Stuck** → **move:** One missing: stop and find it before anything else. Check the floor, the paper stack, the ink tray, the bin. - **Exit:** The count logged, in and out.

The count comes from the same idea art teachers use in schools: watch the distribution and collection of blades carefully so none leave the room.¹² The *Studio Thinking* researchers include caring for tools, materials, and space as part of craft itself, alongside technique.⁵ The count is not a chore added on to art. It is part of it.

SAFE-03 Craft Knife Routine (13–14 only; optional). - **Time:** 5 minutes to teach, then practice on scrap; repeated at the start of every knife session - **Materials:** Self-healing cutting mat larger than the piece being cut; metal safety ruler (the kind with a raised ridge that keeps fingers away from the edge); craft knife with a fresh blade; cut-resistant glove on the holding hand; a container for used blades - **Steps:** 1. An adult sits at the table for the whole session. 2. Blades counted out. 3. Work on the mat, never on the table. 4. Holding hand, gloved, flat on the ruler, *behind* the blade and away from the direction of the cut. 5. Straight cuts only, along the metal ruler. Curves are for scissors. 6. Score lightly two or three times rather than forcing one deep cut. 7. Knife closed, capped, or put down on the mat pointing away between cuts. 8. Blades counted back in; used blades into the container; knife stored. - **Stuck** → **move:** Rushing or pressing hard: "Score lightly twice." Hand drifts: stop, reset. - **Scissors alternative:** Every project in this chapter that could use a knife can also be done with scissors or a rotary safety cutter. - **Exit:** The routine checklist, initialled by student and adult.

These steps follow published school guidance for cutting tools: a cutting mat larger than the area

to be cut, straightedge safety rulers, the holding hand always behind the blade and the direction of cut, rotary safety cutters as an alternative, and a risk judgment based on age and ability.¹² The glove follows the federal guide's advice on sharp tools, mentioned earlier in this chapter.

In-home — Foam Plate Reduction (PRT-01), 11–12

- **Time:** 30–40 minutes
- **Materials:** Foam plate or foam sheet, pencil, two colors of water-based block ink, brayer, tray, paper
- **Mess / safety:** Medium, water cleanup. No blade at all.
- **The fun:** Two colors from one plate.
- **The skill:** Relief logic; registration; planning light to dark.

Steps. Press a simple design into the foam with a pencil. Print three copies in a light color. Press more lines into the same plate. Print the darker color over the first three, lining up the plate each time with a corner guide taped to the table.

Stuck → **move.** Prints don't line up: tape an L-shaped corner guide to the table and put the plate and the paper into it the same way every time.

Exit. A two-color edition of three.

In-home — Soft-Block Carve with Bench Hook (PRT-02)

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** Soft carving block, V and U gouges, bench hook, cut-resistant glove, water-based ink, brayer, paper. An adult beside at 11–12.
- **Mess / safety:** Medium. SAFE-02 before starting; SAFE-05 before and after.
- **The fun:** A stamp you made, printing clean.
- **The skill:** First carving; the cut-away rule in real use.

Steps are in “How to teach it this week” above.

Stuck → **move.** Hand in front of the blade: stop, move the hand behind the tool, re-demonstrate.

Exit. A simple carved block and three prints.

In-home — Lino Mark Sampler (PRT-03), 13–14 and ready 12

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** Lino or easy-cut block (about 4 × 6 inches), bench hook, V and U gouges, glove, water-based ink, brayer, paper, hair dryer if the lino is stiff
- **Mess / safety:** Medium. SAFE-02 and SAFE-05. Warm stiff lino with a hair dryer or by leaving it in a warm spot; no open flame, no stove.
- **The fun:** A page of marks that becomes a personal reference.
- **The skill:** Control; learning what each gouge does before carving an image.

Steps. Divide the block into six squares with pencil. In each, practice one kind of mark: fine V lines, bold V lines, U-gouge clearing, stipple (tiny dots), hatching, and a free-choice texture. Print it. Label each square on the print.

Stuck → **move.** Slips: sharper tool, warmer lino, shallower cut.

Exit. A printed, labelled sampler.

In-home — Reverse-It Lettering Test (PRT-04)

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** Pencil, tracing paper, a mirror
- **Mess / safety:** Low
- **The fun:** A puzzle that saves a block.
- **The skill:** Planning in reverse.

Steps. Write the word on tracing paper. Flip the tracing paper over and transfer it to the block by rubbing the back. Hold the block up to a mirror: the word should read correctly in the mirror. Only then carve.

Stuck → **move.** Backwards print already carved: that block becomes a lesson. Keep the print; redo the lettering on a new block with the flip.

Exit. A word that reads correctly in the mirror.

In-home — Edition of Five (PRT-05), 13–14 and ready 12

- **Time:** 20 minutes after the block is carved
- **Materials:** A carved block, paper, ink, brayer, baren or spoon, pencil
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; water cleanup
- **The fun:** Signing your work like a printmaker.
- **The skill:** Consistency; choosing; presenting.

An **edition** is a set of matching prints from the same block, numbered.

Steps. Pull six or seven prints, re-inking each time with a thin, even layer. Choose the five most consistent. A common convention is to write, in pencil, along the bottom margin: the number on the left (1/5, 2/5...), the title in the middle, and the signature on the right. The extras are “artist’s proofs” or practice pulls. If the student wants a card window around a print, cut it with scissors or a rotary safety cutter, or at 13–14 with a craft knife under SAFE-03.

Stuck → **move.** Inconsistent inking: roll the ink thinner and re-ink before every pull.

Exit. A numbered, titled, signed edition.

In-home — Collagraph Plate (PRT-06)

- **Time:** 30 minutes, plus drying overnight

- **Materials:** Stiff card, textured flat materials (string, mesh, leaves, torn paper, corrugated card), water-based glue, ink, brayer
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; water cleanup; cut materials with scissors
- **The fun:** Building a print instead of carving one.
- **The skill:** Texture and value in relief.

Steps. Glue textures onto the card. Brush a thin coat of water-based glue over everything to seal it. Let it dry. Ink and print.

Stuck → **move.** Parts don't print: textures too high next to low ones. Keep materials roughly the same thickness.

Exit. Plate and print, side by side.

In-home — Slab Box, Air-Dry (BLD-01)

- **Time:** 40 minutes × 2 sessions
- **Materials:** Air-dry clay, rolling pin, two wooden slats as thickness guides, a plastic knife or clay tool, a fork or scoring tool, a cup of slip (clay mixed with water to a thick paste), plastic bag
- **Mess / safety:** Medium. Wet-clean the table; no dry sweeping or sanding of clay dust indoors. Treat air-dry clay as decorative: keep it away from food and water.
- **The fun:** A lidded box that holds something real.
- **The skill:** Construction; planning in three dimensions; patient joining.

Steps. Sketch the box with measurements first. Roll the clay between the two slats for an even thickness. Cut five slabs (base and four walls) plus a lid, using a template if helpful. To join two pieces, **score and slip:** scratch crosshatch lines on both edges, brush on slip, press them together, and smooth the seam. Wrap loosely in plastic and let it dry slowly over several days.

Stuck → **move.** Seams crack: score deeper, use more slip, and wrap the box to slow the drying.

Exit. A box with a lid.

In-home — Coil Vessel from a Drawing (BLD-02)

- **Time:** 40 minutes
- **Materials:** Air-dry clay, the student's profile drawing of a vessel, slip
- **Mess / safety:** Medium; wet-clean
- **The fun:** Watching a drawing become an object.
- **The skill:** Building from a plan; checking against the plan.

Steps. Draw a profile first: the outline of one side of the vessel, full size. Roll ropes of clay (coils), score and slip them in rings on a base, and build up. Every three coils, hold the drawing beside the vessel and compare.

Stuck → **move.** Leaning: check the profile every three coils; smooth the inside to strengthen joins.

Exit. The vessel beside the original drawing.

In-home — Cardboard Relief (BLD-03)

- **Time:** 40 minutes
- **Materials:** Corrugated cardboard, water-based glue, scissors or a rotary safety cutter (both bands); a craft knife under SAFE-03 is an option at 13–14 only; paint in one value family
- **Mess / safety:** Low to medium
- **The fun:** Layers that cast real shadows.
- **The skill:** Value through actual depth; planning layers.

Steps. Sketch a simple design with three or four layers. Cut shapes (scissors for curves; the knife, if used, only for straight cuts along the metal ruler). Glue layers on top of each other. Paint the whole relief one color family. Photograph it with a lamp low to one side so the shadows show.

Stuck → **move.** Ragged cuts: scissors for curves; thinner cardboard; at 13–14, straight knife cuts on the mat with the ruler.

Exit. A relief photographed in raking light (light skimming across the surface from a low angle).

In-home — Wire Line Drawing in Air (BLD-04)

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** Soft craft wire, round-nose pliers, wire snips, eye protection when snipping, the student's contour drawing
- **Mess / safety:** Low. Eye protection while snipping, and snip with the wire end pointed down and away (practice suggestions). Curl or tuck cut ends.
- **The fun:** A drawing you can walk around.
- **The skill:** Line in three dimensions.

Steps. Start from a contour drawing (a hand, a shoe, a mug). Bend the wire to follow the line, using pliers for tight turns.

Stuck → **move.** Wire springs out of shape: work in shorter lengths; bend with pliers rather than fingers.

Exit. The wire piece beside its source drawing.

In-home — Found-Object Assemblage (BLD-05)

- **Time:** 40 minutes
- **Materials:** Clean found objects (bottle caps, spools, wooden offcuts, cardboard tubes), water-based glue and masking tape; at 13–14, a low-temperature glue gun with an adult (practice suggestion)
- **Mess / safety:** Low to medium. Glue gun only at 13–14, low-temperature, adult present, on a heat-safe mat.
- **The fun:** Turning a pile of stuff into a small sculpture with a point.
- **The skill:** Composition in three dimensions; choosing by shape and value.

Steps. Sort objects by shape and value. Make two or three thumbnail sketches of arrangements. Choose one with a clear focal point. Assemble.

Stuck → **move**. A pile instead of a composition: back to thumbnails. “What’s the one thing the eye should find first?”

Exit. The assemblage, with a title.

Out-of-home — Community Class or Open Studio (OUT-06)

- **Time:** Varies
- **Materials:** Local listings (library, community center, arts center, museum education programs)
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules and age limits vary; check them first. Kilns and presses belong in studios with instructors, not in kitchens.
- **The fun:** A real press, a real kiln, other people making things.
- **The skill:** Seeing professional equipment and technique; learning from another teacher.

Steps. Find a printmaking open studio, a ceramics class, or a family workshop. Go together at first. Watch before trying. Afterward, write one note about what was learned and file one piece or photo.

Stuck → **move**. Nervous: go with a parent and just watch the first time.

Exit. A note of what was learned, and one piece.

Firing clay needs a kiln, and this book keeps kilns out of the home at every age.³⁶ If your student wants fired ceramics, a community studio is the place.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “What did the block or the build do that you didn’t plan — and what’s your next cut?”

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Seeing:** “Which marks printed best? Point to them.”
2. **Evidence:** “What surprised you when you pulled it?” or “Where did the clay crack, and why do you think it happened there?”
3. **Process:** “What would you do the same way next time? What would you change?”
4. **Revise:** “What will you carve away next?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three before speaking. The pause comes from classroom research on wait time, not from art studies.⁷ After a first print, students often need a moment just to look. Let the print be the center of attention, not the question.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. Disappointment: the print is blotchy and they think it’s ruined. Or they’re afraid “what didn’t you plan” means “what went wrong.” Or they’re still looking. Help by pointing to something specific and neutral: “This line printed very clean. What about this area?” Blotches are information about ink, not a verdict on the student. “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “Oh no, that didn’t work.” Say instead: “What did the ink do there? What’s your next move?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. The sampler before the image; the practice slab before the box; three foam prints before the soft block. The student repeats the new move until it feels ordinary.

Mixed. A two-color print from the student's own drawing, or a built piece where they decide whether to use slab, coil, cardboard, or wire. You only ask the locked opening.

Retrieval. "Say the bench-hook rule in one sentence." "Why does lettering have to be carved backwards?" "What's score and slip?" Quick, then back to making.

Incorrect examples to diagnose

These are illustrations, not real students' work.

The backwards print. Make a quick foam print of your family's last name without reversing it. The print reads backwards. Ask: "What happened? How would you fix it before carving?" Then do PRT-04 together.

The cracked box. Describe or build a small practice box from two slabs pressed together without scoring or slip. Let it dry. The seam cracks apart. Ask: "Why did this seam fail?" Most students work out that the pieces were never really joined.

For the student

This section is for you.

This chapter is where the real tools come out: gouges for carving printing blocks, clay, wire, and at 13–14, possibly a craft knife. You are trusted with these tools. The rules are how that trust works.

The one rule that matters most: your holding hand lives behind the blade. Always. You carve away from your body and away from your holding hand. To change direction, turn the block, not your hand. A bench hook (a board that hooks over the table edge and holds the block still) is what makes this easy. Use it for every cut. Wear the cut-resistant glove on your holding hand. Put the tool down with its guard on before you reach for anything else. Count the tools out and back in.

Sharp tools are safer than dull ones. That sounds backwards, but a dull tool makes you push harder, and pushing hard is how slips happen.

A tiny worked example: the mark sampler.

1. Hook the bench hook over the table edge. Push your block against the top lip.
2. Divide the block into six squares with a pencil.
3. Glove on your holding hand, flat on the block, behind the gouge.
4. In the first square, carve a few thin lines with the V gouge, away from you. Shallow first.
5. In the next squares, try thicker V lines, a U gouge clearing an area, tiny dots, and crosshatching.
6. Ink it with a thin, even layer and print it. Label each square on the print.

Now you know what each tool does before you carve a real image.

Try 1. Teach the bench-hook rule to an adult, step by step, and explain why each step matters. If you can teach it, you know it.

Try 2. Carve and print a simple image: a leaf, a fish, an initial. If it has letters, write them on tracing paper, flip the paper, and transfer them to the block so they're backwards. Check in a mirror before carving.

Explain it back. Why does a bench hook matter? Answer in one or two sentences, out loud or in the margin.

Challenge. Make an edition of five: five matching prints from one block. Pull six or seven, choose the five most consistent, and in pencil write the number (1/5, 2/5...), a title, and your signature along the bottom margin.

Some honest notes. Your first print will probably be blotchy in places. That's the ink, not you: roll it thinner and more evenly next time. Your first cuts may skip; warm the block or make the cut shallower. Clay cracks if the pieces aren't scored and slipped. None of this means you're bad at printmaking. It means you're learning what the materials do.

If a tool ever slips toward your hand, stop, put it down, and tell the adult. Stopping is what careful artists do. No one will be angry. You'll reset and keep going.

If you're nervous about the tools, that's reasonable. Stay on the soft block longer. There's no rush.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: The gouge keeps slipping. Cuts skip, jump, or go off course.

Next move: Check three things in order. Is the tool sharp? A blunt gouge needs force, and force causes slips. Is the block warm enough? Stiff lino cuts much more easily after a minute with a hair dryer. Is the cut too deep? Go shallower and take two passes. If slipping continues, go back to the soft block for a week.

Diagnostic 2: Prints are blotchy or patchy. Some areas are thick with ink, others barely print.

Next move: Roll the ink out on the tray until it's smooth and even before touching the block. Roll the block in several directions with a thin layer, not one thick pass. Rub the back of the paper firmly and evenly, especially at the edges. Check that carved areas are deep enough not to pick up ink.

Diagnostic 3: Nervous about tools. The student doesn't want to carve, or freezes with the gouge in hand.

Next move: More foam plate and soft block. Let them teach you SAFE-02 several times before carving again. Clay and wire can carry the chapter for a while. There is no deadline for lino. Some students take a month; some take a year. Both end up in the same place.

When to slow down. Any near-miss means slowing down: stop, reset, re-teach the routine, and step back to a softer material or to scissors for the week.

When to go ahead. When the student teaches the bench-hook rule without prompting, runs the tool count unasked, and has printed a clean sampler, move to image blocks, editions, and (at 13–14 if the family chooses) the knife routine.

When to find a human teacher. A community printmaking or ceramics studio can offer presses, kilns, and demonstration skills beyond a kitchen table. A student who loves this chapter will get a lot from one. See Chapter 10.

If there's an accident

Keep a first-aid kit on the shelf in the art area. For a small cut, apply pressure with a clean cloth, clean it, and cover it; get medical care for any cut that is deep or won't stop bleeding. If ink, paint, or glue is swallowed or gets in the eyes, call Poison Control at **1-800-222-1222** (US).¹¹ After any incident, stop the session and reset before the next one.

Tools, including AI

The physical tool list for this chapter is longer than most: bench hook; V and U gouges with guards; cut-resistant glove; foam plates, soft blocks, and (for 13–14 and ready 12) lino; water-based block-printing ink; brayer and tray; baren or wooden spoon; air-dry clay and simple tools; corrugated cardboard; soft craft wire, pliers, snips, and eye protection; scissors and a rotary safety cutter; and, at 13–14 only if the family chooses, a craft knife, self-healing mat, and metal safety ruler. A tool tray for counting. Check labels on inks and glues as described in the safety spine: AP-labelled for grade 6 and below, and read every label at any age.¹⁰ No solvent-based inks or cleaners.

For AI, the rules are in the AI box in *The Art Hour*, unchanged. A tool might help you draft a supply list or explain the difference between easy-cut and traditional lino *to you*. It has nothing to carve. The block, the clay, and the cuts are the student's.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on, check these together. Steady, not perfect.

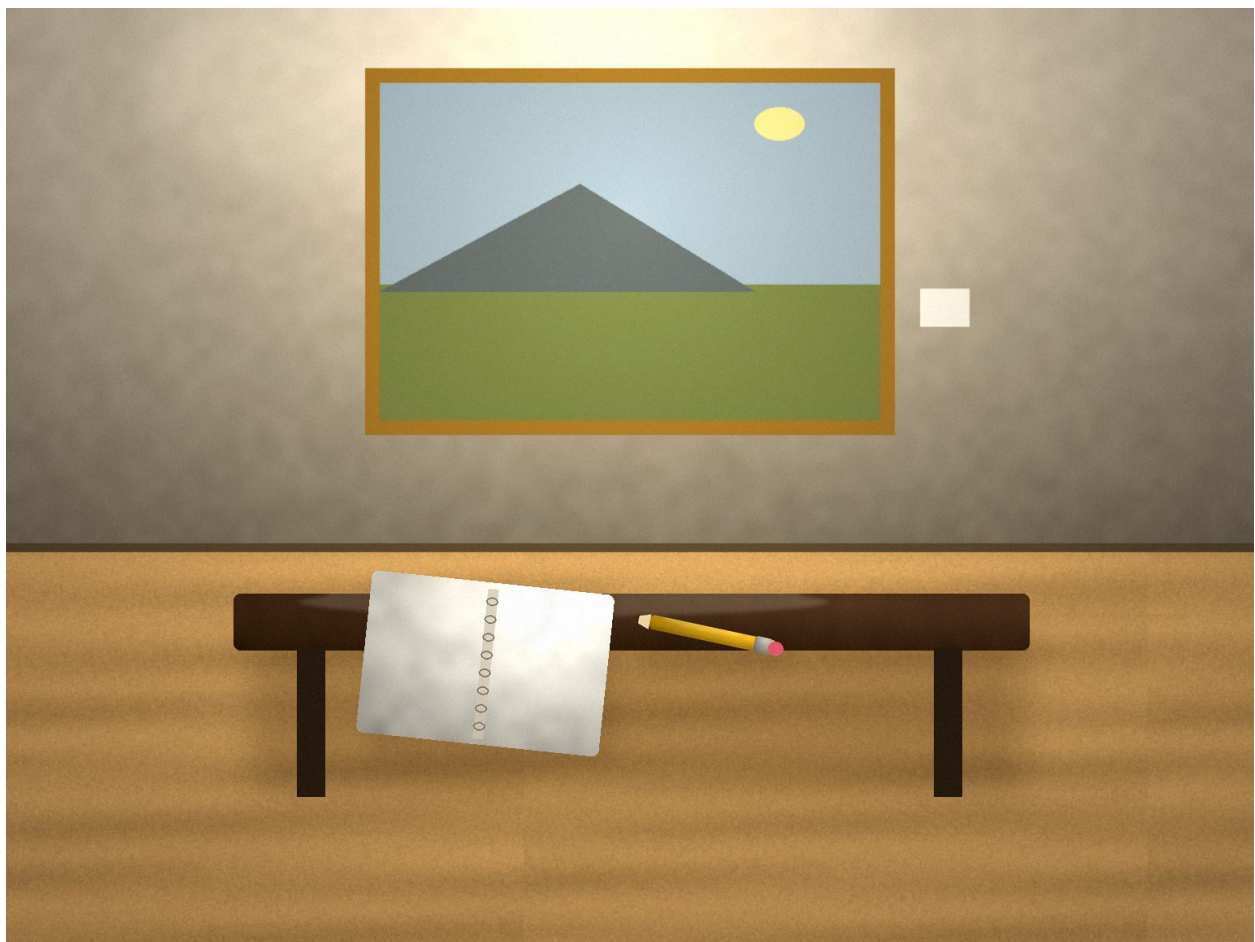
- ☐ The student demonstrates the bench-hook rule unprompted and explains why each step matters.
- ☐ The tool count (in and out) happens automatically, every session.
- ☐ A printed mark sampler (lino at 13–14 or ready 12; soft block at 11–12).
- ☐ At 11–12: three good pulls from a soft block. At 13–14: one edition of five, numbered, titled, and signed in pencil.
- ☐ The reverse-it test used before carving any lettering.
- ☐ One air-dry piece (slab box or coil vessel) built from the student's own drawing.
- ☐ One cardboard relief, wire piece, or assemblage.
- ☐ At 13–14, only if the family chose it: the craft-knife routine checklist initialled, and every knife project done with an adult at the table.
- ☐ No solvents, no indoor aerosols, water-based inks only, all chapter long.

- ☐ One community studio visit, if one is available to you.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice.
- ☐ Ten-minute pages happening on most non-Art-Hour days.

Place by skill, not birthday. Tool readiness depends on the hands and attention in front of you, not on the calendar.

Chapter 7 moves from making to looking hard at real works. A student who has cut a block will look at a woodcut in a museum very differently now.

Chapter 7 — Looking at real works and the language of critique



Why this matters

Sooner or later your student will stand in front of a painting and say, “That’s boring.” Or “I could do that.” Or, on a good day, just “Whoa.” All three are verdicts. None of them is looking yet.

This chapter teaches the looking first, then the talking. It is the focus line turned outward: see

before you judge. The habit that fixes a lopsided mug drawing (look, measure, describe, then decide) works just as well on a museum painting, a print in a library book, a sibling's lino block, and, in Chapter 8, the student's own portfolio.

Why does this come now, after six chapters of making? Because critique goes down easier once you've made things. A thirteen-year-old who has fought a cardboard box into two-point perspective looks at a painted city street differently. They know what it cost. And a young person whose own work has been described fairly is much more willing to describe someone else's fairly.

It also matters because this age is tender about being judged. Researchers who study adolescence find that young people react more strongly to being watched and evaluated than younger children or adults do.⁴ That doesn't mean they can't handle critique. It means critique needs a shape: description first, questions with no hidden opinion inside, and opinions offered only when they're wanted. Those shapes already exist. Teachers and artists have used them for decades. You'll learn three in this chapter, and none of them needs an art degree.

Art history comes along too, though not as a list of dates. It arrives as a few honest questions you ask about each work: who made it, when, where, out of what, and how do we know? A student who can answer those five questions about one painting, with a source, knows more real art history than one who memorized a chart. Art educators who studied serious high-school studios named this habit "understanding art worlds": knowing that art has a history and a community, and that you're joining both.⁵

Then there's writing. At 11–12, one good because-I-see sentence. At 13–14, a paragraph comparing two works, and eventually an artist statement in the student's own words. Writing about art is looking slowed down enough to check.

By the end of this chapter, your student should be able to stand in front of almost anything (a Dutch still life, a Japanese woodblock print, a bronze in a park, a mural on a wall downtown) and say what's going on, what they see that makes them say that, and only then what they think of it. It's a skill for life, and it works on the pictures in a phone feed too.

For the parent: understand it yourself

The everyday picture. Think about how you'd describe a movie scene to a friend. The good version goes something like: "It's a long shot of a kitchen. Nobody's talking. The kettle starts to whistle, and the camera just stays on the mother's hands." Your friend can see it. Then you say, "Best scene in the film," and the verdict lands because the description came first. The weak version is "It was amazing, you have to see it." That tells your friend about you, not about the movie.

The precise picture. You'll use three tools, and each one is built on that same order.

Visual Thinking Strategies (VTS) comes from museum education. It's a looking conversation built on three questions, asked exactly as written: "What's going on in this picture?" "What do you see that makes you say that?" "What more can you find?" Between answers, your job is to paraphrase what the student said, pointing to the spot they mean, *without praising or correcting*.⁶ That last part is harder than it sounds. "Good!" is praise. "Actually, that's a dog" is correction. "You're

saying the figure on the left is leaning away from the window” is a paraphrase. A paraphrase tells the student you heard them, and it invites more.

Feldman’s four steps come from art criticism and are widely taught in schools: **describe** (what’s there), **analyze** (how it’s arranged: light, color, composition), **interpret** (what it might mean or be about), and **judge** (what you think of it, with reasons).⁹ Think of it as a ladder. Judgment is the top rung, not the first step. Use it on finished work by someone who isn’t in the room, like a master’s painting or a print in a book.

Liz Lerman’s Critical Response Process (CRP) was devised in 1990 for artists sharing work in progress.⁸ It has four steps. First come **statements of meaning**, where responders say what struck them or seemed meaningful, with no fixes. Then **the artist asks questions** about what they want feedback on. Then responders ask **neutral questions**, meaning questions with no opinion hidden in them. Last come **permissioned opinions**: “I have an opinion about the shadows. Would you like to hear it?” The artist may say no. CRP is for living makers who are present: your student, a sibling, you.

Here’s how the three fit together. VTS is for looking together at anything. Feldman is for a finished work by someone else. CRP is for work by someone in the room.

Art history, plainly. For each work you study, ask five questions: maker, date, place, material, and *how we know*. The last one matters most. A museum’s own page for the object is a good source. So is a library art book. A confident sentence on a random website, or from a chatbot, is a lead to check. It isn’t a fact yet.

Neutral questions. A neutral question has no verdict inside it. “Why is the sky so dark?” sounds like a question, but it carries an opinion (too dark). “What were you going for with the sky?” or “Tell me about the sky” leaves the judgment with the artist. Most adults need a little practice at this. That’s normal. We were mostly raised on the other kind.

Choosing works to look at. Aim for range: different centuries, places, materials, and kinds of makers. Include paintings, prints, sculpture, pottery, textiles, and buildings. Choose works with plenty to see, such as a still life crowded with objects, a busy street scene, or a landscape with weather in it. Leave out works whose main subject is a live public argument or graphic harm. The point of this chapter is the looking, and there’s more than enough art in the world’s open collections to keep it there.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. “It’s ugly.” “It’s boring.” And that’s the whole response. *What it usually means:* a verdict came before any description. Sometimes it’s a polite way of skipping a hard look. *Your move:* “Maybe. Hold that thought for the end. What’s in the bottom-left corner?”

2. Reading the label first and repeating it back. “It’s a Baroque still life.” *What it usually means:* the label did the looking. The student is hunting for the right answer. *Your move:* cover the label (LOOK-06). Look first, read after.

3. A fluent fact with no source. “He painted it in one night because he was sick.” *What it usually means:* something heard somewhere, whether from a video, a friend, or a chatbot. Fluent isn’t the

same as true. *Your move:* HIST-04 Source Check. “Where can we check that?”

4. “My drawing” for a copy. A careful pencil copy of a museum painting, signed with only the student’s name. *What it usually means:* pride in real work, and no habit of giving credit yet. *Your move:* it is theirs, as a study. Label it “study after [artist, title, date]” (LOOK-04, WRITE-05).

5. An opinion dressed up as a question. “Why did you make the face so weird?” *What it usually means:* the speaker has a verdict and wants it heard. *Your move:* CRIT-05 Neutral Question Rewrite. Try “Tell me about the face” or “What were you going for there?”

Five-minute parent warm-up

Open one painting on a screen or in a library book. Pick something with plenty of things in it. Set a timer for five minutes and list twenty things you see. No opinions. You’ll run dry around item eight, and that’s where the real looking starts. Check the corners, the edges, the shadows, the thing behind the thing. When the timer goes, write one sentence that starts, “I think this is about ____ because I see ____.”

You’ve just done this whole chapter in miniature.

How to teach it this week

First try-it: LOOK-01 Five-Minute Silent Look, then LOOK-02 VTS Three at Home.

Choose one image. It could be a public-domain painting from a museum’s open-access collection, a plate in a library art book, or a postcard. Scenes with people doing something, or still lifes with lots of objects, are easiest to start with. Cover the caption with a sticky note.

Put it where you can both see it and say:

“Five minutes. We just look, no talking. Then we’ll each list what we saw.”

Look too, and really look. Your student can tell if you’re not. When the timer goes, trade lists. Then ask, exactly:

“What’s going on in this picture?”

Wait. When they answer, paraphrase and point: “You’re saying she’s about to pour something, from this jug here.” Then ask:

“What do you see that makes you say that?”

Wait again and paraphrase again. Then:

“What more can you find?”

Keep this going for ten minutes, or until the answers slow down. To finish, uncover the label and read it together (LOOK-06 Caption Last). Ask: “What changed when you read that?”

Exact wording to keep in your pocket.

- “Describe before you decide.”
- “What do you see that makes you say that?”
- “I have an opinion about that part. Would you like to hear it?”
- “Where could we check that?”
- “It’s yours, as a study. Let’s credit it.”

How to fade help. In week one, you ask the VTS questions. In week two, your student asks them of you, about a work they choose. (This is fun to watch. They’re often stricter than you were.) By week three, they run a describe-only pass on their own before you say anything at all.

When to stop talking. Stop completely during the silent look. Also stop whenever the student is mid-sentence and pointing at something. A pointing finger means seeing is happening, and your voice will interrupt it.

Band moves.

11–12. Use VTS, Describe Only (CRIT-01), Caption Last (LOOK-06), labelled master studies (LOOK-04), and because-I-see sentences (WRITE-01). Spoken critique goes better with a sentence frame: “I notice . ***I think*** because I see ____.” Model CRP on your own drawing first, so they see what it’s like to ask for feedback and get neutral questions back. Keep museum visits to one room.

13–14. Add the Feldman ladder in writing (CRIT-02), the two-works comparison (LOOK-05, then WRITE-04), Why This Material Then (HIST-03), source checks the student runs alone (HIST-04), and full CRP with permissioned opinions on a sibling’s work in progress or their own (CRIT-03 through CRIT-06). A ready twelve-year-old can take the two-works comparison early.

This week, honestly

- **Monday:** LOOK-01 and LOOK-02 on one work. A ten-minute page afterward.
- **Tuesday:** a ten-minute page (SKB-01). If you like, add three minutes of CRIT-01 Describe Only on whatever’s in the kitchen: a calendar picture, a tin, a plate.
- **Wednesday:** LOOK-03 Detail Hunt on a zoomable open-access image. Sketch one detail. Then WRITE-01.
- **Thursday:** a ten-minute page, plus a HIST-01 When-and-Where Card for Monday’s work, with a source.
- **Friday:** start LOOK-04 Master Study (it often takes two sessions), then SKB-06 review and one check: did this week’s talk put description before verdict? (That’s AS-05, in Chapter 8.)
- **Once this week or next, out of the house:** OUT-01 Museum One-Room Sit, HIST-05 Local Art Walk, or OUT-04 Library Art Book Hunt.

Many families don’t finish this chapter and move on. They thread it through the year instead: a museum sit every month, one new work on the timeline every week or two. That works very well.

One Art Hour, start to finish (illustration)

This is an illustration, not a report of a real family. A twelve-year-old and a parent sit at the table with a library book open to a still life.

See (6 minutes). Silent look with the caption covered. Each writes a list. The student gets to fourteen, the parent to eleven.

Sketch (8 minutes). The student makes a quick contour of the jug and the lemon, just to feel the shapes.

Make (20 minutes). They start a master study of one corner: the lemon peel curling off the table edge. Labelled at the top: “Study after...” with the rest left blank until the caption comes off.

Talk (6 minutes). “What’s going on in this work — and what do you see that makes you say that?” The student says, “Someone left in a hurry, because the knife is on the edge and the peel is hanging off.” The parent paraphrases, points, and waits. Then: “What more can you find?”

File (4 minutes). Uncover the caption. Finish the credit line. Date the page. Add one line to the timeline string.

That’s a complete hour. Nobody said “beautiful.” The student will remember that lemon for years.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it lists time, materials, mess and safety, the fun, and the skill. Pick one or two per Art Hour. Nobody needs all of them.

In-home try-its

LOOK-03 Detail Hunt (both bands)

- *Time:* 10 minutes
- *Materials:* a zoomable open-access image on a screen; sketchbook; pencil
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* zooming close enough to see a single brushstroke or a crack in the paint. It feels like being allowed to lean past the museum rope.
- *The skill:* slow, specific looking. Zoom in, choose one detail, and sketch it for five minutes. Note where it sits in the whole picture. If they keep scrolling without stopping, say: “One detail. Five minutes.”

The National Gallery of Art offers more than 60,000 images from its collection as free downloads. The Metropolitan Museum of Art marks public-domain works in its open-access collection with a CC0 designation, which means they’re free to use.^{31,32} Chapter 10 has more places to look.

LOOK-04 Master Study, labelled (both bands)

- *Time:* 25–40 minutes, often across two sessions
- *Materials:* a public-domain work (a print, a book plate, or a screen); sketchbook; pencil
- *Mess/safety:* low
- *The fun:* finding out how someone else solved the problem you’ve been fighting, like how they made glass look like glass.

- *The skill:* copy part of a real work carefully, as a study. Write under it: “Study after [artist, title, date].” Master studies are an old, honest way artists learn. They can go in the portfolio as studies, with credit.

LOOK-05 Two Works, One Subject (13–14; ready 12)

- *Time:* 20 minutes
- *Materials:* two images of one subject, such as two still lifes, two harbors, or two animals
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* it’s a spot-the-difference puzzle, except every difference is a decision somebody made.
- *The skill:* a T-chart of differences in material, light, and composition. If it starts with “I like this one,” say: “Three differences first.”

LOOK-06 Caption Last (both bands). This takes five minutes and one sticky note over the label. Look first. Then read the maker, date, and material. Write one sentence about what changed.

HIST-01 When-and-Where Card (both bands)

- *Time:* 10 minutes
- *Materials:* an index card; the museum’s page for the work, or a library book
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* detective work with a short answer.
- *The skill:* five lines: maker, date, place, material, how we know. If a line can’t be sourced, leave it blank. A blank is honest. An invented date isn’t.

HIST-02 Timeline Thread (both bands, ongoing). Use a string along a wall or a long sketchbook spread. Every work you study gets pinned in its place in time, with the student’s own study beside it. When the thread bunches up in one century, go looking for one work earlier and one later. Over a year, this thread quietly becomes the student’s own art history.

HIST-03 Why This Material Then (13–14; ready 12)

- *Time:* 15–20 minutes
- *Materials:* two works in different media, such as a woodblock print and an oil painting, or a fresco and a watercolor
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* thinking like the maker. What did the block let them do? What did it stop them from doing?
- *The skill:* one because-sentence, marked as a guess when it is one: “I think the printmaker used flat areas of color because a carved block prints flat shapes cleanly.” Writing “I think... because...” keeps a guess honest. Your student has carved a block in Chapter 6, so they have real evidence for this one.

HIST-04 Source Check (both bands)

- *Time:* 10 minutes
- *Materials:* one claim about an artist or a work, from a book, a video, a friend, or a chatbot
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* catching a mistake somebody made confidently.

- *The skill*: check the claim against the museum’s page or a book. Mark it “confirmed,” with the source, or “unconfirmed.” No source, no fact.

CRIT-01 Describe Only (both bands). Three to five minutes of description with no opinion words. When “pretty” or “weird” slips in, swap it for a noun or a measurement: “The sky takes up about two-thirds of the picture.”

CRIT-02 Feldman Ladder (both bands; fuller at 13–14). Fifteen minutes. Write four short lines, in order: describe, analyze, interpret, judge. If they jump straight to the judgment, go back down a rung.

CRIT-03 Statements of Meaning (both bands). Five minutes, on work by a sibling, a parent, or the student. Say what struck you or seemed meaningful. No fixes yet. Advice waits for step four.

CRIT-04 Artist Asks First (13–14; modeled at 11–12). The maker asks two questions about their own piece. “Is it good?” is too big to answer. “Does the shadow read as a shadow?” works. Chapter 8 uses this on the portfolio.

CRIT-05 Neutral Question Rewrite (both bands)

- *Time*: 10 minutes
- *Materials*: a list of loaded questions you write together
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The fun*: it’s a word puzzle, and adults are often worse at it than students are.
- *The skill*: rewrite “Why is the sky so dark?” as “What were you going for with the sky?” If a question still sounds loaded, cut the adjectives. Do three rewrites.

In a mixed-age house, this is a good job for the older student. The thirteen-year-old asks neutral questions about the eight-year-old’s painting. It’s a real responsibility, and it protects the younger child from verdicts.

CRIT-06 Permissioned Opinion (13–14; modeled at 11–12). “I have an opinion about _____. Would you like to hear it?” The artist may say no. If they always say no, that’s allowed. Ask again next week.

WRITE-01 Because-I-See Sentence (both bands). Five minutes: a claim plus evidence you can see. “The painting feels cold because I see blue-grey shadows and bare branches.” If the evidence is a feeling, ask them to point at the spot in the picture that gives them the feeling.

WRITE-02 Process Note (both bands). Three minutes, written on the day’s page: what I tried, what changed, what’s next.

WRITE-03 Artist Statement, Own Words (13–14; a short version at 11–12). Sixty to 150 words in the student’s own voice: what, how, and why. Start from their process notes, not a blank page. Chapter 8 puts it to work.

WRITE-04 Compare-Two Paragraph (13–14). Twenty minutes, built from the LOOK-05 T-chart. One claim sentence comes first, then evidence from both works.

WRITE-05 Credit Line for References (both bands). Three minutes. “After [artist, title],” “from my own photo,” or “reference: [open-access link].” A piece that used a reference and has no credit

line doesn't go in the portfolio yet.

The voluntary national arts standards for grade 8 include being aware of the practices, issues, and ethics of appropriation, fair use, copyright, open source, and Creative Commons when you make art.³⁷ The credit line is where that awareness shows up on the page.

Out-of-home try-its

OUT-01 Museum One-Room Sit (both bands)

- *Time*: 45–60 minutes inside the building
- *Materials*: a small sketchbook and a pencil
- *Mess/safety*: pencil only; stay well back from the work
- *Venue rules*: check the museum's visitor rules before you go. Many galleries allow pencil only, and some limit sketchbook size or folding stools. Photography rules vary by gallery and by loan. Ask at the front desk.
- *The fun*: permission to skip most of the museum. One room, one work. You're not failing to see everything. You're choosing to see one thing well.
- *The skill*: a silent look, one sketch, one VTS pass, and a caption-last note. If they want to see it all, say: "One room today. We'll come back."

HIST-05 Local Art Walk (both bands)

- *Time*: 30–60 minutes
- *Materials*: a map and a sketchbook
- *Mess/safety*: the usual street sense; face the work, not strangers
- *The fun*: finding art you've walked past a hundred times without noticing.
- *The skill*: find public sculpture, a mural, or an interesting building. Sketch one, and record the maker if a plaque names them. If there's no plaque, write down the location and the date you saw it.

OUT-04 Library Art Book Hunt (both bands)

- *Time*: 30 minutes
- *Materials*: a library card
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The fun*: big, heavy picture books that nobody else has opened this year.
- *The skill*: find one book on one artist or period and choose one image to study. If they browse covers forever: "Pick the one image that stops you."

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): "What's going on in this work — and what do you see that makes you say that?"

Follow-ups:

1. "What more can you find?" (seeing)
2. "What material is it — and what did that allow?" (evidence and process)

3. “When and where was it made — and how do we know?” (history, with a source)
4. “Now: what’s your judgment, and why?” (the last rung, with reasons)
5. “Has anything you said changed since you started looking?” (revising)

How to wait. After you ask, count a slow three in your head. After they answer, wait again, because the second answer is often the better one. The slow three comes from classroom research on wait time. It’s a helpful convention, not a law of art.⁷ If the silence feels long, look at the picture, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. They’re worried about saying something “wrong” about a Famous Painting. They’re hunting for the right art word. You’ve already signaled what you think (“Isn’t this wonderful?”). The question sounded like a test. Or they’re simply mid-look. Try describing one small thing yourself, neutrally (“There’s a crack running down the jug”), and then wait. “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say: “Don’t you think it’s beautiful?” **Say instead:** “What’s going on in this work — and what do you see that makes you say that?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked: run VTS on three different works across one week, with the same three questions each time. The questions become automatic, which frees up attention for the looking.

Mixed: compare two works (LOOK-05), then write it up at 13–14 (WRITE-04) or say it aloud at 11–12. Or run a Feldman ladder on a book painting and CRP on a sibling’s print in the same Art Hour. Knowing which tool fits which situation is the real skill.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

A student writes this about a still-life painting:

“This painting is boring and too dark. The lemon is the best part. It’s a still life with a lemon, a glass, and a knife on a table. The light comes from the left. I think it’s about how things don’t last.”

Ask your student: “What’s out of order?”

The verdict comes first (“boring and too dark”). The description is buried in the middle. The analysis gets one short line. The interpretation has no evidence behind it. Now reorder it on the Feldman ladder:

Describe: A half-peeled lemon, a glass, and a knife sit on a table with a white cloth. The background is almost black. *Analyze:* The light comes from the left and hits the lemon hardest, so the lemon is the brightest thing in the picture. *Interpret:* I think it’s about things not lasting, because the lemon is peeled and starting to dry, and the glass is nearly empty. *Judge:* I like it more than I did at the start. The background I called “too dark” is what makes the lemon glow.

Same student, same painting. The judgment changed because the looking came first. (This is an illustration, not a particular painting you need to go find.)

A composite: when critique went wrong (illustration)

This is a composite drawn from common situations, not a real family. A co-op held a show-and-tell. A guest parent looked at a shy thirteen-year-old's charcoal hallway and said, kindly enough, "The perspective's wrong." The student didn't bring work back for a month.

Nobody was cruel, and the comment was even accurate. What was missing was permission. At the next session, the group used CRP. Statements of meaning came first ("The dark doorway pulls me in"). Then the student asked her own question: "Does the hallway look deep enough?" She heard the perspective point as an answer to that question, and it felt completely different.

If you run a co-op critique, print the four CRP steps on a card for the table. The guests will thank you, and so will the students.

A composite: the student who only draws from screens (illustration)

Another composite. A fourteen-year-old draws anime characters from screens, beautifully, and draws nothing else. Respect that. It's real drawing, with real decisions in it. Add a credit line for screen references (WRITE-05), a daily observational page (SKB-01), and a labelled master study of a Japanese woodblock print (LOOK-04, HIST-03). The flat color areas and confident outlines will feel familiar. That study becomes a bridge, and the student gets to walk across it on their own.

For the student

Critique, in one line: **see before you judge.**

Critique isn't about finding what's wrong. It's about looking long enough that your opinion, when you give it, is worth hearing. Anyone can say "that's boring." It takes an artist to say why, while pointing at the canvas.

You'll use three tools. The first is three questions for looking at anything. The second is a four-step ladder for finished work. The third is a way to give feedback to living artists, including you, where opinions only come when they're wanted.

Worked example: the Feldman ladder

Say you're looking at a painting of a harbor at dusk. Climb four rungs, in order.

- **Describe.** Boats with tall masts. Water filling the bottom half. A pinkish sky. Tiny figures on a dock at the right.
- **Analyze.** The brightest part is the sky just above the horizon. The masts make vertical lines that repeat across the picture. The figures are small, so the boats feel big.

- **Interpret.** I think it's about the quiet end of a working day, because the figures are standing still and the sails are down.
- **Judge.** I think it works. The repeated masts give it a calm rhythm. I'd go back and look at it again.

By the time you judge, you have reasons. Sometimes your own judgment will surprise you.

Two tries

1. Pick an image from a museum's open-access website or a library art book. Cover the caption. Set a timer for five minutes and list twenty things you see. Then write two because-I-see sentences: "I think ____ because I see ____."
2. Take a question with an opinion hiding in it, like "Why are the colors so dull?", and rewrite it three different ways so it's neutral. (Hint: cut the adjectives.)

Explain it back

What makes a question neutral? Explain it to someone at home, with one loaded question and your neutral version of it.

Challenge

Find two works with the same subject (two still lifes, two landscapes, two animals) made in different centuries or places. Make a T-chart of differences in material, light, and composition. Then write one paragraph that starts with a claim and backs it up with evidence from both works.

Credit and sources

When you copy a real work to learn from it, the drawing is yours, as a study. Write "study after" with the artist, title, and date underneath. If someone tells you a fact about an artist, whether it comes from a book, a video, a friend, or a chatbot, check it on the museum's page or in a book before you write it down as true. Sounding confident isn't the same as being right.

Your right to say "not yet"

Your sketchbook is private unless you choose to share it. When someone offers an opinion about your work, you're allowed to say, "Not today, thanks." That's part of how critique works. It isn't rude.

If it isn't clicking

1. Bored in museums. They drag, sigh, and want to leave by minute ten. *What it usually means:* too much, too fast. *Next move:* one room, one work, one sketch, and then leave while it's still good. A snack afterward helps morale. Next month, try a different room.

2. Only opinions. Every response is “love it” or “hate it.” *What it usually means:* nobody has asked them for evidence before. *Next move:* the describe-only timer (CRIT-01): three minutes, no opinion words, and you play too. Make it a game. Whoever uses an opinion word first owes the other person a description of something in the room.

3. Parroting labels. They read the caption and say it back. *What it usually means:* they believe there’s a right answer and it’s printed on the wall. *Next move:* cover the label (LOOK-06) every time for two weeks, and read it only at the end.

When to slow down. If describe-only still feels hard, stay with LOOK-01 and CRIT-01 for another week or two. Nothing is lost.

When to go ahead. If they start saying “because I see...” without being prompted, move up to the Feldman ladder in writing, and then to compare-two.

When to find a human teacher. Museum teen programs, docent-led tours, and community critique groups give your student a wider circle of looking partners. A good docent is a gift. Check each program’s age rules.

The rescue order is the same as always: ask, wait, hint, give a short demo (here, that means you describing one small thing out loud), and then hand the looking back.

Tools, including AI

The Art Hour’s AI box has the full rules. One use fits this chapter especially well: art-history questions.

You, or your 13–14-year-old sitting with you on an account the service’s terms allow, can ask a chatbot when and where a work was made, what it’s made of, or what else was happening in art at the time. Then check every claim against the museum’s own page, a library book, or a reputable art-history site (HIST-04). Chatbots give fluent, confident answers, and researchers have documented them inventing references outright.²⁰ That isn’t a reason to ban them. It’s a reason to treat every answer as a lead. The source check is the lesson, and the chatbot just supplied something to check.

You can also ask a tool to help you *find* open-access works on a theme (“public-domain still lifes with strong window light”) and then go look at the real museum pages yourself.

Some things stay off the table. A tool doesn’t write the student’s critique, compare-two paragraph, or artist statement. Those words are the student’s thinking made visible, and a model’s paragraph isn’t their words.

Plain tools do most of the work here anyway: a sticky note to cover labels, a timer, an index card for HIST-01, and a string on the wall for the timeline.

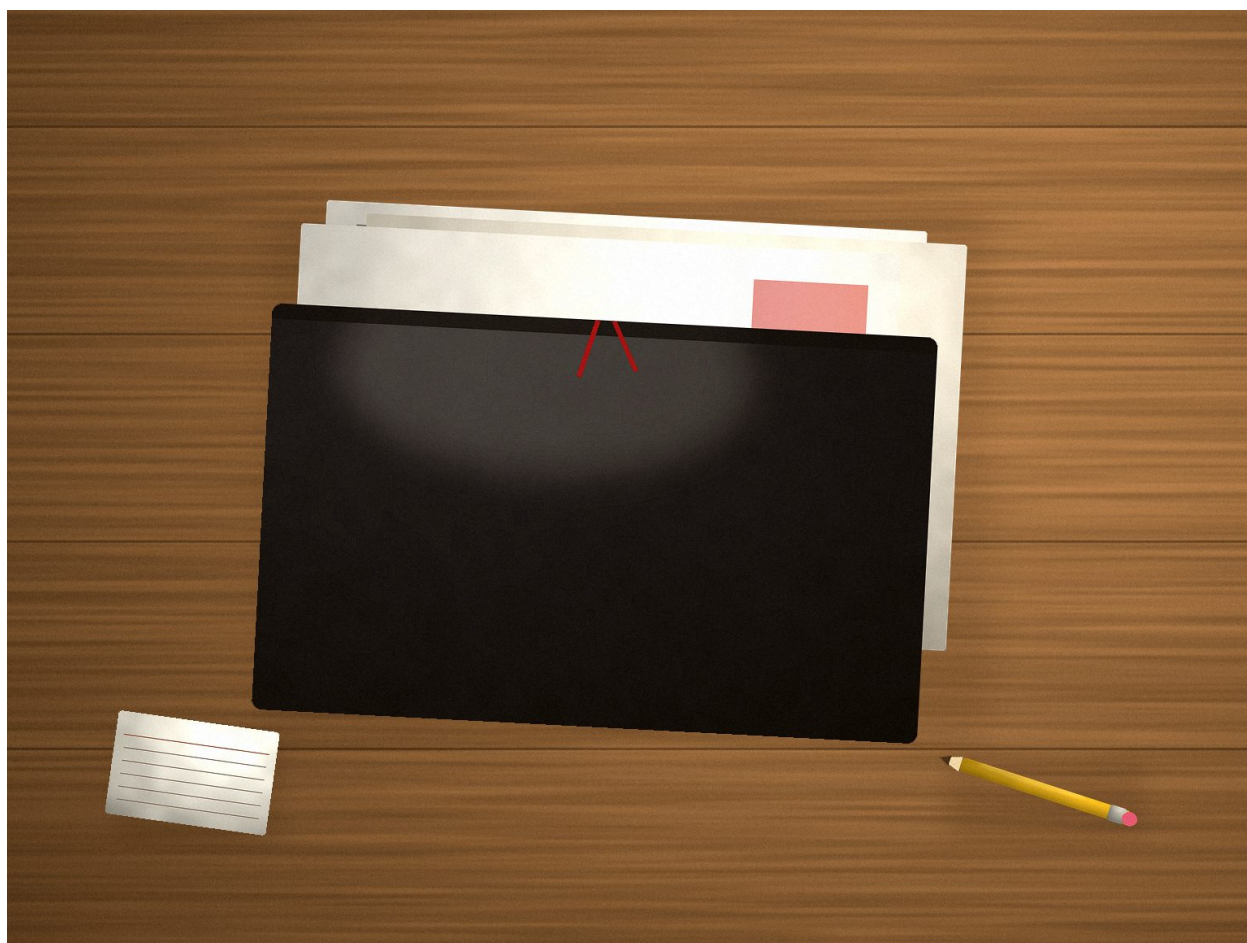
What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on (or while you keep threading this chapter through the year), check:

- ☐ Two VTS sessions happened, with the three questions asked as written.
- ☐ One labelled master study exists, with a credit line.
- ☐ At 11–12, three because-I-see sentences. At 13–14, one compare-two paragraph.
- ☐ One source-checked fact sits on a When-and-Where card.
- ☐ The student can explain what makes a question neutral.
- ☐ One out-of-home looking try-it happened, or it's on the calendar.
- ☐ At least once, the student's judgment changed after describing.

Placement is by skill, not birthday. A twelve-year-old who writes clear because-I-see sentences can try the compare-two paragraph. A fourteen-year-old who's new to looking starts with VTS. Both of them are doing Art.

Chapter 8 — Portfolio and progress checks



Why this matters

A lot of families have a height chart penciled on a kitchen doorframe. Every so often somebody stands against it, a book goes flat on their head, and a line gets a date. Nobody grades the chart. Nobody calls a line “good.” But ask a family to show you growth and they’ll walk you straight to that doorframe.

That’s what this chapter builds for art. Assessment at 11–14 isn’t a percentile, and it isn’t a stack

of rubrics. It's evidence you can see and date. Here is what it looks like:

- a sketchbook with dated pages
- one unaided observational drawing each month, of the same kind of object (the doorframe line)
- a few short skill checks, like a value scale or a perspective error hunt
- a simple look at critique quality: did evidence come before the verdict?
- an honest card on each serious piece that says whose marks are on it
- a small portfolio the student chooses, puts in order, and explains

At this age, the portfolio *is* the assessment. The student decides what goes in, and that deciding is a big part of what's being learned. Choosing six pieces and saying why is harder than it sounds. It takes looking back at your own work with the same fair eyes Chapter 7 taught you to use on a museum painting. See before you judge, pointed at yourself.

This chapter also protects something. A private sketchbook only works if it stays private. Checks only mean something if they aren't performances. And showing work to anyone only helps if the student agreed to it. Because this age is especially sensitive to being watched and evaluated, consent comes first in everything that follows.⁴

It closes the loop on the other half of the focus line too: sketch before you polish. A portfolio that puts process pages beside finished pieces makes the sketching visible, which tells anyone looking that the ugly middles were part of the work, not something to hide.

A good portfolio at the end of this year won't be perfect. It will be honest, specific, and clearly the student's own. That's worth more than a grade, and Chapter 9 shows how to turn it into a record a stranger can read.

For the parent: understand it yourself

The everyday picture. The height chart. Same measure, same spot, repeated. Growth shows up without anyone saying "better." That's the whole logic of the monthly check.

The precise picture. Four pieces fit together.

The monthly unaided observational check (AS-01). Once a month, the student draws the same kind of object from life (a mug, a shoe, their own non-drawing hand) for ten minutes, with no help and no erasing marathons. Date it and file it. Pull out September and March side by side, and the growth is right there: proportions that were guessed now look measured, outlines that floated now sit on a surface, and value turns up where there used to be only lines. Nobody has to argue about it. It's a snapshot, not a performance, so no redos.

Short skill checks. The value scale check (AS-03) is seven even steps from white to darkest, done unaided. The perspective error hunt (AS-04) is a drawing with a planted mistake for the student to find and explain. The critique quality check (AS-05) asks two questions of any critique the student gives: did evidence come before the verdict, and was any opinion permissioned? Each takes five to ten minutes. None needs a score out of 100.

The whose-mark card (AS-02). One card per portfolio candidate, recording what the piece was made from, what references and tools were used, and any AI use. It's the honesty tool of this book. It isn't suspicion. It's the same disclosure habit the College Board asks of high-school students in AP Art and Design, where all AI use must be disclosed and generative AI is prohibited in final submitted work.²³ The full card is below.

The portfolio (PORT banks). The student photographs work (PORT-01), selects with reasons (PORT-02), pairs finals with process pages (PORT-03), puts them in order and titles them (PORT-04), and talks about them with a guest (PORT-05). The voluntary national arts standards ask eighth graders to develop and apply criteria for evaluating a collection of artwork for presentation, so choosing portfolio pieces with reasons is ordinary art-room work, not an extra.³⁸

The whose-mark card, in full. One index card, or a sketchbook margin, per portfolio candidate:

- **Title and date.**
- **Made from:** life / memory / imagination / reference (name it).
- **References and credit lines:** for example, "After [title], [artist], [date], [museum], open access." A master study is labelled "study after..." and goes in the portfolio *as a study*.
- **Tools used:** including any grid, tracing, projector, or photo reference. All of these are allowed when they're named.
- **AI use, if any:** what it was used for (questions, reference searching), plus a plain statement that the marks are the student's. A generated image is never the piece.
- **One sentence in the student's own words:** what they learned making it.

At 11–12, you can write the card while the student tells you what goes on it. At 13–14, the student writes it.

Notice what the card doesn't do. It doesn't ban grids, tracing, or photo references. Artists have used all of them for centuries. It simply asks that they be named. A traced drawing with a credit line is honest. The same drawing passed off as freehand observation isn't. The difference is the card.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. Choosing only the "prettiest" pieces. *What it usually means:* the student thinks a portfolio is a highlight reel. *Your move:* "Keep those. Now add one that shows the most learning, even if it's not the best-looking."

2. No process pages anywhere. *What it usually means:* the thumbnails got tossed, or the student is embarrassed by them. *Your move:* start keeping them now (PORT-03). From this week on, thumbnails get dated and stay in the sketchbook.

3. A generated or traced piece offered as original. *What it usually means:* an authorship blur, usually more confusion than deceit. The student may truly feel that writing the prompt was the making. *Your move:* the whose-mark card. Label what it is. A generated image doesn't go in the portfolio as the student's work. A traced piece can go in if the card says so.

4. Grading the sketchbook. *What it usually means:* the adult is looking for something to measure, and the sketchbook is the thickest thing on the table. *Your move:* check *that* pages exist, and read

only the pages the student offers. The sketchbook is where bad drawings are allowed. Once it's graded, the bad drawings stop, and so does the learning.

5. Critiquing a piece the student didn't offer. *What it usually means:* a well-meaning adult, often a visitor, saw something and spoke up. *Your move:* nothing gets critiqued without being offered. If it happens, say to the student later: "That wasn't yours to have to hear. You choose what you show."

Five-minute parent warm-up

Lay out September's AS-01 page and this month's side by side. (If you're just starting, lay out the student's earliest dated drawing and their most recent one.) Look for five minutes. Write one sentence of growth you can *see*: not "better," but something like "The mug's rim is an ellipse now instead of a circle," or "The shadow sits under the shoe instead of floating beside it."

Keep that sentence. You'll use it in the talk box, and it may end up in the record in Chapter 9.

Starting partway through the year

If you're reading this chapter before you've kept any monthly checks, you haven't missed anything. Start AS-01 this week, and today's page becomes the baseline. Then go through the sketchbooks you already have and put a sticky tab on the earliest dated drawing from life. It won't match the monthly check exactly, but it's honest evidence of where things began. From here on, the doorframe gets a line every month.

What this chapter is not

It isn't a rubric battery. No chart of criteria scored from one to four will be validated here, because none has been validated for home art at this age. It isn't a percentile, since there's no national art score for homeschooled middle-schoolers to compare against. And it isn't a verdict on talent. The checks show change over time in one person, which is the only comparison that matters here.

How to teach it this week

First try-it: PORT-01 Photograph Your Work, then PORT-02 Select Six with Reasons.

Start with photographs, because they're practical and low-pressure. Choose a spot with daylight and a flat surface, away from direct window glare.

Say:

"Let's photograph the work you've made this year. Straight on, cropped to the paper. No faces, no house in the background."

Let the student hold the phone. Show them how to square up the shot (phone parallel to the paper) and crop tight. File photos by date. That's PORT-01.

Then spread out the year's work: the sketchbook, loose pieces, prints, a photo of the clay box. Say: "Which pages show what you've learned — and which would you show a stranger first?"

Then wait. Let them handle things. When they pick one, ask:

"Tell me why this one."

Write the reason down, or have them write it at 13–14. Keep going until there are six, or eight to twelve at 13–14. That's PORT-02.

Exact wording to keep in your pocket.

- "Which pages show what you've learned?"
- "Which would you show a stranger first?"
- "Tell me why this one."
- "Which process page explains this final?"
- "You choose what goes in. I'll ask questions."

How to fade help. The first time, you sit beside the student and ask the questions. The second time, they run the selection and you ask one neutral question per piece (Chapter 7's CRIT-05 skill). By the end of the year, they sequence, title, and write reasons on their own, and you're the first guest.

When to stop talking. When they start moving pieces around to put them in order. That's where the real decisions happen, and your voice will only nudge them toward your favorites.

Band moves.

11–12. Six pieces. Spoken reasons, which you can write down for them. One process page beside each final. You model CRP by presenting your own sketchbook page first: you say what you were trying, you ask them a question, and they practice neutral questions on you. The AS-01 monthly check can be as short as ten minutes on a mug. The whose-mark card is spoken, and you write it.

13–14. Eight to twelve pieces. A written artist statement in the student's own words (WRITE-03, Chapter 7). Sequence and titles (PORT-04). A portfolio conversation with a guest using CRP (PORT-05). The student writes the whose-mark cards. A ready twelve-year-old can take sequencing and titles early.

This week, honestly

- **Monday:** PORT-01 Photograph Your Work. Ten-minute page after.
- **Tuesday:** ten-minute page. AS-01 if it's the monthly check day.
- **Wednesday:** PORT-02 Select Six with Reasons, plus whose-mark cards for the chosen pieces (AS-02).
- **Thursday:** ten-minute page. PORT-03 Process Beside Finals: find a process page for each selected piece.
- **Friday:** AS-03 Value Scale Check or AS-04 Perspective Error Hunt (five to ten minutes), SKB-06 review, and AS-06 done-enough for whatever chapter you're in.
- **Once this term, out of the house (or with a guest at home):** PORT-05 Portfolio Conversation with a relative, a mentor, or a co-op group.

This chapter doesn't need a month of its own. Most of it runs alongside the others all year. AS-01 happens monthly. Whose-mark cards get written as pieces are finished. The Friday check is short. PORT-02 through PORT-05 are a two- or three-week push, once or twice a year.

Turning evidence into a sentence

Once a quarter, after you've laid out the AS-01 pages, write a three-line growth note. It takes five minutes and it's the most useful record you'll keep.

- **What I see:** "The March mug has a measured rim and a cast shadow; the September mug was an outline."
- **Where it shows:** "AS-01 pages, September and March; value scale check in February."
- **What's next:** "Two-point perspective from life; keep the monthly check going."

Let the student read the note, and add a line of their own if they want. At 13–14, they can write the whole note and you add one line. These notes feed straight into the records in Chapter 9, and a stranger can read them.

The artist statement, the short way

At 13–14, the portfolio gets a statement of 60 to 150 words (WRITE-03, Chapter 7). The easiest way in is through the process notes the student has been writing all year. Have them read back through their notes and pick three sentences that still sound true. Then they answer three questions in their own words: What did I make? How did I make it? What was I trying to figure out? That's a first draft.

Help by asking questions, not by rewording. "What do you mean by 'better'?" is useful. Rewriting their sentence into smoother language isn't, because then it stops being theirs. A statement with a clunky sentence the student actually means is worth more than a polished one they don't recognize. At 11–12, the statement can be three spoken sentences that you write down word for word.

A community show, if the student wants one. Some libraries, co-ops, and community centers hang student work. That's a lovely next step for a student who chooses it. It's never a requirement, and saying no is a complete answer.

Two bands at one table (illustration)

This is a composite drawn from common situations, not a real family. Two siblings, eleven and thirteen, do portfolio week together. They both photograph their work at the same window on Monday. On Wednesday, the eleven-year-old picks six pieces and says the reasons aloud while the parent writes them down. The thirteen-year-old picks ten, writes her own cards, and starts arranging them on the floor.

On Friday they swap roles for ten minutes. The thirteen-year-old asks her brother neutral questions about his six ("Tell me about the blue in this one"), and he asks her one question about her order. Same talk box, two bands, and both of them are practicing being fair to someone else's work. Neither one has to show the other anything they didn't choose.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it lists time, materials, mess and safety, the fun, and the skill.

In-home try-its

AS-01 Unaided Observational Check (both bands, monthly)

- *Time:* 10 minutes
- *Materials:* the same kind of object each month (a mug, a shoe, or the student's own non-drawing hand); pencil; the sketchbook
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* in about three months, the student gets to see their own growth with their own eyes. For some students, this is the first time they believe they can learn to draw.
- *The skill:* ten minutes of drawing from life with no help. Date it. Once a quarter, lay the pages side by side.
- *Stuck → move:* if they want to redo it, say: "It's a snapshot, not a performance. Next month's page will show next month's you."

Why life and not a photo? Because the skill being tracked is seeing. Research with adults suggests most drawing errors come from misperceiving the object, not from the hand, so a drawing from life shows how the seeing is growing.¹ (That study was done with adults, so treat it as the reason for the method, not a promise about any one student.)

AS-02 Whose-Mark Card (both bands)

- *Time:* 2 minutes per piece
- *Materials:* index cards, or the sketchbook margin
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* honestly, not much. It's a label. But it's the label that lets a student say, with a straight face, "All of this is mine."
- *The skill:* fill in the card (full version above). If a generated element turns up, label it. That piece doesn't go in the portfolio as "my drawing."

AS-03 Value Scale Check (both bands)

- *Time:* 5 minutes
- *Materials:* pencil, paper
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The fun:* it's quick, and it's satisfying when the jumps come out even.
- *The skill:* seven even steps from white to darkest, with no help. If there's a big jump in the middle, go back to VAL-01 in Chapter 3 for a week and try again.

AS-04 Perspective Error Hunt (both bands)

- *Time:* 10 minutes
- *Materials:* a drawing with one or two planted perspective errors. Draw it yourself, or use a generated image you've checked, as a looking object only.
- *Mess/safety:* none

- *The fun*: catching the adult’s deliberate mistake.
- *The skill*: find and mark the wrong convergence or the second eye level, and explain the fix. If they find nothing, point to one area: “Look near the door.”

AS-05 Critique Quality Check (both bands)

- *Time*: 5 minutes
- *Materials*: any critique the student has given, spoken or written, of a master work, a sibling’s piece, or their own
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The fun*: the student gets to check their own critique like an editor.
- *The skill*: two ticks. Did evidence come before the verdict? Was any opinion permissioned? If the verdict came first, run a Feldman ladder (CRIT-02) on the same work.

AS-06 Done-Enough Checklist (both bands). Five minutes. Student and parent tick what’s secure on the current chapter’s list, then plan next week. If the answer is “nothing’s done,” pick the one secure thing and start there. There always is one.

PORT-03 Process Beside Finals (both bands)

- *Time*: 15 minutes
- *Materials*: thumbnails, sketches, and the selected finals
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The fun*: seeing the ugly first thumbnail next to the finished print. It’s the most encouraging thing in the whole portfolio.
- *The skill*: pair each final with one process page that explains it. If there’s no process page for a piece, that piece can wait, and thumbnails start getting kept from today.

PORT-04 Sequence and Title (13–14; ready 12)

- *Time*: 15 minutes
- *Materials*: the selected pieces or their photos
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The fun*: it’s like curating a tiny show.
- *The skill*: put the pieces in order for a stranger, then give each one a title, a date, and its medium. If the order feels random, start strong and end strong, and let the middle show range.

CRIT-04 Artist Asks First, on your own work (13–14; modeled at 11–12). Before anyone comments on a portfolio piece, the student asks two specific questions about it. “Is it good?” is too big. “Does the cast shadow read as a shadow?” or “Is it clear which print was the first pull?” can be answered.

CRIT-06 Permissioned Opinion, on your own work (13–14; modeled at 11–12). A guest or parent says, “I have an opinion about the order. Would you like to hear it?” The student may say no. Log it either way. A no is a legitimate answer, and it’s worth respecting.

Photographing work and privacy

PORT-01 is how a portfolio travels. It's also how a young person's details can leak. A few habits:

- Photograph the work, not the student. Crop to the paper.
- No faces, no house numbers, no school names in the frame.
- If a photo will go anywhere public, cover or crop out signatures with full names, and turn off location data in the phone's camera settings where you can.
- Uploading a photo to any AI service is a privacy decision for you to make. Some services' terms give the company a broad license to content you upload, and some use uploads to improve their products unless you opt out.^{16,15} Read the terms before you upload, and crop to the paper when you do.
- Posting work publicly is the student's choice as well as yours. A portfolio can be complete without ever going online.

Out-of-home try-its

PORT-05 Portfolio Conversation (both bands)

- *Time*: 20 minutes
- *Materials*: the portfolio and one guest: a grandparent, a family friend who draws, a co-op parent, or a mentor. Brief the guest on CRP beforehand.
- *Mess/safety*: emotional safety matters most here. The student chooses the guest.
- *Venue*: a relative's kitchen, a library study room, or a co-op meeting.
- *The fun*: being the expert in the room. The student knows more about these pieces than anyone else there.
- *The skill*: the student presents. The guest gives statements of meaning first, then answers the student's own questions, then asks neutral questions, and offers opinions only if the student says yes.⁸ If the student freezes, they read from their own process notes. Afterward, the guest writes one note and the student writes one reflection.

Give the guest a card before they sit down. Something like this:

Thanks for looking. Here's how we do it. 1. First, tell the artist what struck you or seemed meaningful. No fixes yet. 2. The artist will ask you a couple of questions. Answer those. 3. Then ask your own questions, without opinions tucked inside. ("Tell me about the order" works. "Why is this one last?" can sound like a verdict.) 4. If you have an opinion, ask first: "I have an opinion about _____. Would you like to hear it?" The artist may say no.

Most adults are relieved to get instructions. Grandparents especially tend to love this.

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): "Which pages show what you've learned — and which would you show a stranger first?"

Follow-ups:

1. “What’s different from September?” (seeing the growth)
2. “What still needs practice?” (honest measure)
3. “Which process page explains this final?” (process as evidence)
4. “What would you like a guest to ask you?” (the artist asks first)
5. “Would you change the order now that you’ve said all that?” (revising)

How to wait. Count a slow three after you ask, and wait again after they answer. Here the waiting is often longer, because the student is thinking about their own work, which is harder than thinking about someone else’s. Look at the work, not at them.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. They’re afraid nothing is good enough. They think “which would you show a stranger” means “which is best,” and they don’t want to be wrong. You’ve already hinted at a favorite. Or the work feels too personal today. Try: “You don’t have to choose the best. Choose the one where you learned the most.” “Not today” is allowed. Try again next week.

Don’t say: “This one’s your best, put it first.” **Say instead:** “Which pages show what you’ve learned — and which would you show a stranger first?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked: three months of AS-01 on the same kind of object, same ten minutes, same conditions. Consistency is what makes it a measure.

Mixed: once a term, a full portfolio pass: photograph, select, pair with process, sequence, cards, conversation. That mixes every chapter’s work into one decision.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

This is an illustration, not a real student. A thirteen-year-old’s portfolio has six pieces: a colored-pencil fox, a painted landscape, a charcoal still life, a lino print, a detailed pen drawing of a city, and a portrait of a movie character. All six are finished. There are no thumbnails, no sketchbook pages, and no cards. Asked about the city drawing, the student says it was traced from a phone photo “to get it right.”

Ask your student (or yourself): “What’s missing?”

- **Process.** There isn’t a single thumbnail. Nobody can see how any of this was learned.
- **Credit.** The city drawing needs a whose-mark card: “Traced from my photo” or “traced from [source].” Once it has one, it’s honest. The movie-character portrait needs a credit line for its screen reference too.
- **Range of evidence.** Nothing from observation shows how the seeing has grown. One AS-01 page would do it.
- **Reasons.** Nobody knows why these six.

Here’s the fix. Keep the four strongest finals. Add one AS-01 page and one “most learned” sketchbook page. Pair each final with a process page. Write cards for all six. None of this is about punishment. It turns a folder of pictures into evidence of learning.

For the student

A portfolio isn't a trophy case. It's evidence of what you've learned, chosen by you, with the messy parts included on purpose.

That last part surprises people. A portfolio with only perfect finals tells a stranger almost nothing. A portfolio with a finished print *and* the three ugly thumbnails you made first tells them how you think. Artists and art teachers care about that more than polish.

You choose what goes in. Nobody should critique a piece you didn't offer. When someone does give you feedback, you can ask them your own questions first, and you can turn down an opinion.

Worked example

Here's one portfolio entry:

- **The final:** a lino print of a pear, edition 3/5.
- **The process page:** a sketchbook page with four thumbnails. Two are crossed out. One has a note: "too centered, try left."
- **Your reason (two lines):** "I chose this because it's my first print where the lettering came out the right way. The thumbnails show how I moved the pear off-center."
- **The whose-mark card:** made from life (a real pear); tools: gouges, bench hook, brayer; references: none; AI: none; what I learned: "Reverse your letters before you carve, not after."

That's one complete entry. Six of those makes a real portfolio.

Two tries

1. Pick one finished piece. Find the process page that goes with it (a thumbnail, a sketch, a messy first try). Write two lines explaining why you'd put them side by side.
2. Fill in a whose-mark card for one piece. Be exact about what you used: a photo, a grid, a book page, anything.

Explain it back

Why keep ugly pages? Explain it to someone at home in two or three sentences.

Challenge

Present your portfolio to one guest you trust. Before they say anything, ask them two questions you actually want answered ("Does the order make sense?" "Which process page surprised you?"). Take notes. You're allowed to say "no, thanks" to any opinion.

A word about AI

A picture a program makes is not your drawing. If you used a tool to find a reference or to ask questions, write that on the card. That’s what working artists and AP students do too. The U.S. Copyright Office said in 2025 that typing prompts isn’t enough to make someone the author of an image; the phrase it used was “not the mere provision of prompts.”²² Your marks are what make it yours.

If it isn’t clicking

1. “Nothing’s good enough.” The student won’t pick anything, or picks and then un-picks. *What it usually means:* they’re choosing by “best,” and against a standard nothing can meet. *Next move:* change the question. “Pick the one where you learned the most.” Put September’s AS-01 beside this month’s and ask them what changed. Seeing their own growth usually loosens things.

2. Won’t present. Even the idea of a guest makes them go quiet. *What it usually means:* evaluation sensitivity, which is real at this age. *Next move:* present to one trusted person, maybe just you, or write a short statement instead of speaking. The portfolio is complete either way. Try a guest again next term if they want.

3. The portfolio is all one kind of thing. Every piece is colored pencil, or every piece is the same character. *What it usually means:* comfort, and a real strength. *Next move:* keep the favorites, and add one piece from a different chapter, such as a value study, a print, or a perspective drawing. Range shows learning that a single medium can hide.

When to slow down. If the AS-01 pages aren’t showing change after three or four months, go back to Chapter 2 for a few weeks of sighting and contour. The monthly check just told you something useful. That’s what it’s for.

When to go ahead. If the student sequences, titles, and explains without much prompting, they’re ready for a guest conversation, a community show if they want one, or a longer series of related pieces.

When to find a human teacher. A community class, open studio, or museum teen program can give a portfolio outside eyes and new techniques. For a 13–14-year-old heading toward high-school art, that’s a gift, not a sign you’ve fallen short. Check each program’s age rules.

Tools, including AI

The Art Hour’s AI box has the full rules. For this chapter:

- **Photo edits that don’t generate anything are fine.** Cropping, straightening, and adjusting exposure or contrast so the photo looks like the real piece are all fine. AP Art and Design draws the same line: non-generative edits are allowed, and generative features such as generative fill or background replacement aren’t.²³
- **No generative fill, expand, or “enhance” on portfolio images.** The photo should show what the student made.

- **Disclose any AI use on the whose-mark card.** If a chatbot helped find a reference or answered an art-history question, it goes on the card. That doesn't count against the piece. It's honesty.
- **No AI detectors as grades.** They're unreliable. Text detectors have been shown to misclassify human writing, especially from non-native English writers.²¹ The honesty tools in this book are the whose-mark card and the process pages, not a detector.
- **After the student's own critique,** you may ask a tool for three neutral questions about a cropped photo of a finished piece (no faces), and read them aloud as extra prompts. The student's own statement comes first and stays theirs.

A model doesn't write the artist statement. The statement is the student's thinking, in the student's words, rough edges included.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you close out a term:

- ☐ AS-01 pages exist, one for each month, dated.
- ☐ A portfolio of six (11–12) or eight to twelve (13–14) pieces, each with a process page beside it.
- ☐ A whose-mark card on every portfolio piece, with any AI use recorded.
- ☐ A spoken (11–12) or written (13–14) statement in the student's own words.
- ☐ At least one AS-03 or AS-04 check this term.
- ☐ One critique checked with AS-05: evidence first, opinions permissioned.
- ☐ A plan for next term, even one sentence: “More printmaking; try two-point outdoors.”

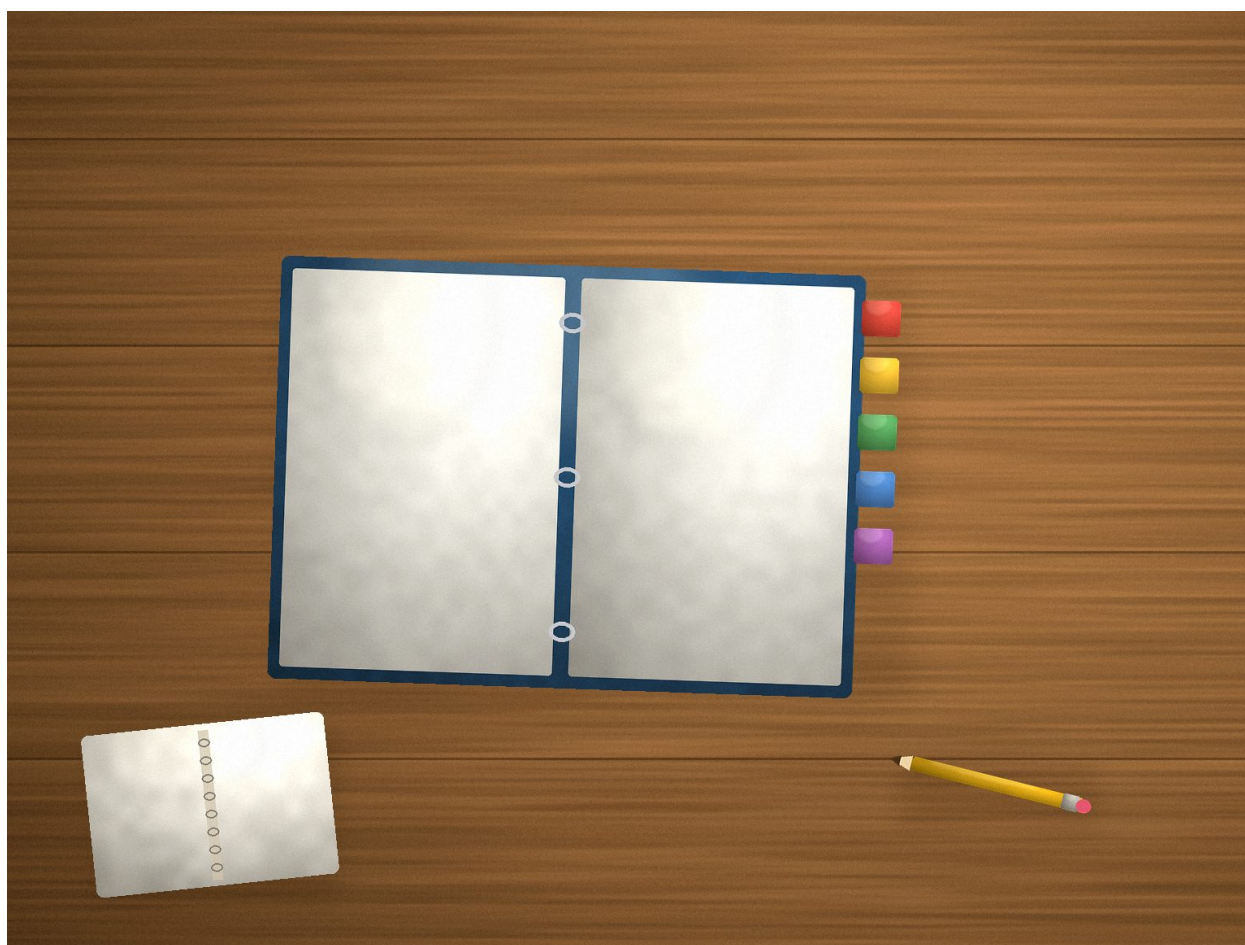
Placement is by skill, not birthday. A twelve-year-old who can sequence and explain a portfolio is doing the 13–14 work. A fourteen-year-old whose AS-01 pages show early skills gets the 11–12 moves and more time. A “grade 8 art” book is a publisher's scope, not a legal level.

Life of the habit. The goal was never a finished portfolio. It was a person who keeps seeing and making after this book is back on the shelf. A few things help:

- **Keep the sketchbook going over breaks.** One ten-minute page a few times a week keeps the eye warm. Holidays and trips are some of the best drawing days of the year.
- **Revisit last year's object.** Draw the same mug, shoe, or hand you drew for your first AS-01. Put the pages side by side. It's the most convincing proof there is.
- **Stop while you want one more line.** End sessions a little before the energy runs out, and tomorrow will start easier.
- **Keep one page for yourself.** Not every drawing needs to be a portfolio candidate. Some pages are just for you.
- **Look at one real work a month.** A museum room, a library book, or a public sculpture on your street.

A dated sketchbook, a year of monthly checks, and a small honest portfolio make a real art education, and in Chapter 9 they become a record a stranger can read.

Chapter 9 — Records and next steps



The art itself happened at your table: the egg under the lamp, the lino block on the bench hook, the one-room museum sit. A record is how that year makes sense to someone who wasn't there. That might be an evaluator, a school registrar, a co-op coordinator, or your student at seventeen, trying to remember what they did at twelve.

This chapter shows you how to keep simple, honest records of art at 11–14, and how to write a course line a stranger can read. Nothing here is complicated. You'll be surprised how much evidence you already have.

You're in good company, too. In the 2022–23 school year, about 3.4 percent of U.S. students ages 5

through 17 were homeschooled, about 1,765,000 children. In the middle grades, grades 6 through 8, the figure was 3.0 percent.²⁹ Registrars and evaluators see homeschool records all the time. A clear one makes their job easy.

This week you can do two things. Start a one-line log, and write the course line at the top of it: **Art**. Everything else in this chapter builds from those two.

What you're keeping, and why

A good art record answers three questions for a stranger:

1. **What was studied?** The course line and a short description.
2. **How much?** A log of dates and minutes, or a reasonable summary of one.
3. **What came of it?** Evidence: dated sketchbooks, monthly checks, a portfolio.

The first two fit on one page. The third lives in a box or a folder, with photos as backup. You're not building a legal brief. You're keeping the kind of file that, if someone asked, lets you say "here" and hand it over.

The records serve your student too. A fourteen-year-old flipping through the September sketchbook in June sees something no grade could show them: they learned to draw. That moment is worth the whole filing system.

Who reads the record

Picture the reader before you write. It might be:

- **an evaluator or reviewer** in a state that asks for one, who wants to see that art was taught and that the student made progress
- **a school registrar**, if your student enrolls somewhere, who wants a course name they recognize and some idea of what was covered
- **a co-op or program coordinator** placing your student in a class
- **your future self**, writing a high-school transcript in three years and trying to remember what grade 7 held
- **your student**, who deserves to see what they did

None of these readers needs much. They need a plain title, a short description, a sense of how much time went in, and evidence if they ask. They don't need a curriculum's marketing copy or a stack of worksheets. Write for someone busy, fair, and curious, and you'll serve all of them.

The course line: Art

The course title is **Art**.

That's it. It isn't a curriculum name or a brand, and it isn't this book's title. Never write "Young Minds Art I," "Young Minds Art," "Art for Young Minds I," or any variant. None of those is a

subject. A stranger can't read them, and they make your student's work look like a product instead of an education.

If your year leaned heavily toward one area, you can let the description say so. The title still stays plain. "Art" works in every state, for every kind of reader, in every future transcript format. It travels.

A few other titles to leave off:

- **"Honors" anything.** Unless you've defined an honors standard in writing and can show how the work met it, leave the word off.
- **"AP" anything.** AP is a College Board designation for specific high-school courses and exams.²³ A middle-school year at home isn't AP, however strong the work.
- **A program's name as the title.** If you used a published program, it can go in the description ("including lessons from ____"). It doesn't go in the title.

Writing the description

Under the title, write one or two sentences that say what actually happened. Here's the pattern:

Art (grade 7, 2026–27). Observational drawing, value, perspective, color and design, relief printing, and air-dry clay; looking at and discussing real works, including two museum visits; portfolio of eight pieces with process pages. About 100 hours logged.

Or, for a year that went deep in fewer areas:

Art (grade 8, 2027–28). Daily sketchbook practice from observation; relief printmaking including a numbered edition; critique and writing about art (compare-two paragraphs, artist statement); portfolio conversation with a guest reviewer.

Both descriptions use plain words. Each names media, skills, outings, and evidence, and neither makes a claim the file can't support.

If the student did master studies, say so: "master studies from public-domain works, labelled as studies." If they used references and grids, you don't need to mention it here, because the whose-mark cards in the portfolio already record it.

If the student used AI anywhere (to find open-access references, say, or to ask art-history questions they then checked), the whose-mark cards record it too. The description doesn't need a line about it. Never describe a year of generated images as art study. A generated image isn't the student's mark, and Chapter 8 explains why it stays out of the portfolio as their work.

Honest lines and dishonest lines

Here are a few side by side. The honest versions aren't humbler. They're just true, and a stranger can check them.

Honest	Not honest
Art (grade 7). 90 hours logged; sketchbook and portfolio; two museum visits.	Studio Art Honors (no defined honors standard).
Art (grade 8). Drawing, printmaking, critique; portfolio of 10 with process pages.	AP-level Drawing.
Art. Hours from a weekly log.	Art. Hours made up by multiplying 180 days by an hour.
Portfolio includes two master studies, credited as studies.	Master studies listed as original compositions.
Grade derived from written criteria and the portfolio (see below).	A grade the work can't support.
Art (grade 8), with a note pointing to high-school credit handled separately.	Young Minds Art I.

The honest column protects your student. If anyone ever asks a question, every line has a page behind it.

Evidence: what to keep in the file

Keep these. Most already exist if you've been using the book.

1. **Dated sketchbooks, all of them.** Even the half-empty one from October. They're the backbone of the record, and they show practice over time better than anything else. The sketchbook stays private in the sense that matters: you don't grade it, and you don't show pages the student hasn't agreed to show. But it stays in the file.
2. **Monthly AS-01 pages.** The unaided observational checks from Chapter 8, dated and together. Three or four of these side by side are the clearest growth evidence you'll have.
3. **Whose-mark cards.** One per portfolio piece, with references, tools, and any AI use recorded.
4. **The portfolio, photographed.** Six pieces at 11–12, eight to twelve at 13–14, each with its process page. Photos filed by date (PORT-01), cropped to the work, no faces.
5. **Quarterly growth notes.** The three-line notes from Chapter 8: what I see, where it shows, what's next.
6. **A short log.** More on this below.
7. **Outings.** Museum visits, library trips, local art walks, and community classes, with a date and one line each. A class certificate or receipt can go in too, if there is one.
8. **Done-enough checklists.** The AS-06 list for each chapter, ticked and dated. They show a stranger what was taught, in order.
9. **The artist statement** (13–14) or spoken statement you wrote down (11–12), in the student's own words.

What you don't need: every worksheet, every scrap, or grades on sketchbook pages. A dozen well-chosen pages beat a crate.

Store originals flat, in a box or portfolio folder, away from damp. Photograph anything fragile, like charcoal that smudges or clay that might break. Photos are your backup, and they're also how the portfolio can travel if a reader is far away.

Showing evidence without giving up privacy

Chapter 8 promised your student that the sketchbook is private by default. Records don't break that promise. Here's how the two fit together.

When a reader needs to see sketchbook evidence, the student chooses the pages. A sticky tab on each chosen page works well, and it's the same move as the Friday review in Chapter 2 (SKB-06). Ten tabbed pages across a year show practice, range, and growth. The rest of the book stays closed.

The monthly AS-01 pages and the portfolio are made to be shown. They're the public face of the year. Most readers will be satisfied with those two, plus the log.

If a reader asks to see "everything," it's reasonable to explain that the sketchbook is a practice space and offer the tabbed pages, the checks, and the portfolio instead. Most readers understand at once. They've kept a private notebook themselves.

Making the record together

Near the end of the year, make the record *with* your student. Set aside one Art Hour for it. It's a good one.

Lay out the year: sketchbooks, AS-01 pages, portfolio, log. Ask the student to help write the description. "What did we actually do this year? What would you want someone to know?" At 11–12, they talk and you write. At 13–14, they draft and you check it against the log.

Two things happen. The record gets more accurate, because the student remembers things you forgot (the week they did seven days of the same shoe, the library book they studied for a month). And the student sees the year as a whole, often for the first time. That view is an assessment in itself, and a kind one.

If you have two students in different bands, make two records. Siblings who shared a table still did different work, and each deserves a line that describes their own year.

A simple log

A log doesn't need to be elaborate. One line per session is plenty:

14 Oct · 45 min · Ch. 3 · Egg under a lamp; five parts of light labelled. 15 Oct · 10 min · SKB-01 · Ten-minute page: the kettle. 18 Oct · 60 min · OUT-01 · Museum one-room sit; study of a still life, caption-last note.

Date, minutes, chapter or bank code, and one line of what happened. That's all. Keep it in a notebook, a spreadsheet, or the back pages of your planner, whatever you'll actually use. A log

kept roughly every week is honest. A log reconstructed from memory in June is shakier, so aim for weekly.

If you want totals, add up the minutes each month. You'll likely find that two to four Art Hours a week plus ten-minute pages adds up faster than you'd expect. There's no national rule for how many minutes of art a middle-schooler should have at home, so the log is a record, not a quota. The exception is if your state sets a quantity, and New York does (see below).

Outings count. A ninety-minute museum visit with a sketch and a looking note is real art time, and it goes in the log like any other session.

If you need a grade

Many families never need a grade for middle-school art. Some do, for a state report, an umbrella school, or a later transcript. If you do, derive it honestly from evidence, and write down how you did it.

Here's one straightforward approach. It's a method, not a validated rubric:

1. **Write your criteria at the start of the year**, in plain words. For example: sessions logged consistently; monthly AS-01 checks completed; done-enough lists met for the chapters taught; a portfolio assembled with process pages and cards; critique that puts evidence before verdict (AS-05).
2. **At the end of the term, check the evidence against each one.** Did it happen? Is there a page for it?
3. **Assign the grade the evidence supports.** A pass/credit mark is fine for middle school, and a letter is fine if your reader wants one. Either way, keep the criteria sheet in the file.

Keep effort and growth in the conversation, but make sure there's evidence behind them. "AS-01 pages show measured proportions by March" is evidence. "Tried hard" is lovely, but it isn't a record on its own.

Grade the year, not the sketchbook. The sketchbook is where bad drawings are allowed, and it has to stay that way.

What your state asks (five examples)

Homeschool rules are state law, and they vary a lot. Some states name art, and some don't. Either way, a dated sketchbook and a small portfolio are the best record you can keep. Here are five examples, read from the current state texts at the time of writing. They're a map, not legal advice.

New York. The home-instruction regulation lists required subjects by grade band. For grades 7 and 8, the list includes "art (one-half unit)," and the units are cumulative across the two years. The regulation defines a unit in minutes of instruction per school year (6,480 minutes).²⁷ So in New York, middle-school art has a real quantity attached, and a log of minutes is the natural way to show it. Grades 1 through 6 list visual arts among the required subjects, and grades 9 through 12 list art and/or music. New York also has its own reporting steps (an instruction plan, quarterly

reports, an annual assessment), and art belongs in those under its own name. Read the regulation for the details.

Pennsylvania. The home education statute names art among the subjects taught at both the elementary and the secondary level.³⁹ Pennsylvania portfolios can include samples of “creative materials used or developed by the student,” so photographs of sketchbook pages and finished work fit naturally.

Texas, North Carolina, and Virginia. The home-school rules we read for these three states don’t name art as a required subject.⁴⁰ In Texas, the curriculum requirement centers on reading, spelling, grammar, math, and good citizenship. North Carolina’s annual testing covers English grammar, reading, spelling, and mathematics. In Virginia, the parent provides the program. You’re free to include art in all three, and if you do, record it as Art like any other subject.

Everywhere: laws change. Read your state’s current text, or a current summary from your state’s education department, before you rely on any of this. An advocacy group’s chart can be a helpful starting point, but it isn’t the law itself. And if you live somewhere else, your state has its own page. Look it up this week and write down what, if anything, it says about art.

The fourteen-year-old counted as a ninth grader

Sometimes a fourteen-year-old’s year counts as high school, and the family wants high-school credit for art. Here’s what this book suggests:

- **Record it as “Art,”** with the year and the same kind of honest description.
- **Log the hours** carefully, because high-school credit often depends on them.
- **Keep the portfolio,** with process pages and whose-mark cards. It’s the strongest evidence for any credit you claim.
- **For high-school credit rules and course titles, see *Art for Homeschooling*** (the Wisdom-Forge title for grades 1–12), **and check your state’s rules for high-school credit.** Credit hours, course titles, and diploma requirements are a high-school matter, and they vary by state.

This book doesn’t set high-school credit rules. The record stays plain and true, and the credit question gets answered with the right book and your state’s text.

The same fourteen-year-old might be curious about AP Art and Design later on. That’s a high-school exam from the College Board, with its own rules. One of those rules is already familiar from Chapter 8: generative AI isn’t allowed in final submitted work, and all AI use has to be disclosed.²³ A student who’s been filling out whose-mark cards since age eleven will find that easy.

If you transfer

If your student enters a school, the receiving school will place them its own way. It may look at your records, ask for a portfolio, or simply start them in the grade-level class. A clear record helps: “Art” on the course line, a description in plain words, and a portfolio they can show. It’s even better

if your student can talk through their portfolio with a teacher, which they’ve practiced in Chapter 8.

A brand name in the course column won’t be read as Art. A plain title with evidence behind it will.

A few common questions

We used a published program for part of the year. Does it go in the title? No. The title is Art. The description can say “including lessons from ____” if that helps a reader, and the program’s own materials can sit in the file.

The whole year was drawing. Can the title be “Drawing”? You can say so in the description: “Art (grade 7). Drawing from observation: contour, sighting, value, perspective.” “Art” is still the safest title, because it’s the one every reader recognizes.

Does a co-op class or community class count? Yes. Log the hours, keep any certificate, and put one or two pieces from the class in the portfolio with whose-mark cards. If the class had its own teacher, the card says so: “made in a community printmaking class.”

Is there a national art test we should be taking? No. There’s no national art test for homeschooled middle-schoolers, and no percentile to aim at. The evidence in this chapter is the assessment.

Our student barely drew in the spring. Do we pretend otherwise? No. Log what happened. A thin spring and a strong fall is an honest year. Some years are like that, and the record can say so without apology.

Do we need to keep the sketchbooks forever? If your state sets a period for keeping records, keep them at least that long. Then keep them anyway if you can. Your student will want them.

Next steps

When this book is done (or when your student is), here’s where things can go.

Keep the habit. A sketchbook, a monthly check, a museum room now and then. Chapter 8’s life-of-the-habit list is the whole plan. The best next step after a year of art is usually another year of it, at the next band. The thirteen-year-old’s two-point box and full critique are the eleven-year-old’s one-point hallway and first because-I-see sentence, grown up.

Find outside eyes. A community class, an open studio, a museum teen program, or a co-op critique group. When your student wants more than you can demonstrate, that’s good news. It means the book worked. Chapter 10 has more on finding these, and each program sets its own age rules.

Look ahead. For high-school depth (course titles, credit, portfolios for outside readers, oils and other materials this book leaves out), see *Art for Homeschooling*. It picks up where this book stops.

Look back, for a younger sibling. If there’s a five- to ten-year-old in the house, *Art for Little Thinkers* is the WisdomForge title for that age. Its “look before name; make before polish” is where this book’s “see before you judge; sketch before you polish” began.

Keep the file. Store the sketchbooks and the portfolio somewhere dry. In a few years, your student will want to see them, and they'll be glad you kept the ugly pages too.

A one-page record (illustration)

This is a composite, not a real student:

Art — Grade 7, 2026–27 Observational drawing (contour, sighting, negative space); value and light; one-point and two-point perspective; color mixing and design; relief printing (soft block and lino, edition of five); air-dry slab and coil; looking and critique (VTS, Feldman ladder, compare-two paragraph). Evidence: three dated sketchbooks; monthly observational checks, September–May; portfolio of eight with process pages and whose-mark cards; artist statement (student's own words); museum visits, 3; library art-book studies, 4; community printmaking class, 1. Time: about 110 hours, from a weekly log. Grade: Credit, per written criteria (attached).

Anyone can read that. Every line has a page behind it. And there's no brand anywhere.

Chapter 10 — Resources



This chapter is a map of what's out there: free collections, a starter shelf, published programs, community studios, and a few digital tools. It isn't a ranking. No program here is "the best," because the best one is whichever fits your student, your week, and your budget. Some families use nothing but a library card and this book. Others add a published program for structure, or a community class for tools they don't have at home. All of those are good ways to do Art.

The list starts with what costs nothing. Most of what an 11- to 14-year-old needs for a year of real art (things to look at, ideas to try, examples of how artists solved problems) is already free at your library, your nearest museum, and a handful of open online collections. Buy things only after you've checked those.

This week you can do one thing from this chapter: get a library card if you don't have one, or use the one you have to borrow one art book your student picks. That's a full resources plan for week one.

How to choose: four questions

Whatever you're considering, whether it's a book, a program, a class, or a set of materials, four questions will tell you most of what you need to know.

1. How much will you carry? Some resources expect you to read, prepare, and demonstrate. Others (video lessons, for instance) do more of the teaching themselves. Neither is better. It depends on your week. A parent with three other children and a job might want lower preparation. A parent who enjoys the art hour might want more.

2. Does the student look at real things, or copy steps? Some programs center observation: draw the mug in front of you. Others center step-by-step demonstration: follow these strokes to draw a fox. Both have a place. Step-by-step can build confidence and technique. Observation builds seeing, which is what this book leans on most. If a program is all step-by-step, add the ten-minute page from life (SKB-01) and the monthly check (AS-01) so seeing still gets practiced.

3. Where does your student actually sit? Place by skill, not birthday. A publisher's age label is a starting guess. A thirteen-year-old new to drawing may do best with material labelled for younger students, and a confident eleven-year-old may be ready for material labelled "12 & up." Check a sample lesson against what your student can do today.

4. Can the record still say Art? It always should. A program's name goes in the description, if anywhere, never in the course title (Chapter 9).

A fifth question, for materials: **what does the label say?** More on that below.

Start free: library, museum, and open collections

The library

The library is the first studio outside your house. Most homeschooling families already use it. In the 2022–23 national survey, 53 percent of homeschooled students' parents reported a library visit in the past month, compared with 29 percent across all students.²⁹

What to look for:

- **Art books with big, clear reproductions.** Books on one artist, one period, or one kind of art (prints, sculpture, pottery). These are your looking objects for Chapter 7's LOOK and HIST try-its. Let the student pick (OUT-04 Library Art Book Hunt).
- **How-to books on drawing, perspective, and printmaking.** Many are excellent, and they cost nothing to try. If one clicks, you can buy your own copy later.
- **Art-history picture books,** even ones written for younger readers. They're quick visual references with clear captions, and nobody has to know which shelf they came from.

- **Interlibrary loan.** If your branch doesn't have it, ask. Many libraries can borrow from other libraries.
- **Workshops and programs.** Many libraries run art workshops or teen programs, and some publish their own tutorials. The Topeka and Shawnee County Public Library, for example, has published a lino block printing tutorial that covers the bench hook and carving away from yourself.¹³ Check your library's calendar.

The museum

Museums are the other great free (or low-cost) resource. The same national survey found that 43 percent of homeschooled students' parents reported a visit to an art gallery, museum, or historical site in the past month, compared with 23 percent across all students.²⁹

Before you go:

- **Check admission.** Many museums offer free days, free hours, or free admission for young people. Look at the museum's website. Rules vary by museum and change over time.
- **Check sketching rules.** Many galleries allow pencil only, and some limit sketchbook size or folding stools. Photography rules vary by gallery and by loan.
- **Check teen programs.** Some museums run programs for middle-schoolers and teens, from drop-in drawing sessions to multi-week classes. Each sets its own age rules.
- **Plan for one room.** OUT-01 Museum One-Room Sit (Chapter 7) is the whole plan: one room, one work, one sketch, one conversation. Come back next month for another room.

Smaller places count too: a university gallery, a historical society, a sculpture garden, a local art center. The best museum is often the one close enough to visit monthly.

Open collections online

Several major museums put high-quality images of public-domain works online for free. These are ideal for LOOK-03 Detail Hunt, LOOK-04 Master Study, and HIST-01 When-and-Where Cards. Each museum's own page for an object gives you the maker, date, medium, and credit line, so the source check is built in.

- **National Gallery of Art (Washington, D.C.).** The museum has made more than 60,000 images from its collection available as free downloads, and its collection data is openly licensed.³¹
- **The Metropolitan Museum of Art (New York).** The Met's Open Access program marks public-domain works in its online collection with a CC0 designation, which means you can download and use them freely.³²
- **Smarthistory.** A free art-history website run by what it calls a tiny not-for-profit, co-founded by the art historians Beth Harris and Steven Zucker, with essays and videos on works across many periods and places.⁴¹ It's useful for parents getting their bearings before a museum visit, and for 13–14-year-olds doing source checks.

A few habits make these collections work well at home:

- **Search by subject, not just by name.** “Still life,” “harbor,” “woodblock print,” “bronze.” Let the student choose from the results.
- **Zoom.** The detail is the point.
- **Copy the credit line** from the museum page onto the study (WRITE-05) and the whose-mark card (AS-02).
- **Open the museum’s page itself**, not a copy on some other site. That’s where the reliable information lives.

Your own town

Public sculpture, murals, old buildings, bridges, a church doorway, the carved lettering on a bank. HIST-05 Local Art Walk turns any town into a collection. Many towns and cities also publish public-art maps. Search your town’s name with “public art.”

Free resources, chapter by chapter

Chapter	A free place to start
1–2 Seeing and the sketchbook	Any object in the house; a library drawing book; a pocket sketchbook on a walk
3 Value, light, and form	An egg and a desk lamp; a library book on drawing light and shadow; bark and stones outside
4 Space and perspective	Your own hallway and street; a window and a dry-erase marker; old buildings downtown
5 Color and design	Fruit from the kitchen; posters on a library bulletin board; one painting in an open collection studied for color
6 Cut, print, and build	A library tutorial or how-to book on relief printing; a community studio’s open day
7 Looking and critique	Open collections; a museum’s free day; a library art book; public art in your town
8–9 Portfolio and records	A phone camera, index cards, sticky tabs, a notebook

A starter shelf

You don’t need much. Here’s a shelf that covers every chapter of this book. Buy it gradually, as chapters need it, and borrow or share where you can.

Drawing (Chapters 2–4) - A sketchbook (one the student likes; a small pocket one for outings too) - Graphite pencils in a range, roughly 2H to 6B - A kneaded eraser - A fine pen for contour and crosshatching - A ruler - Vine and compressed charcoal, for value work (subtractive charcoal is a 13–14 move) - Wet wipes for charcoal dust, since dust gets wiped, never blown

Color and design (Chapter 5) - Watercolor, gouache, or acrylic, with the AP seal: a warm and a cool of each primary, plus white - A few brushes, a water jar, a palette or plate - Bristol or mixed-media paper - Card for a viewfinder

Print and build (Chapter 6) - A soft carving block (the first block for 11–12) - Beginner gouges (V and U) - A bench hook - A brayer and water-based block ink - Air-dry clay, a rolling pin, and a scoring tool - Soft craft wire and small pliers - Scissors and a rotary safety cutter - At 13–14, if your family chooses: a self-healing cutting mat larger than the cut, a metal safety ruler, and a craft knife, used only under the Chapter 6 protocol with an adult at the table - A cut-resistant glove for the holding hand; the federal safety guide for art materials names metal-mesh or Kevlar gloves for work with sharp tools¹¹ - A tray for counting tools in and out

Records (Chapters 8–9) - Index cards for whose-mark cards - Sticky tabs - A folder or portfolio box - A notebook for the log

Read every label

This is the one shopping habit that matters most.

- **The AP seal** from the Art and Creative Materials Institute (ACMI) is the one to look for first. ACMI says AP products are suitable for students in sixth grade or younger, and that products with its **CL** (cautionary label) seal are only for seventh grade and up, with the label read in full.¹⁰ In this book, a student in grade 6 or below uses AP materials only. From grade 7, a CL product can be used only when a project truly needs one, with the whole label read and an adult present. The projects in this book almost never need one.
- **“Conforms to ASTM D-4236”** means the product is labelled under the U.S. standard for chronic health hazards. It’s a labelling standard. It doesn’t mean “safe for children.”¹⁰
- **No solvents.** Everything in this book cleans up with water. The federal art-safety guide advises avoiding solvents and solvent-based supplies (turpentine, paint thinner, and some glues, inks, and permanent markers) for students through grade 6.¹¹ This book keeps that rule for every age. Oils and solvent cleanup belong to high school and *Art for Homeschooling*.
- **No indoor aerosols.** Skip spray fixative and spray paint indoors.
- **No home kilns.** Firing happens at a community studio.
- **Poison Control:** 1-800-222-1222 (U.S.). Keep the number on the shelf, next to the first-aid kit.

If a product has no seal and you can’t find it in ACMI’s listings, leave it for another day.

Published programs, described by fit

Here are some programs families commonly meet at this age. They’re described in each publisher’s own terms, in no particular order, with no prices (prices change, so check the publisher’s site). Nothing here is an endorsement. Always check the publisher’s current description before you buy.

Artistic Pursuits. The publisher’s website organizes its books by grade band, including “7-8th | Middle School,” “Classic- 6 - 8th,” and a sculpture title for grades 6 to 12.⁴² The publisher describes

an emphasis on original work from observation. *Fits*: families who want looking and original work at the center, with moderate parent preparation. *Asks of you*: gathering materials and sitting with the lessons. *Pairs with this book*: naturally. The banks here can extend any lesson.

How Great Thou Art. The publisher lists intermediate drawing programs as “Ages 12 & Up,” covering, in its words, “line, shading, shadows, values, composition, still lifes, chiaroscuro, foreshortening, negative space, nature, animal studies, human anatomy, portraits and perspective.” A second volume, also “Ages 12 & Up,” adds pen and ink, perspective, nature studies, and graphics. The publisher’s younger course, *I Can Do All Things*, is listed as “Ages 8 thru 11.”⁴³ The program is explicitly Christian. *Fits*: families who want directed, step-by-step lessons within a Christian framework, with lower parent preparation. *Pairs with this book*: add the ten-minute page from life and the monthly check, so observation gets its share.

Atelier (Arts Attack). A video-based program. The publisher describes eight levels for ages 4 to 16, with the video doing much of the teaching.⁴⁴ *Fits*: families who want low parent preparation, or a co-op that wants a shared format. *Asks of you*: materials, a screen, and pausing the video so the student can work. *Pairs with this book*: use the talk box after the video lesson, so the student describes before they judge. (This program shouldn’t be confused with the classical “atelier” drawing tradition taught in person.)

Library how-to books. Drawing, perspective, and printmaking guides from many publishers, borrowed free. *Fits*: any budget, any parent. *Asks of you*: choosing, since you’re the curator. *Pairs with this book*: well. Use a library how-to for technique and this book for the Art Hour shape, critique, and records.

A high-school textbook, for the ready student. *Discovering Drawing* (Davis Publications) is a high-school studio drawing textbook.⁴⁵ *Fits*: a 13–14-year-old who wants a school-style drawing year and is heading toward high school. For high-school course planning, see *Art for Homeschooling*.

Fit at a glance

This is not a ranking. Read across for the fit.

If you want...	Consider...
No cost at all	Library, museum, open collections, and this book’s banks
Observation and original work, moderate prep	Artistic Pursuits, or library books plus this book
Step-by-step, Christian, lower prep	How Great Thou Art
Video does more of the teaching; co-op friendly	Atelier (Arts Attack)
A school-style drawing text for an older student	<i>Discovering Drawing</i> , with <i>Art for Homeschooling</i> for high-school planning
Tools you don’t have (presses, kilns, wheels)	A community studio or class (below)

Combining honestly

Combining is fine. Library books plus a museum sit plus this book is a complete year. A published program plus a community print class plus the monthly check is too. Whatever you combine, the record still says **Art**, and the student's marks are still the student's. Every portfolio piece gets its whose-mark card, whichever program it came from.

When a program's lessons come with a finished sample to copy, treat the result like a master study: it's the student's, as a study, with a credit line. Keep at least one observational page a week alongside it.

When your student needs a different door

Some students need the materials adjusted. You don't need a diagnosis to make these changes, and if your student works with therapists or specialists, they're good people to ask.

- **Fine-motor difficulty or tiring hands.** Try thicker pencils and charcoal sticks, larger paper taped or clamped to the table, shorter Make beats, and soft block instead of lino. Value can be built with broad charcoal instead of fine hatching.
- **Color-vision differences.** Label the paint tubes and lean on value (Chapter 3). A painting built on value reads well to every viewer. Never treat naming colors as a skill to test.
- **Attention.** Keep the five beats short and predictable, use a visible timer, work with one object at a time, and choose out-of-home try-its that involve moving around.
- **Anxiety about being judged.** A private sketchbook, describe-only rules, CRP with the right to decline opinions, and no showing unless the student chooses it.
- **An advanced student.** Longer observational pieces, a longer master study, a community class, and an earlier look at the high-school material in *Art for Homeschooling*. Being advanced is no reason to skip the seeing, though. Advanced students gain as much from the monthly check as anyone.

Resources for you

The parent at the table deserves resources too. Many parents of 11- to 14-year-olds were told around this same age that they "couldn't draw," and some still believe it. A few things help:

- **Borrow a drawing book for yourself** and do the ten-minute page alongside your student a few times a week. Your honest, ugly page, drawn beside theirs, is one of the best lessons in this book.
- **Take a docent tour** at a museum, on your own or with your student. Docents are good at asking questions, and you'll pick up moves for the talk box.
- **Take a class yourself.** A single evening drawing class at a community center can change how you see your student's work.
- **Read the student sections of this book.** They're short, and they're a quick way to review each chapter's main idea.

Community: classes, studios, and other people

Sooner or later, your student will want something you can't give at the kitchen table: a printing press, a kiln, a wheel, a figure-drawing session, or just other people making art in the same room. That's a good sign.

Places to look:

- **Community art centers and open studios.** Presses, kilns, and wheels belong here, under instructors, with ventilation and firing done properly. OUT-06 Community Class or Open Studio (Chapter 6) covers the first visit.
- **Museum teen programs.** Drawing in the galleries, workshops, and sometimes longer courses.
- **Library workshops.** Often free. Check the calendar.
- **Homeschool co-ops.** A co-op art class adds critique partners. If you help run one, bring the CRP card from Chapter 7.
- **Youth organizations,** such as a local 4-H club, which may offer art projects. Ask your county office what's available near you.
- **A local artist.** Some working artists teach small groups or take a young apprentice-helper for an afternoon. Ask at a gallery or art center.

Every venue sets its own age rules and safety rules. Check them before you sign up, and ask whether a parent must stay. For a nervous student, going together and watching first is a perfectly good start.

AI tools: a pointer and a dated table

The Art Hour's AI box has the full rules, and they don't change here: a generated image is not the student's mark, any AI use goes on the whose-mark card, and at 11–12 you hold the account while the student sits beside you.

For reference, here is what the main services' own terms said about age when this book was written. **Terms change often, so check the current terms before you set up anything.**

Service	Minimum age in its terms	Teens	Notes for parents
ChatGPT (OpenAI)	13	Under 18 needs a parent's or guardian's permission	Parental controls can link accounts, remove image generation, and opt a linked teen out of model training ¹⁵
Grok (SpaceXAI)	13	13–17 need a parent's permission, and the parent agrees to the terms	Terms grant the company a broad license to content you submit ¹⁶

Service	Minimum age in its terms	Teens	Notes for parents
Gemini (Google)	13 to manage your own Google Account (U.S.)	Under 13 only if a parent turns Gemini on through Family Link	Some features have age requirements ¹⁷
Midjourney	13	A parent agrees for younger teens and is responsible for their activity	An image generator, not a tool for the student in this book ¹⁸
Claude (Anthropic)	18	Not permitted	Adults only; not for students ¹⁹

The COPPA amendments' compliance date (22 April 2026) has passed. COPPA is the federal rule that protects children under 13 online, and it's the reason 11- and 12-year-olds don't get their own accounts in this book.¹⁴

If you run your own assistant, such as a self-hosted agent on your computer or a hosted bot, treat it as *your* tool. It isn't the student's. A shared hosted workspace isn't a privacy boundary, so anything uploaded to it may be visible across that workspace. One hosted service's own documentation says plainly not to rely on separate bots as a security boundary.²⁵ Keep the student's photos cropped to the paper, with no faces, whatever tool you use.

Before you buy anything

Five questions:

1. Did we use the library this month?
2. Have we looked at one of the free open collections?
3. Does this resource have the student looking at real things, or only copying steps? (If only steps, what will we add?)
4. Do the materials carry the right label for my student's grade?
5. Will the record still say **Art**?

If the answers are yes, yes, a real plan, yes, and yes, go ahead and buy with confidence. If not, the library is open tomorrow.

A Note on Sources

Studies, standards, and product terms named in the chapters are listed in Notes, in one series at the back. That is where the full citations live, so the teaching pages can keep a teaching voice. When the same source comes up in several chapters, it has one note, and every mark that cites it carries that note's number.

Some questions stay open, and the book leaves them open rather than filling them. No national table of art minutes for homeschooled middle schoolers was found, so the dose suggestions are practice suggestions. The tool-age bands for carving tools and craft knives are house rules; no federal source sets them. Lowenfeld's stage ages vary by edition, and the book uses them as a map, not a diagnosis. A few studies (Cohen and Bennett's, the *Studio Thinking* research, and the classroom wait-time work) come from adults, high schools, or elementary science classrooms, and are used for what they show about the method, not as findings about eleven- to fourteen-year-olds.

Platform ages, program descriptions, and product terms are taken from the companies' own pages and change often; the dates in each note say when they were read. Where a page could only be reached through a search result or an archived copy, the note says so. Access date for web sources: 27 September 2026. Nothing here is legal advice; state rules are summarized from the texts named in Chapter 9's notes.

Notes

1. Dale J. Cohen and Susan Bennett, “Why Can’t Most People Draw What They See?” *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance* 23, no. 3 (1997): 609–621. Adult participants drawing from photographs; misperception of the object was the major source of drawing error, with motor coordination a very minimal source. Adult sample, used here as a mechanism only, not as a study of 11- to 14-year-olds. Author PDF: <https://people.uncw.edu/cohend/research/papers/Cohen%20and%20Bennett%2097.pdf> (accessed 27 September 2026).
2. National Center for Education Statistics, *Homeschooling in the United States: 2016* (NCES 2020-001), Table 9 (Parent and Family Involvement in Education Survey, 2016). Share of home-schooled students taught Art during home instruction that year: 53 percent overall; 78 percent in K–2; 63 percent in grades 3–5; 50 percent in grades 6–8; 29 percent in grades 9–12. The table does not give reasons. <https://nces.ed.gov/pubsearch/pubsinfo.asp?pubid=2020001> (accessed 27 September 2026).
3. Ellen Winner and Lois Hetland, *The Arts and Academic Improvement: What the Evidence Shows* (Reviewing Education and the Arts Project, Harvard Project Zero; executive summary, 2000). A review of 188 reports, 275 effect sizes, and 10 meta-analyses; no reliable causal link was found between arts-rich education and verbal or mathematics achievement. <https://pz.harvard.edu/sites/default/files/REAP%20Executive%20Summary.pdf> (accessed 27 September 2026).
4. Leah H. Somerville, “Special Issue on the Teenage Brain: Sensitivity to Social Evaluation,” *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 22, no. 2 (2013). A review describing heightened adolescent sensitivity to peer and social evaluation, including a lab finding that being watched by a peer produced more self-reported embarrassment in adolescents than in children or adults. Somerville notes that the older “imaginary audience” idea has been challenged. Not a study of art critique or art assessment; used here as the reason for consent before work is shown. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3992953/> (accessed 27 September 2026).
5. Lois Hetland, Ellen Winner, Shirley Veenema, and Kimberly M. Sheridan, *Studio Thinking 2: The Real Benefits of Visual Arts Education*, 2nd ed. (New York: Teachers College Press, 2013), Figure 1.2, “Eight Studio Habits of Mind.” Habits drawn on in this book: Develop Craft, where Technique includes “learning artistic conventions (e.g., perspective, color mixing)” and Studio Practice is “learning to care for tools, materials, and space”; Observe, “learning to attend to visual contexts more closely than ordinary ‘looking’ requires”; and Understand Art Worlds (domain and com-

munities). Developed from research in two arts-intensive high schools; used here as vocabulary, not as evidence of transfer or a trial result. Figure PDF via <https://www.studiothinking.org/the-framework.html> (accessed 27 September 2026).

6. Visual Thinking Strategies, *Resources for Families* (March 2020). The three questions — “What’s going on in this picture?”, “What do you see that makes you say...?”, and “What more can you find?” — and the guidance to paraphrase each comment “without praising or correcting.” VTS began in museum and classroom programs; the family materials adapt it for home. <https://vtshome.org/> (accessed 27 September 2026).

7. Mary Budd Rowe, “Wait-Time and Rewards as Instructional Variables” (paper, National Association for Research in Science Teaching, 1972), ERIC ED061103, <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED061103>; Robert J. Stahl, “Using ‘Think-Time’ and ‘Wait-Time’ Skillfully in the Classroom,” ERIC Digest ED370885 (1994), <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED370885>. Classroom-origin research (Rowe’s in elementary science). The pause is borrowed here as a questioning habit, not as art-education evidence. Accessed 27 September 2026.

8. Liz Lerman, Critical Response Process (devised 1990). Four steps: Statements of Meaning; Artist as Questioner; Neutral Questions; Permissioned Opinions, in which the responder asks permission to give an opinion and the artist has the option to say no. <https://lizlerman.com/critical-response-process/> (accessed 27 September 2026).

9. Edmund Burke Feldman’s four-step approach to art criticism (description, analysis, interpretation, judgment), as widely taught and summarized in teaching materials, for example a Grand Valley State University teaching handout, <https://www2.gvsu.edu/hipshean/resources/Feldman's%20Model%20Crit.pdf> (accessed 27 September 2026). Feldman set the method out in his textbooks, including *Varieties of Visual Experience*. This book cites no particular edition or year.

10. The Art and Creative Materials Institute (ACMI), “Classroom Art Materials Safety,” <https://www.acmiart.org/classroom-art-materials-safety>, and “Materials Safety,” <https://www.acmiart.org/material-safety> (accessed 27 September 2026). AP Seal products are for students in sixth grade or younger; CL Seal products are for seventh grade or older and should never be given to children in sixth grade or younger; CL product labels should be read in full before opening. “Conforms to ASTM D-4236” is a labelling standard for chronic hazards, not a “safe for kids” stamp.

11. U.S. Consumer Product Safety Commission, *Art and Craft Safety Guide* (Pub. 5015), <https://www.cpsc.gov/s3fs-public/5015.pdf> (re-read 27 September 2026). For children up to 12 years of age (pre-kindergarten through grade 6): products with cautionary labels should not be used; “avoid solvents and solvent-based supplies” (turpentine, paint thinner, shellac, toluene, and some glues, inks, and permanent markers); “avoid materials in self-pressurized containers”; avoid “processes that produce airborne dusts.” The guide describes ASTM D-4236 as the standard for labelling art materials for chronic hazards. On relief printing: “Avoid laceration injuries by cutting away from the body, using bench hooks while carving, and storing tools with guards in place”; “Use water and non-toxic inks, water-soluble glues”; “Use low temperatures to heat linoleum. Avoid open flame.” It also advises “metal-mesh or Kevlar gloves when using sharp tools or knives,” and lists Poison Control, 1-800-222-1222. The guide sets no age for craft knives or carving tools. This book extends the solvent, aerosol, and dust rules to both of its bands and uses water-based paints only.

12. National Society for Education in Art and Design (NSEAD, UK), “Cutting Tools,” health and safety guidance (2018), <https://www.nsead.org/resources/health-safety/h-s-machines-equipment-tools-and-processes/h-s-cutting-tools/> (accessed 27 September 2026). Bench hooks or clamps give a stable working surface; direct the cut away from the body and hands; keep tools sharp because “bluntness causes the user to exert excessive pressure”; easier-cutting vinyl or polymer lino is available; use a cutting mat “larger than the area to be cut”; consider “straightedge safety cutting rulers,” with rotary safety cutters as an alternative; “The hand holding the paper/card must always be positioned behind the cutting blade and direction of cut”; teachers should carefully oversee the distribution and collection of blades so none leave the room; risk assessments “should consider age and ability.” UK school context. Neither this guidance nor CPSC gives an age for craft knives; the book’s 13–14 rule, and the choice to make knives optional, are practice rules.

13. Laura Anderson, “Art Reproductions: Lino Block Printing,” Topeka & Shawnee County Public Library (2024), <https://tscpl.org/articles/art-reproductions-lino-block-printing> (accessed 27 September 2026). A practitioner tutorial from a public library, not a safety standard: bench hook strongly suggested; always carve away from yourself; start with light cuts; warm stiff lino with a hair dryer.

14. Federal Trade Commission, Children’s Online Privacy Protection Rule, final rule amendments, 90 Fed. Reg. 16918 (22 April 2025); effective 23 June 2025, with a general compliance date of 22 April 2026. COPPA governs services collecting personal information from children under 13. <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2025/04/22/2025-05904/childrens-online-privacy-protection-rule> (accessed 27 September 2026).

15. OpenAI, Terms of Use (effective 1 January 2026), <https://openai.com/policies/terms-of-use/>: content may be used to provide, maintain, develop, and improve services, with an opt-out available. OpenAI, “Introducing Parental Controls” (29 September 2025, updated 13 July 2026), <https://openai.com/index/introducing-parental-controls/>: parental controls can opt a linked teen out of model training. Both (accessed 27 September 2026). Terms change; read the current versions before signing up or uploading.

16. SpaceXAI (xAI), Terms of Service – Consumer (updated 11 September 2026), <https://x.ai/legal/terms-of-service> (accessed 27 September 2026). The terms grant the company an irrevocable, perpetual, transferable, sublicensable, royalty-free, worldwide right to use, copy, store, and modify submitted content.

17. Google For Families Help, “Guide your child’s Gemini Apps experience,” <https://support.google.com/families/> (a parent must enable access before a child under 13 can use Gemini Apps with a supervised account, through Family Link; some features have age requirements), and Google Account Help, “Age requirements on Google Accounts,” <https://support.google.com/accounts/answer/1350409> (13 is the minimum age to manage your own Google Account in countries not listed, including the U.S.). Both read live on 27 September 2026.

18. Midjourney, Terms of Service (version effective 27 May 2026), section 2, “Age Requirements,” <https://docs.midjourney.com/hc/en-us/articles/32083055291277-Terms-of-Service>: users must be at least 13 and meet the local minimum age of digital consent; where a teen cannot consent to the terms, a parent or guardian agrees on their behalf and is responsible for the teen’s activity. Read live on 27 September 2026.

19. Anthropic, Claude Help Center, “Age assurance on Claude” (18 May 2026), <https://support.claude.com/en/article/age-assurance-on-claude>: the consumer product is only available to people over 18. Read live on 27 September 2026.
20. William H. Walters and Esther Isabelle Wilder, “Fabrication and Errors in the Bibliographic Citations Generated by ChatGPT,” *Scientific Reports* 13 (2023): 14045. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-023-41032-5>.
21. Weixin Liang et al., “GPT Detectors Are Biased Against Non-Native English Writers,” *Patterns* 4, no. 7 (2023); arXiv:2304.02819, <https://arxiv.org/abs/2304.02819>. Detectors frequently misclassified human-written essays by non-native English writers as machine-written. This study tested text detectors; it is cited for the general point that detectors are not a fair basis for grading. The book’s honesty tool is the whose-mark card and the student’s process pages, not a detector.
22. U.S. Copyright Office, *Copyright and Artificial Intelligence, Part 2: Copyrightability* (29 January 2025), summarized in NewsNet Issue 1060: generated outputs are protectable only where a human author has determined sufficient expressive elements, “but not the mere provision of prompts.” <https://copyright.gov/newsnet/2025/1060.html> (accessed 27 September 2026). Cited as an echo of the book’s teaching reason, not as legal advice.
23. College Board, AP Central, “Guidance for Artificial Intelligence Tools and Other Services — AP Art and Design Policy,” <https://apcentral.collegeboard.org/exam-administration-ordering-scores/administering-exams/exam-policies/artificial-intelligence-tools> (accessed 27 September 2026). Finished pieces must be the student’s own work; generative AI may be used only during research, ideation, practice, experimentation, and revision; using generative AI tools to create final submitted artwork is prohibited; all AI use must be disclosed. Generative features such as generative fill and background replacement are prohibited; non-generative edits such as exposure, contrast, and cropping are allowed. AP is a high-school program and exam; it appears here only as a comparison.
24. Hamsa Bastani, Osbert Bastani, Alp Sungu, Haosen Ge, Özge Kabakçı, and Rei Mariman, “Generative AI without Guardrails Can Harm Learning: Evidence from High School Mathematics,” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122, no. 26 (2025): e2422633122. About 1,000 Turkish high-school mathematics students. High-school math; off-age and off-subject for this book. The authors note that creative subjects lack math’s objective scoring. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2422633122>.
25. xAI, Grok Bot FAQ, <https://docs.x.ai/grok-bot/faq> (accessed 27 September 2026): every Bot on an account uses one persistent cloud computer and shares its files, browser sessions, and logins, and the FAQ advises, “Do not use separate Bots as a security boundary.” The company’s own documentation; no education product was listed. An adult tool in this book.
26. Nous Research, Hermes Agent homepage (accessed 27 September 2026): a self-hosted, open-source agent with messaging, browser, and image-generation features, described in the maker’s own words. An adult tool in this book.
27. New York Codes, Rules and Regulations, title 8, § 100.10 (Home instruction), <https://www.law.cornell.edu/regulations/new-york/8-NYCRR-100.10>. For grades 7–8, required instruction includes “art (one-half unit)”; “The units required herein are cumulative requirements for both grades seven and eight”; “a unit means

6,480 minutes of instruction per school year.” Text read 27 September 2026. Not legal advice; read the current regulation.

28. Viktor Lowenfeld, *Creative and Mental Growth*, 4th ed. (1964), and later editions with W. Lambert Brittain. The fourth edition places the Pseudo-Naturalistic Stage (Stage of Reasoning) at about eleven to thirteen, followed by the Period of Decision; many later summaries give twelve to fourteen. Stage ages vary by edition. The book uses the stages as a map of typical change, not as a diagnosis, and does not use Lowenfeld’s older visual/haptic distinction, which later editions softened. Archive scan: <https://archive.org/details/creativementalgr00> (located 27 September 2026).

29. Ellena Sempeles and Jiashan Cui, *Parent and Family Involvement in Education: 2023, First Look* (NCES 2024-113; National Center for Education Statistics, September 2024), <https://nces.ed.gov/pubsearch/pubsinfo.asp?pubid=2024113> (accessed 27 September 2026). Table A-5, among students enrolled or homeschooled in kindergarten through grade 12 or equivalent, percentage whose parents reported the activity in the past month, 2022–23 — homeschooled students: “Visited a library,” 53 percent; “Visited an art gallery, a museum, or a historical site,” 43 percent (all students: 29 and 23 percent). Table A-6: among students aged 5 through 17 with a grade equivalent of kindergarten through grade 12, 3.4 percent were homeschooled (about 1,765,000), and 3.0 percent in 6th–8th grade. The 5.2 percent figure in the same table is “instruction at home,” homeschooled or in full-time virtual education, and is not the homeschool rate.

30. Richard A. Salome, “The Effects of Perceptual Training upon the Two-Dimensional Drawings of Children,” *Studies in Art Education* (1965). Training that directed children’s attention to contours and points of high visual information improved their representational drawings, with clearer gains at fifth grade than at younger ages. Cited for direction only; the statistics were not re-audited for this book. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00393541.1965.11650140>.

31. National Gallery of Art, “Free Images and Open Access,” <https://www.nga.gov/artworks/free-images-and-open-access> (accessed 27 September 2026): more than 60,000 images from the collection available as free downloads, with collection data under CC0. Check each image’s rights line before use, and record the credit line on the study.

32. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Open Access, <https://github.com/metmuseum/openaccess> (accessed 27 September 2026): public-domain works are released under Creative Commons Zero (CC0) and marked with the CC0 icon on the collection site. This book gives no image count.

33. Michael C. Corballis, “Left Brain, Right Brain: Facts and Fantasies,” *PLOS Biology* (2014). A review explaining why popular left-brain/right-brain accounts of creativity are not supported. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pbio.1001767>.

34. Texas Essential Knowledge and Skills for Fine Arts, 19 Tex. Admin. Code § 117.202, Art, Middle School 1 (adopted 2013; effective 28 July 2013, 38 TexReg 4575), (c)(1)(B)–(C): the elements of art, “including line, shape, color, texture, form, space, and value,” and the principles of design, “including emphasis, repetition/pattern, movement/rhythm, contrast/variety, balance, proportion, and unity.” <https://www.law.cornell.edu/regulations/texas/19-Tex-Admin-Code-SS-117-202> (accessed 27 September 2026). A Texas state standard, not a national one.

35. No age threshold for craft knives or carving tools was found in CPSC Pub. 5015 when it was

re-read on 27 September 2026. The 11–12 / ready 12 / 13–14 tool bands in this book are house practice rules built from the sourced CPSC, NSEAD, and library protocols cited in this chapter, not legal or CPSC ages.

36. The no-home-kiln rule, the low-temperature glue gun with an adult at 13–14, and eye protection when snipping wire are this book’s practice suggestions, not rules taken from a published standard.

37. National Core Arts Standards, Visual Arts, grade 8, VA:Cr2.2.8a (National Coalition for Core Arts Standards, 2014), paraphrased here; checked on 27 September 2026 against the Smithsonian Learning Lab standard page, <https://learninglab.si.edu/standards/8.VA:Cr2.2-demonstrate-awareness/4346>, and NCCAS, *Visual Arts at a Glance*, <https://www.nationalartsstandards.org/>. The standards are voluntary: a school map, not a homeschool requirement.

38. National Core Arts Standards, Visual Arts (National Coalition for Core Arts Standards, 2014), Presenting, anchor standard 4 (select, analyze, and interpret artistic work for presentation), VA:Pr4.1.8a, paraphrased: develop and apply criteria for evaluating a collection of artwork for presentation. At grades 6 and 7 the Pr4.1 standards concern preserving and presenting work; the word portfolio appears at kindergarten and high-school levels, not grades 6–8. NCCAS, *Visual Arts at a Glance*, <https://www.nationalartsstandards.org/> (accessed 27 September 2026). The standards are voluntary: a school map, not a homeschool requirement.

39. 24 P.S. § 13-1327.1 (Pennsylvania home education program), <https://www.legis.state.pa.us/cfdocs/legis/LI/con> Art is named among elementary and secondary courses, and the portfolio provision includes samples of creative materials. Text read 27 September 2026. Not legal advice.

40. Texas Education Agency, “Home Schooling,” <https://tea.texas.gov/families-and-students/finding-school-your-child/home-schooling>; North Carolina Division of Non-Public Education, “Home School Requirements & Recommendations,” <https://www.doa.nc.gov/divisions/non-public-education/home-schools/requirements-recommendations>; Va. Code § 22.1-254.1, <https://law.lis.virginia.gov/vacode/title22.1/chapter14/section22.1-254.1/>. The texts were read and saved on 24 September 2026 for the sibling title *Art for Little Thinkers*, and art is not named as a required subject in any of them. Re-check the current texts before relying on this. Not legal advice.

41. Smarthistory, “About,” <https://smarthistory.org/about/> (“Smarthistory is a tiny not-for-profit”; resources free and ad-free), read on 27 September 2026 through the Internet Archive’s copy because the live site blocks automated access; Smarthistory, “Board of Trustees and Board of Advisors,” <https://smarthistory.org/our-board/> (Beth Harris and Steven Zucker, co-founders), from a search result the same day. Check the current site.

42. Artistic Pursuits, <https://artisticpursuits.com/>. Site navigation as seen on 27 September 2026 (the publisher’s own descriptions). The emphasis on original work from observation comes from the publisher’s pages as read for the sibling title on 31 August 2026.

43. How Great Thou Art Publications, <https://www.howgreatthouart.com/>. Publisher’s homepage as seen on 27 September 2026; the age labels and topic list are quoted from it. Prices omitted.

44. Atelier / Arts Attack, <https://homeschoolart.com/curriculum>. The publisher’s description (video-based; eight levels; ages 4–16), as read for the sibling title *Art for Homeschooling* on 31

August 2026. Check the current page.

45. Sallye Mahan-Cox, *Discovering Drawing*, 3rd ed. (Davis Publications), <https://catalog.davisart.com/Products/3/discovering-drawing-student-book-3rd-ed.aspx>. Publisher's catalog listing as a high-school studio textbook, as read for the sibling title on 31 August 2026.